

Presidency's Attack On Me Exposes Tinubu To Public Scrutiny – Atiku

● Your Campaign Relies On Divisive Rhetoric, Regional Posturing, Says Presidency

SAMUEL OGIDAN;
INNOCENT OWEH
ABUJA

Former Vice President and African Democratic Congress (ADC) presidential candidate, Atiku

Abubakar, has said the Presidency's attempt to invoke China while attacking him has backfired, arguing that it has instead exposed President Bola Tinubu to greater public scrutiny.

Atiku, in a statement on Saturday,

in Abuja, by his Senior Special Assistant on Public Communication, Phrank Shaibu, described the Presidency's argument as a "monumental own goal," saying it was ironic that government officials introduced China into the debate without con-

sidering the country's strict laws on drug-related offences.

According to him, the spokesman's comparison inadvertently highlighted that China imposes the death penalty for the most serious drug trafficking offences, thereby

inviting Nigerians to assess the same standard against the President.

Atiku maintained that he has never been indicted or convicted by

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Senate's Quiet Battle With Tinubu's Executive

SOLA SHITTU,
ABUJA

The atmosphere inside Nigeria's Senate Chamber on Thursday was unlike the familiar scenes that have defined much of the 10th National Assembly.

There was no debate over a presidential loan request. No consideration of a ministerial nominee. No discussion on another appropriation bill.

Instead, senators turned their attention to what many described as an emerging constitutional crisis—one that, if left unchecked, could fundamentally alter the delicate balance of power between the Executive and the Legislature.

Leading the charge was the Chairman of the Senate Committee on Finance, Senator Sani Musa, who tabled a motion accusing several Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs) and Government-Owned Enterprises (GOEs) of persistently ignoring invitations issued by Senate committees.

To Musa, the issue was no longer about mere administrative noncha-

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Godswill Akpabio, Senate President



Anxiety Rises Over August 15 Osun Governorship Election

● Stakeholders Task Security Agencies, INEC, Party Stalwarts On Peaceful Poll

EJIKEME OMENAZU
LAGOS

Chief Emeka Charles Kalu, a seasoned politician and Labour Party chieftain, has raised the alarm over reported electoral violence and tension in Osun State ahead of the August 15, 2026, off-season governorship election, saying that the development is deeply disturbing.

Kalu, an aspirant for the

Abia North Senate seat, who was speaking with Sunday Independent, said that the ongoing political violence, including thuggery, killings and abductions represent a dangerous assault on democracy and the rule of law.

It would be recalled that there have been rising cases of political killings, thug attacks and destruction of campaign materials, bill boards

and party flags and offices of opponents by sponsored thugs.

This is even as the Governor Ademola Adeleke, who is seeking a return ticket under the Accord Party, has accused the state Commissioner of Police, Ibrahim Gotan, and his men of looking the other way while his supporters are being attacked and killed by political thugs.

He has, therefore, called on

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Senate's Quiet Battle With Tinubu's Executive

lance. It was about the authority of Parliament itself.

Presenting the motion, the Niger East senator reminded his colleagues that Sections 88 and 89 of the 1999 Constitution empower the National Assembly to investigate the conduct of public institutions, expose corruption, inefficiency and waste, and ensure accountability in the management of public funds.

He noted that the Senate Committee on Finance routinely scrutinises the financial operations of government agencies, including their internally generated revenue, statutory remittances to the Consolidated Revenue Fund, operating surpluses and compliance with the Fiscal Responsibility Act and other financial regulations.

Yet, despite repeated invitations, several agencies had simply refused to appear.

According to Musa, "This persistent non-compliance constitutes a direct affront to the constitutional authority of the Senate. It undermines legislative oversight, weakens transparency and accountability in the management of public resources and erodes the doctrine of checks and balances."

He warned that if the trend was allowed to continue, it could encourage institutional impunity, frustrate the oversight responsibilities of the National Assembly, and weaken public confidence in democratic governance.

OBLIGATION TO HONOUR LEGISLATIVE SUMMONS

His motion sought far-reaching resolutions.

Among them were directives compelling all MDAs and government-owned enterprises to honour Senate invitations, a call on the Secretary to the Government of the Federation, the Head of the Civil Service of the Federation and supervising ministers to ensure compliance, and a warning that agencies that deliberately ignore legislative summons could face sanctions under the Constitution, the Legislative Houses (Powers and Privileges) Act and the Senate Standing Orders.

But it was the debate that followed that revealed the depth of concern within the Red Chamber. First to lend his voice was Senator Mohammed Tahir Monguno, representing Borno North.

Describing the motion as "long overdue", Monguno argued that the National Assembly must jealously guard its constitutional independence if Nigeria's democracy is to remain healthy.

"The presidential system of government operates around the philosophical cornerstone of separation of powers between the Executive, the Legislature and the Judiciary," he said.

He stressed that oversight was not a privilege granted by the Executive but a constitutional obligation imposed on the Legislature.

"So, when the Executive displays executive arrogance or executive rascality," Monguno declared, "Parliament should stand up and jealously guard its constitutional powers."

He cautioned that while co-operation between both arms of government was desirable in delivering dividends of democracy, such cooperation must never come at the expense of legislative independence.

His intervention echoed concerns that have quietly circulated within some Senate committees—that certain agency heads now treat parliamentary invitations as optional rather than binding constitutional obligations.

If Monguno defended the institution, Senator Abdul Ahmed Ningi challenged it to defend itself.

The Bauchi Central senator, one of the longest-serving legislators in the National Assembly, expressed disappointment that such a motion had become necessary under President Bola Ahmed Tinubu's administration.

Interestingly, Ningi did not immediately blame the President.

Instead, he suggested that the President might not even be aware that some heads of agencies were routinely ignoring the National Assembly.

"I know very well that President Bola Ahmed Tinubu had a fantastic relationship with the

Legislature between 1999 and 2007," he said, adding that the current situation may have developed without the President's knowledge.

Then came perhaps the most powerful line of the day's debate.

"Without oversight," Ningi declared, "there is no Legislature."

"This Parliament is not a department of the Executive. Legislators are elected by the people just like every other elected public officer. We have constitutional responsibilities that must be respected."

READINESS TO WIELD THE BIG STICK

Rather than stopping at criticism, Ningi proposed a graduated response.

He urged Senate committees to issue final warnings to defaulting agencies. If they still refused to appear, the matter should be formally reported to President Tinubu.

Should the defiance continue, he argued, the National Assembly should consider one of its most potent constitutional powers—refusing to appropriate funds for agencies that consistently undermine legislative oversight.

He also turned the searchlight inward.

"We must remain senators," he said. "We must not go begging. We must not go pleading. We must not allow ourselves to be induced. Oversight is our con-

stitutional duty."

His remarks drew attention to another dimension of the debate—the need for legislators themselves to protect the independence and integrity of Parliament.

By the time the motion was unanimously adopted, the Senate had sent one of its strongest institutional messages since the inauguration of the 10th National Assembly.

Yet outside the walls of the National Assembly, another narrative has continued to dominate public discourse.

For many Nigerians, this is the same Senate that has repeatedly been accused of acting as a "rubber stamp" for the Executive by approving major presidential requests with little visible resistance.

That contradiction raises a question that goes beyond Thursday's debate.

Can a Parliament accused of being too close to the Executive genuinely reclaim its constitutional role as the nation's foremost watchdog—or has the battle for legislative independence only just begun?

The question, therefore, is whether Thursday's dramatic show of defiance by senators marks a genuine turning point or simply another moment of legislative rhetoric.

The "rubber stamp" label did not emerge in a vacuum. Since the inauguration of the 10th National Assembly in June 2023, the Senate has approved several high-profile requests from President Bola Ahmed Tinubu with remarkable speed. Annual budgets, supplementary appropriations, external borrowing plans, tax reform proposals and presidential appointments have all passed through the Red Chamber with minimal delays, reinforcing the perception among critics that the legislature has become overly accommodating of the Executive.

That perception has been amplified by opposition parties, civil society organisations and constitutional scholars who argue that legislative independence is measured not by the number of motions adopted on the floor but by the willingness of Parliament to subject executive proposals to rigorous scrutiny before granting approval.

Supporters of the Senate, however, reject that characterisation. They argue that disagreement should not be mistaken for effectiveness, just as cooperation should not be interpreted as submission. According to them,

unnecessary confrontation between the Executive and Legislature has, in the past, slowed governance and delayed the implementation of critical national programmes.

Thursday's debate nevertheless exposed an uncomfortable reality. If ministries, departments and agencies now feel sufficiently confident to ignore invitations from Senate committees, it raises questions about whether legislative oversight is gradually losing its practical force despite the constitutional powers available to Parliament.

That concern was at the heart of Senator Abdul Ahmed Ningi's intervention when he reminded his colleagues that, "Without oversight, there is no Legislature." His warning was more than a defence of parliamentary privilege. It was a reminder that oversight remains one of the principal mechanisms through which Nigerians hold the Executive accountable for the management of public resources.

WATCHING THE DAYS AHEAD

The Senate's resolution directing all MDAs and government-owned enterprises to honour committee invitations—and warning of possible sanctions against persistent defaulters—will now face its greatest test. The true measure of the chamber's resolve will not be the strength of its resolutions but its willingness to enforce them where necessary.

For many political observers, this may well become a defining moment for the 10th Senate. If the leadership follows through by compelling compliance and imposing sanctions where appropriate, it could begin to reshape the narrative that has followed the National Assembly since its inauguration. If, however, the warnings fade without concrete action, the "rubber stamp" accusation will almost certainly gain renewed traction.

Ultimately, this is about more than the reputation of the Senate. It is about preserving the constitutional equilibrium between the Executive and the Legislature. Democracy functions best when each arm of government respects the powers of the other while remaining accountable to the Nigerian people.

Whether the Senate emerges from this confrontation as a rising watchdog or remains burdened by the perception of being a rubber stamp will depend not on Thursday's passionate speeches, but on what happens after the applause in the Red Chamber has faded.



President Bola Ahmed Tinubu receives (right), receiving Yousef Mohammed Albalawi, Kingdom of Saudi Arabia Ambassador to Nigeria, at the Presidential Villa, Abuja, on Friday.

ITODE AKARI,
PORT HARCOURT

The Niger Delta Development Commission (NDDC) has reaffirmed its commitment to advancing gender inclusion and strengthening the economic empowerment of women across the Niger Delta as it celebrated the 2026 International Women's Day in the region.

The Commission made the pledge during the International Women's Day event held in Yenagoa, Bayelsa State, where the Director of Culture and Women Affairs, Mrs. Ahunna

NDDC Marks International Women's Day, Renews Commitment To Women's Economic Empowerment

Imoni, emphasised the indispensable role of women in family life, community development and nation-building.

She said the celebration, themed "Rights, Justice, Action for All Women and Girls," underscores the Commission's resolve to promote inclusive development by creating opportunities that enable women to thrive socially and economically.

Imoni stressed that the NDCC would continue to implement initiatives that support women and enhance their participation in economic activities across the region.

"Women are central to everything we do at the NDCC, and that is why we celebrate you every year. Your contributions to peace-building, regional development, and nationhood are enormous, and we remain

committed to supporting and empowering you.

"With the commemoration of this day, we are asking for equal opportunities at the table for women. When a woman is empowered, there is transfer of both wealth and knowledge to her immediate community. Culture thrives when women thrive; women should be supported. This year, let us transition to action. It is not enough

to attend these programmes; let us put the outcome to use," she said.

The event featured entrepreneurship and business development sessions aimed at equipping women with practical skills to expand their enterprises.

Speaking on "Strengthening Local Enterprises for Global Trade Opportunities," Secretary of the Niger Delta Cham-

bers of Commerce (NDCC), Chief Solomon Edebiri, urged entrepreneurs to embrace sustainable business practices through effective cost management, ethical operations and leadership succession.

Also, Mrs. Sylvia Adeneye of the Nigerian Export Promotion Council (NEPC) delivered a presentation on "Non-Oil Export Opportunities and Export Readiness," encouraging women to take advantage of export opportunities and the benefits available to registered exporters, including participation in international trade exhibitions.

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Anxiety Rises Over August 15 Osun Governorship Election

the Inspector General of Police, Olatunji Disu, to redeploy the Police Commissioner and bring an apolitical police officer as the states CP, a request the IGP is yet to grant.

So far, both the ruling Accord Party and the federal backed All Progressives Congress (APC) have been trading accusations over the reported attacks in the state.

Last Monday, two factions of the National Union Of Road Transport Workers (NURTW) clashed over the control of motor parks and who will take charge of the transportation of the INEC materials and other logistics during the coming election.

Kalu stated: "The governor, as the state's Chief Security Officer (CSO), should work closely with all security agencies to ensure the safety of every resident, regardless of political affiliation.

"Those responsible for violence, intimidation, or attacks must be identified and prosecuted without bias. The Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) should be allowed to operate independently, while political parties and their supporters must reject violence and embrace peaceful campaigns.

"Only a secure, free, and transparent electoral environment can guarantee a credible election and preserve public confidence in democracy."

DEPOLITICISING SECURITY

Fatai Ibu-Owo, an African Democratic Congress (ADC) chieftain, listed the necessary actions that should be taken by the government to control the violence and political killings in Osun State.

According to him, they include depoliticising security. On this, he maintained that law enforcement agencies, including the Nigeria Police Force (NPF) and the Department of State Services (DSS), must enforce the law impartially.

He said politicians, government officials, or party loyalists involved in sponsoring, aiding, or abetting thuggery must be arrested and prosecuted, regardless of their political affiliation.

Another action he suggested is the disarming of political thugs. He said that security agencies must actively track down, disarm, and dismantle armed groups and cult networks operating under the guise of political factions, as seen in recent incidents in Osogbo.

On intervention, he stated: "State leaders and security heads (such as the Inspec-

tor-General of Police) must hold joint security and peace meetings to ensure warring factions are held accountable."

He also suggested citizens' participation, adding that "residents should refuse to be used as tools for destruction or violence.

"Communities must increase local vigilance and share credible intelligence with the police regarding the movement of suspicious groups or the stockpiling of weapons."

Ibu-Owo said the government must tackle unemployment, stressing, "many political thugs are unemployed youths driven by poverty and financial desperation.

"Expanding economic opportunities, vocational training, and youth empowerment programmes will reduce the pool of vulnerable youth who are easily recruited by politicians for violent assignments."

He also stressed the need for civic education, maintaining that "campaigns against electoral violence should target youths, educating them on the long-term consequences of political thuggery and ensuring they protect their own futures."

Dr Bolaji Akinyemi, a Christian activist, said the August 15 Osun governorship election must not become another contest where violence triumphs over the will of the people.

Akinyemi, a gospel Apostle and Convener of The Apostolic Round table (ART), said that the INEC, security agencies, political parties, traditional rulers, religious leaders and civil society must jointly commit to a peaceful and credible process.

He said: "Security should be intelligence-driven, impartial and visible enough to deter violence, while perpetrators of attacks, vote-buying and intimidation must be arrested and prosecuted promptly, regardless of political affiliation.

"Transport arrangements for election materials must remain under INEC's exclusive control and be protected from sabotage.

"Ultimately, political actors should remember that no electoral victory is worth the loss of a single human life. Democracy is strengthened when ballots, not bullets, determine outcomes."

IGNOBLE ROLE OF FACTIONAL NURTW

Dr Victor Mathew, a security expert and human rights promoter, said that it is very disturbing that Nigerians are once more confronted with election violence.

Mathew, Executive Director, Kingdom Advocacy Network (KAN), and CEO, Nextstep Security Organisation, stated: "Elections related violence will continue to be a recurring decimal simply because elections in Nigeria are seen as a do-or-die.

"Only very few people contest elections to serve. Most of them seek political offices for personal gains.

"The tension and killings in Osun State have become very worrisome, especially among the NURTW members. A faction is alleged to be with the incumbent governor's camp, while the other faction says they are the authentic NURTW.

"We all know the antecedents of these people everywhere they are. They are known for violence, especially in the South West.

"The NURTW members are involved in the logistics of INEC materials. They are very critical to the elections. Any of the factions can derail the election by subversive activities, either for the incumbent governor or the APC, which is backed by the federal might.

"I will advise that the political parties and their leadership must tell their supporters to sheath their swords.

"Most of the killings and violence are perpetrated at the directive of the leadership of these political parties. Violence does not happen in a vacuum.

"Our office seekers must desist from seeing elections as a do-or-die. If truly serving the people is their objective and desire, they do not need to kill and maim to achieve that objective.

"Our law enforcement agencies must also do their job professionally without sentiments or favouring any party or candidate."

Dr Ekechukwu, who was speaking on the election violence in Osun State, stated: "Actions to be taken to ensure credibility are as follows.

"First, stop the bloodshed. Let there be security beef-up by various security agencies and local vigilantes, Joint Security Task Force, deployment of police, DSS, NSCDC, etc.

"INEC must work with the NURTW and RTEAN and independent park leaders to provide non-partisan vehicles for the sake of carrying non-sensitive materials.

"Police should escort all sensitive materials. Any attempt to hijack the unions should be treated as an electoral offence.

"There should be swift ar-

rest and prosecution of those behind reported attacks. They send signals of impunity and fuel more violence.

"The INEC and the Osun State government should ban night campaigns and rallies in volatile areas. INEC should hold crucial stakeholders' meetings involving all candidates, traditional leaders, religious leaders and CSOs.

"The ad hoc staff are usually targeted. Therefore, adequate security measures should be put in place to protect them.

The EFCC and ICPC should track vote buying and distribution of cash and food materials to voters 48 hours to election.

"All governorships candidates and the party chairmen must sign a peace accord with INEC, Police and the traditional rulers.

"Party leaders must publicly denounce the use of transport unions and cult groups. Gubernatorial candidates should focus on campaign issues like economy, education, infrastructure, security, etc."

CALLS FOR INEC'S INDEPENDENT OPERATIONS

Julius Adegunna, a media executive, stated: "I wonder why Osun State has become a theatre of war over this coming 2026 governorship election.

"Osun used to be a friendly and loving family, but for what the politicians have done to them. It is very unfortunate that they are now divided on very bitter political party lines."

"Now to what can be done. I think the onus is on the people not to allow politicians to use them against one another.

"Yet, the Independent Electoral Commission (INEC) should instil confidence in the people that it will play its role as an independent, incorruptible, credible and fair electoral body.

"The police and other security agencies must also work well to maintain peace and orderliness, before, during and after the election."

Tola Oresanwo, an activist and the Director, Administration and Programmes, Centre for Anti-Corruption and Open Leadership (CACOL), stated: "To ensure a peaceful and credible governorship election in Osun State on August 15, all stakeholders must prioritise security and transparency.

"The police and other security agencies should deploy adequately across hotspots to deter violence, protect voters, and swiftly arrest perpetrators of killings, attacks, and destruction of campaign materials.

"INEC must maintain full operational independence, resisting any attempts to hijack transport unions or logistics.

"Political parties and candidates should publicly commit to non-violence, engage in issue-based campaigns, and pursue disputes through legal channels.

"The civil society, media, and international observers need to monitor the process closely. While voter education promotes peaceful participation, it should not be left for INEC alone."



Tobore Oborevwo, wife of Governor, Delta State/founder, You Matter Charity Foundation (fourth left); Ezinne Catherine Onyeme, wife of Deputy Governor (third right), and special needs children during a free medical outreach for the children in Ughelli, Udu Federal Constituency, held at Otor Udu, Delta State, on Friday.

PHOTO: GODDY UMUKORO

Lions Club Takes Clean Market, Hepatitis B Awareness Campaign To Lagos Market

SEYI TAIWO-OGUNTUASE, LAGOS

The Lions Club International has intensified efforts to promote public health and environmental sanitation with the Clean Market Campaign and free Hepatitis B screening for traders at Day and Sunday Market, Ogba, in Lagos.

The outreach, organised

by the Ikeja Dynamic Lions Club in collaboration with the Lagos Hilton Lions Club District 404B5 Nigeria featured the donation of cleaning materials, waist aprons and waistbands to market leaders, alongside free Hepatitis B tests for traders.

Speaking during the exercise, President of Ikeja Dynamic Lions Club, Lion

Temitayo Osunremi, said the initiative was part of activities marking World Hepatitis Day, observed annually on July 28.

According to him, the club selected the market because its activities are largely focused within the Ikeja axis.

"We came to the market to promote our Clean Mar-

ket Campaign by donating waistbands, aprons and cleaning materials to market women. We also came to carry out free Hepatitis B screening for traders as part of activities for World Hepatitis Day," he said.

Osunremi explained that the club had previously carried out similar interventions in other markets,

including Ipodo and Opebi markets, but decided to extend the campaign to another location.

He said the cleaning materials were handed over to the secretary of the market's leadership because the Iyalaja was unavailable.

He disclosed that the organisers planned to screen about 100 people for Hepati-

tis B, adding that between 60 and 70 traders had already been tested during the exercise.

Also speaking, Marketing Chairperson of Lagos Hilton Lions Club, Lion Paul Aina, said the market sanitation exercise and free health screening formed part of the club's monthly community service activities.

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any court in Nigeria or elsewhere for corruption, drug offences, or any criminal offence, describing this as an undisputed matter of public record.

He argued that if the Presidency insists on using China as the benchmark for accountability, Nigerians are equally entitled to ask how Chinese authorities would treat cases involving the forfeiture of funds allegedly linked to narcotics trafficking and money laundering, as well as allegations of corruption and abuse of public office.

Atiku urged the Presidency to improve the quality of its public communication and focus on addressing Nigeria's economic challenges, insecurity, rising hunger,

Presidency's Attack On Me Exposes Tinubu To Public Scrutiny – Atiku

and institutional decline rather than engaging in what he called political distractions.

"The lesson is simple," he said. "Those who invoke China must be prepared to accept the Chinese standard completely. Accountability cannot be applied selectively."

PRESIDENCY FIRES BACK

Responding to Atiku Abubakar's claims on Saturday, Sunday Dare, Special Adviser to the President on Media and Public Communications, ridiculed Atiku's several attempts to be elected as president.

He noted that the former vice president's unbroken marathon of ambition has done little to el-

evate the standards of modern democratic inclusivity or national cohesion.

"Instead, Atiku's prolonged shadow-boxing has consistently heightened national tensions, inflamed ethnic fault lines, and weaponized religious dogmatism."

He expressed this observation in a statement on Saturday, entitled, 'Atiku Abubakar's Flight of Fancy and an Ambition on Crutches'.

Part of the statement read: "For nearly three decades, the Nigerian political landscape has played host to a singular, interminable political psychodrama: the relentless presidential voyage of Alhaji Atiku Abubakar. Since the

dawn of the Fourth Republic in 1999, the Wazirin Adamawa has maintained a stubborn, almost messianic grip on the presidential ballot, gallivanting through successive electoral cycles with the monotonous rhythm of a clock that refuses to stop.

"Five times he has thrown his hat into the national ring; five times he has lost. This, despite traversing political platforms from the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) to the Action Congress (AC), the All Progressives Congress (APC), and now the African Democratic Congress (ADC) for the 2027 showdown.

"This unbroken marathon of ambition has done little to elevate the standards of modern

democratic inclusivity or national cohesion. Instead, Atiku's prolonged shadow-boxing has consistently heightened national tensions, inflamed ethnic fault lines, and weaponized religious dogmatism.

"In an era where modern pluralistic democracies demand programmatic vision, social engineering, and unifying leadership, his campaigns have relied on divisive rhetoric, regional posturing, and the stale grievances of

an exhausted political elite.

"Worse still, for a man who presumes to offer leadership to Africa's most populous nation, his recent resort to grievance offshoring—outsourcing political warfare to Washington and reportedly paying \$1.2 million to an American lobbying firm to peddle petitions against a sitting Nigerian President—stands as an affront to Nigeria's sovereignty and a vote of no confidence in its democratic institutions."

Adedimeji Says NBA's 2026 Election Offers Hope Of National Rebirth

NSIKAK EKANEM,
LAGOS

Adam Adedimeji, the chairman of Lawyers in the Media Forum, has described the last biennial election of the Nigerian Bar Association, NBA, as signs of national renewal.

Adedimeji made the remark in a message of congratulation to the NBA President-elect, Oyinkansola Badejo-Okusanya, a Senior Advocate of Nigeria, SAN.

A copy of the message was made available to SUNDAY INDEPENDENT on Saturday.

The 2026 24-hour duration NBA election was concluded last Sunday morning with Badejo-Okusanya emerging president to succeed the outgoing president, Afam Ozigwe, in September.

With specific reference to the incoming 33rd president of the NBA, Adedimeji explained multiple ways through which Badejo-Okusanya's leadership of the Nigerian bar offers hope of national rebirth.

Referring to Badejo-Okusanya being the first elected female

president of the NBA, Adedimeji asserted that "Getting elected in an election contested by men of equally high standing in the legal profession is clearly stating that the culture of condescending treatment of women has shown signs of ebbing in our society", adding that "it is even great that she was neither elected on the basis of a quota nor exclusive reservation for women."

According to him, "Badejo-Okusanya was elected based on the strength of what Nigerian lawyers considered to have constituted her character and competence that could aid in giving the Nigerian bar its deserving niche in the course of shaping things in the Nigerian nation.

Pointing to the NBA's zoning and rotation of the presidency that produced Badejo-Okusanya from Western bar, he described it as "nationalistic pride", explaining that "her emergence is yet another proof that quality people who can lead at any level and field of our national life abound in every nook and cranny of the Nigerian nation."



Mariam Jonathan, Vice Principal Administration, Government Day Secondary School, Numan Local Government Area (LGA) (left); Bashir Khalifa, the overall third best student from the Government Day Secondary School, Numan LGA (middle), and Clement Minokaron, District Head of Lafiya, Lamurde LGA, during the fifth edition/2026 annual DSR Numan Secondary Schools Quiz Competition, a qualitative education CSR initiative by Dangote Sugar for indigent students of its host communities in Numan Federation, Adamawa State, held on Friday.

EJIKEME OMENAZU
LAGOS

The United Action for Democracy (UAD), a coalition committed to the defence of democracy, human rights, constitutional governance, and the rule of law, has expressed deep concern over the continued detention of former Kaduna State governor, Mallam Nasir el-Rufai through the weaponisation of punitive bail conditions.

The UAD, which addressed a press conference on Saturday in Lagos, alleged that the President

UAD Frowns At El-Rufai's Continued Detention

Bola Tinubu administration is descending to tyranny, even as it called for the immediate release of el-Rufai, who as at Saturday, has spent 150 days in prison detention.

Kunle Wizeman Ajayi, UAD General Secretary who signed and read the press conference statement, said the organisation strongly condemned the way the Tinubu government has been using the security agents and the judiciary to shut down opponents and keep many in jail, stressing

that the group is against all forms of oppression.

He stated: "UAD is particularly concerned by reports surrounding the condition of Mallam El-Rufai in detention and allegations that he may not be receiving adequate and timely medical attention.

"We are equally concerned by reports regarding the alleged arrest and detention of his personal physician, Professor Bello Abubakar, by the Independent Corrupt Practices and Other Related

Offences Commission (ICPC).

"This same madness of arresting and unlawfully detaining medical personnel is an insult to democracy.

"The same Tinubu regime arrested and unlawfully detained Nnamdi Kanu's doctor just for doing his professional work!

"We wish to state clearly that the fight against corruption and the prosecution of alleged offenders must be conducted strictly within the framework of the Constitution and the rule of law."

Police Arrest Two Suspected Armed Robbers Targeting Passengers In Rivers

ITODE AKARI,
PORT HARCOURT

The Rivers State Police Command has arrested two suspected armed robbers believed to be members of a criminal syndicate that targets unsus-

pecting passengers across the state.

The arrest followed the directive of the Commissioner of Police, Rivers State Command, CP Olugbenga Adepoju to intensify the crackdown on violent crimes and organised criminal groups operating in

Rivers State.

The development was disclosed in a statement issued on Saturday by the Police Public Relations Officer, ASP Blessing Agabe.

The suspects, identified as Uche Samuel, 45, from Omunato Local Government Area of

Imo State, and Nkechi Amadi, 42, from Nkede in Imo State, were apprehended by operatives of the Command during an intelligence-led operation.

Agabe said the suspects confessed during interrogation to their involvement in robbing passengers, adding that efforts are ongoing to apprehend other members of the criminal syndicate who remain at large.

Only Accredited Health Facilities Will Operate In Anambra — Commissioner

RAYMOND OZOJI,
AWKA

Anambra State Commissioner for Health, Dr. Ben Afam Obidike, has made it categorically clear that only government accredited health facilities will now operate in the state.

Obidike said that the measure was to eliminate quackery; ensure that unlicensed health facilities do not operate in the state and that above all, to ensure that the people have access to quality and comprehensive healthcare services.

The commissioner who stated this during the statewide facility accreditation exercise, noted that the newly introduced Health Facility Accreditation Sticker will help residents identify genuine, government-approved health facilities and avoid unlicensed operators across the state.

Obidike said that the initiative

was a major step by the Ministry of Health to improve transparency, patient safety and quality healthcare delivery, pointing out that all private hospitals, maternity homes, medical laboratories, dental clinics and other health facilities were required to renew their licences and accreditation every year.

The Commissioner explained that only health facilities that meet the Ministry's required standards are issued the official accreditation sticker, which must be displayed where patients and visitors can easily see it.

According to him, the sticker carries a unique QR code that allows members of the public to verify the accreditation status of any health facility using their smartphones. It also contains the Ministry's website and contact details for reporting complaints and suspected quack health facilities.

KAZEEM AWOJODU,
IBADAN

Medical practitioner and public health advocate, Dr. Oluwatosin Ademola Ojo, has called on governments at all levels to establish mini gyms in communities

Provide Community Mini Gyms To Combat Hypertension, Ademola Ojo Urges Govt

across Nigeria as part of efforts to reduce the growing burden of hypertension and other lifestyle-related diseases.

Dr. Ojo made the appeal while featuring on a Radio program

on The Africa Portal Radio/TV, where he spoke extensively on the importance of preventing high blood pressure through healthy living.

According to him, hyperten-

sion has become one of the leading health challenges affecting millions of Nigerians, stressing that greater investment in preventive healthcare would help reduce the number of people

living with the condition.

He urged Nigerians, especially those with parents or relatives suffering from hypertension, to pay close attention to their health by adopting healthier lifestyles.

He advised the public to consume more fruits and vegetables, engage in regular physical exercise, limit alcohol consumption, and undergo routine medical check-ups.

New 6 Div GOC Pledges Tougher Protection Of Oil Assets

ITODE AKARI
PORT HARCOURT

The newly appointed General Officer Commanding 6 Division Nigerian Army and Land Component Commander, Joint Task Force (South- South), Operation Delta Safe (OPDS), Major General Everest Okoro, has pledged to strengthen the protection of critical oil and gas infrastructure in the Niger Delta and sustain efforts aimed at boosting Nigeria’s oil production.

Major General Okoro made the commitment on Friday during the change of command ceremony at the Headquarters, 6 Division Nigerian Army, Port Harcourt Barracks, where he officially assumed office as the 12th General Officer Commanding of the Division following the recent appointment and redeployment of senior Nigerian Army officers.

This was contained in a statement issued by the Acting Deputy Director, 6 Division Nigerian Army Public Relations, Lieutenant Colonel Umar Adam.

In his inaugural remarks, the new GOC expressed grat-

itude to the Chief of Army Staff, Lieutenant General Waidi Shaibu, for finding him worthy of the appointment. He described his predecessor, Major General Emmanuel Emekah, as a distinguished officer and mentor whom he had known since their days at the Nigerian Defence Academy.

Okoro commended Major General Emekah for his successful tenure and assured officers and soldiers that he would build on the achievements already recorded by the Division.

He specifically pledged to sustain the protection of critical national infrastructure, intensify operations against threats to oil facilities and consolidate efforts that have contributed to increased crude oil production for enhanced national revenue.

Earlier, the outgoing GOC, Major General Emmanuel Emekah, thanked the Chief of Defence Staff and the Chief of Army Staff for the opportunity to serve the nation, while expressing appreciation to officers and soldiers of the Division for their loyalty, professionalism and dedication throughout his tenure.

Oborevwoiri Congratulates New NBA President, Two Deltans On Election Into National Executive

GODDY UMUKORO
ASABA

Delta State governor, Rt. Hon. Sheriff Oborevwoiri, has congratulated Mrs. Oyinkansola Badejo-Okusanya, SAN, on her historic election as the first elected female President of the Nigerian Bar Association (NBA), describing her emergence as a milestone for the legal profession and a victory for merit, excellence and gender inclusion.

The governor also felicitated with two Deltans, Chief Oghenero Okoro and Mrs. Gladys Aghogho Okpomor, on their election into the National Executive Committee of the NBA.

In a statement issued on Friday in Asaba by his Chief Press Secretary, Sir Festus Ahon, Oborevwoiri said Badejo-Okusanya’s emergence reflected the confidence reposed in her by members of the legal profession, following her distinguished career marked by integrity, professionalism and dedication to justice.

He expressed optimism

that her leadership would strengthen the legal profession, deepen the rule of law and promote reforms that would improve access to justice across the country.

The governor urged the new NBA President to unite members of the association after the keenly contested election and work with stakeholders in advancing judicial reforms, protecting the sanctity of the Constitution and sustaining the legal profession’s role in Nigeria’s democratic development.

He also wished her a successful tenure. Oborevwoiri described the election of Chief Oghenero Okoro as the First Vice President of the NBA as a well-deserved in recognition of his outstanding contributions to the legal profession.

He equally congratulated Mrs. Gladys Aghogho Okpomor on her election as Assistant General Secretary of the NBA, noting that her emergence underscored the growing influence of Delta professionals in the nation’s legal community.

EJIKEME OMENAZU
LAGOS

The Commandant General of the Nigeria Security and Civil Defence Corps (NSCDC), Professor Ahmed Abubakar Audi, has commended Executive Chairman of Ikosi - Ejirin Local Council Development Area (LCDA), Hon. Dr Akogun Wale Anomo

and the Paramount Ruler of Ayandelu Kingdom, Ayandelu of Odo-Ayandelu, His Royal Majesty (HRM) Oba (Builder) Ganiu Aderibigbe Asunmo, Jamade 1 and the people of Ikosi - Ejirin for commissioning and handing over a newly built Divisional Office for the

FG Inaugurates Inter-Ministerial Committee To Develop 2026 VAT Modification Order

CHIDI UGWU
ABUJA

The Federal Government has inaugurated an Inter Ministerial Committee to develop the 2026 Value Added Tax (VAT) Modification Order; a major step towards ensuring the smooth implementation of Nigeria’s new tax laws and providing greater certainty for businesses, investors and tax administrators.

The Minister of Finance and Coordinating Minister of the Economy, Mr. Taiwo Oyelede, inaugurated the Committee on Friday in his office, charging members to deliver a modern and practical VAT framework that reflects the intent of the Tax Reform Acts and responds to the realities of today’s economy.

He described the Tax Reform Acts, which came into effect on January 1, 2026, as the most extensive changes to Nigeria’s tax system in decades, noting that the reforms simplify tax administration, improve certainty, strengthen competitiveness, protect vulnerable Nigerians and create a stronger foundation for sustainable economic growth.

Efe Ovuakporie, Head, Information and Public Relations, who made this known in a statement on Saturday noted that the Minister explained that while the previous VAT Modification Order made under the repealed VAT Act had served its purpose, the new legal framework requires a fresh Order to provide clarity, update relevant schedules and support the effective implementation of the Nigeria Tax Act.

“This is not about reproducing an old document,” Mr. Oyelede said. “It is about developing a VAT Modification Order that is clear, practical and responsive to the needs of a changing economy.”

He stated that the new order should remove uncertainty, make compliance easier for taxpayers, support investment decisions and provide tax administrators with clearer guidance in implementing the law.

The minister directed the committee to undertake a thorough review of the legal framework, administrative practices and policy directives governing VAT administration, particularly the VAT exempt and zero rated provisions contained in Part

IV of the Nigeria Tax Act, 2025, while identifying areas that require further clarification.

He also charged members to engage extensively with stakeholders across government, the organised private sector, professional bodies and other interest groups to validate classifications, address implementation concerns and ensure that the final recommendations are practical and balanced.

Oyelede further instructed the committee to recommend a comprehensive schedule of VAT exempt and zero rated supplies, taking into account revenue implications, social impact, Nigeria’s treaty obligations and regional integration commitments.

In addition, the committee is expected to prepare a clear and implementable VAT Modification Order that aligns with the provisions of the Nigeria Tax Act and, where necessary, recommend amendments to the Tax Reform Acts and other enabling laws to strengthen implementation.

The minister urged members to ensure that every recommendation remains faithful to both

the letter and the spirit of the new tax laws, adding that the order should encourage industrial growth, support investment, promote exports, strengthen food security, encourage innovation and facilitate Nigeria’s energy transition without compromising the integrity of the VAT system.

He also stressed the need to reduce ambiguity in VAT administration so that taxpayers, investors, regulators and tax administrators can operate with greater confidence and certainty.

Oyelede further encouraged the committee to draw from international experience while ensuring that the final document reflects Nigeria’s unique economic realities and development priorities.

The committee has been given six weeks to complete its assignment and submit a Draft VAT Modification Order, schedules of VAT exempt and zero rated supplies with their corresponding Harmonised System Codes, implementation notes, a stakeholder consultation report and recommendations on any legislative amendments considered necessary.



Oba Ganiu Aderibigbe Asunmo, Ayandelu of Odo-Ayandelu Kingdom (left); Adedotun Keshinro, Lagos State Commandant of NSCDC (middle), and Akogun Wale Anomo, Chairman, Ikosi Ejirin LCDA, during the commissioning of the newly built NSCDC divisional office in Lagos, recently.

Anambra Police Command Deny Extortion Allegations At Onitsha Bridge Head

GLORIA ANAEZE
ONITSHA

The Anambra State Police Command has dismissed allegations circulating on social media that senior police officers benefit from extortion allegedly perpetrated by personnel at the Onitsha Bridge Head, insisting that such claims do not represent the values and operational standards of the Nigeria Police Force.

In a statement issued on Saturday by the Police Public Relations Officer, SP Tochukwu Iken-ga, the Command reaffirmed its unwavering commitment to professional, transparent and accountable policing, stressing that corruption and extortion remain unacceptable within its ranks.

The Command maintained that the conduct of any police officer reflects the individual’s personal character and adherence to the ethics of the policing

profession, and should not be mistaken for the official policy or directives of the Police leadership.

According to the statement, the pride of every senior and supervising officer lies in leading teams that operate lawfully, professionally and with integrity, rather than engaging in unethical practices.

The Police Command reiterated its zero-tolerance policy on corruption, extortion and other forms of misconduct, assuring

members of the public that every credible complaint would be thoroughly investigated and any officer found culpable would face appropriate disciplinary action in accordance with the laws and regulations governing the Nigeria Police Force.

While calling on residents to support ongoing efforts to sanitise policing in the state, the Command urged victims and witnesses of police misconduct to provide specific and verifiable information, including the date, time, location, vehicle registration number and, where possible, the identity of the patrol team involved.

Audi Commends Ikosi Ejirin LCDA Over Commissioning Of NSCDC’s New Divisional Office

Corps in Ikosi - Ejirin, Agbowa, in Lagos.

Represented by the Lagos State Commandant of the Nigerian Security and Civil Defence Corps (NSCDC), Mr Adedotun Keshinro, at the event, Prof. Audi said the timely and successful completion of the

project has demonstrated the belief of government and traditional institution in the mandates of the Corps and its commitment towards providing security and safety for the lives and property of the community.

In a statement signed by

SC Oluwaseun Bolurin, NSDC Lagos State Public Relations Officer (PRO), Prof Audi called on citizens to see the newly built office as a symbol of partnership between government, community and security agencies and a base for rapid response, centre for

intelligence gathering and a place for reporting matters and seeking help.

Hon. Dr Akogun Wale Anomo, the Executive Chairman of Ikosi - Ejirin Local Council Development Area (LCDA), responding commended the robust and effective collaboration between government, traditional institution(s) and security agencies in the LCDA.

NEWS

EJIKEME OMENAZU
LAGOS

Dr Bolaji O. Akinyemi, a Christian activist and Convener of The Apostolic Round Table (ART), has urged the Middle Belt region to choose its alliance wisely in view of its travails since insecurity and continued killings of its people.

Akinyemi, an Apostle and Nation Builder, in a statement made available to Sunday Independent, spoke against the backdrop of recent statement by the Middle Belt Forum (MBF) rejecting the proposed Northern Nigeria Security Trust Fund, a development which he said raised a question that extended far beyond security funding.

Choose Your Alliances Wisely, Akinyemi Tells Middle Belt People

Akinyemi, who prides himself as 'a friend of the Middle Belt', in the statement also advised the people of the region on the need to re-strategise towards the 2027 general elections, maintaining that the rejection of the proposed Northern Nigeria Security Trust Fund was fundamentally a question of identity, interest and political alignment.

It would be recalled that the people of the Middle Belt have consistently maintained that they are not part of the North, as their history, culture, tradition and location are unique and different from those of the core North.

Akinyemi stated: "Politics has never been an emotional en-

terprise. It is the organised pursuit and protection of interests.

"Every people who desires to survive must identify their interests, organise around them and build alliances that protect them.

"The Middle Belt can no longer afford to define itself merely as an appendage of a political construct called 'the North'.

"The Northern Region ceased to exist with the abolition of the regional structure in 1966. What remains today are constitutionally recognised states within a federal republic.

"While cultural and historical associations may continue, no region should demand political loyalty at the expense of

the security and wellbeing of its constituent peoples."

Akinyemi maintained that for decades, the Middle Belt has paid an extraordinary price for insecurity, even as he stressed: "Thousands have lost their lives. Communities have been destroyed. Places of worship have been attacked.

"Farmlands have been abandoned. Millions have been displaced. These are not abstract statistics. They are human tragedies.

"The question, therefore, becomes simple: What political arrangement best protects the lives, liberties and future of the Middle Belt people?

That question should guide

every alliance.

"No people should continue to invest political capital in arrangements that consistently fail to guarantee their security. This is not hostility towards any ethnic group, region, religion or traditional institution.

"Every community is entitled to organise itself in pursuit of its legitimate interests. Likewise, the Middle Belt must unapologetically organise around its own legitimate interests within the framework of the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

"No one can be expected to protect your interests better than you protect them yourself. The time has come for the Middle Belt to move beyond dependency towards responsible self-determination.

"This is neither rebellion nor separatism. It is mature federalism. It is democratic citizenship. It is responsible leadership.

"The advocacy for State Police provides perhaps the greatest opportunity for the Middle Belt to rethink its security architecture.

"Rather than committing

scarce public resources into regional security structures whose accountability may appear distant from local communities, Middle Belt states should prioritise building resilient state and community-based security systems within the law.

"Resources should strengthen intelligence gathering. Support modern surveillance technology. Improve emergency response systems.

Empower lawful community policing initiatives

"Rebuild destroyed communities. Resettle internally displaced persons.

Support victims. Restore agriculture. Protect schools. Secure highways.

"These investments will produce measurable security outcomes where they matter most—within the communities that have suffered the greatest devastation.

"The Middle Belt must also rethink its political alliances. The future belongs to regions and states willing to collaborate around shared constitutional values rather than inherited political identities."



Traffic congestion after an early morning auto accident along Lagos-Ibadan Expressway on Friday.

PHOTO: ANTHONY OLIGBO

VICTORIA OJUGBANA
LAGOS

Lagos State residents have been urged to adopt positive environmental habits and take greater responsibility for keeping their surroundings clean, as the state government intensifies efforts to sustain the reintroduced monthly environmental sanitation.

Lagos State First Lady, Dr. Ibijoke Sanwo-Olu, who among other state officials, at the monthly environmental sanitation exercise at Eputu London in Ibeju-Lekki Local Government Area of the state, commended residents for their active involvement in the exercise.

Dr. Sanwo-Olu described the response of the state residents as evidence of increasing environmental consciousness.

Embrace Positive Environmental Habits, Lagos First Lady Urges Residents

She noted that many residents began cleaning their surroundings days before the official sanitation period, adding that it demonstrated a commitment to environmental cleanliness.

"We noticed that both children and parents came out very early. In fact, some residents started cleaning three days ago. That shows people are becoming more aware and conscious of their environment," she said.

Sanwo-Olu noted that despite flooding challenges in some parts of the state, residents were making deliberate efforts to clear debris and maintain cleaner communities.

She said the state government was also deliberately involving

young people in the exercise to build a new generation of environmental champions.

Mrs. Sanwo-Olu said: "Our children have been here as early as 6.30 am. We are catching them young so they can continue the culture of environmental responsibility. By next month, we will also involve students from tertiary institutions."

Also, the state Commissioner for the Environment and Water Resources, Tokunbo Wahab, said the government was strengthening waste management infrastructure across the state, including ongoing work at the Olusosun Waste Transfer Loading Station and plans for a Material Recovery Facility.

Wahab stressed that the residents must take ownership of waste management rather than indiscriminately dumping refuse on roads, medians and drainage channels.

"Habits built over time take time to change, but with consistency, advocacy and proper messaging, we will get there. People should not dump waste indiscriminately. If a PSP operator fails to collect waste, residents should contact LAWMA for intervention," Wahab said.

He assured residents that while government would continue public enlightenment campaigns, enforcement and sanctions would also be applied where necessary.

Shehu Sani Advocates Renewed Commitment To Education

BOLU-OLU ESHO

To achieve sustainable national development, a former senator and human rights activist, Shehu Sani, has declared that there must be renewed national commitment to education, accountable leadership, youth inclusion and responsible management of Nigeria's human and natural resources.

He stated this on Friday while speaking on Nigeria's development at a lecture organised by the Faculty of Arts, Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife (OAU).

Delivering the lecture, entitled: 'Rethinking Development in Nigeria: Key Lessons and Prospects for the Future', Sani said Nigeria has made tremendous impacts through its contributions to institutional and societal development within and outside the country.

He told his audience, comprising of university administrators, lecturers, students, political stakeholders and other guests, that it's a known fact that Nigerian professionals, intellectuals and citizens had, at different levels in the globe, made significant

contributions exuding high quality of human resources abound in the country.

Nevertheless, the former senator of the Federal Republic of Nigeria identified the critical challenge the nation has in exploring and exploiting its advantageous population, talents and natural wealth for sustainable national development.

He noted that the nation would need a holistic approach towards achieving any serious development by examining the choices, achievements and mistakes of previous generations.

Sani emphasised that the younger generation of Nigerians should be guided by history as they prepare to take greater responsibility for the federation.

According to him, what today's Nigerians are enjoying, in terms of institutions, opportunities and values, were products of past decisions.

He, therefore, tasked young Nigerians to see it as an obligation to prepare a better society for the next generation, urging them to study the country's history, take pride in its accomplishments and resist every temptation to surrender to hopelessness.

TOR VANDE-ACKA
MAKURDI

The National Secretariat of Nigerian Association of Patent and Proprietary Medicine Dealers of Nigeria (NAPPMED), this weekend, dissolved its Benue State chapter over issues of lacklustre performance.

The national secretariat of NAPPMED, which dissolved the state chapter of the association, said the state leadership was not carrying out its activities in accordance with laid down rules and procedures.

The decision to dissolve the state chapter of NAPPMED

NAPPMED Dissolves Benue Chapter Over Lack-Lustre Performance

was reached at an Extraordinary Congress meeting of the association held in Makurdi, where it also set up an Interim Committee, to oversee the affairs of the association and midwife the setting up of new executives in the state, in a couple of months.

Speaking at the event, the National Organising Secretary of the association, Alhaji Musa Wakili, also explained that the election that brought in the previous executives was ridden with irregularities.

He observed that even so,

the national body decided to let the executives be, but later discovered that the situation in the state had grown from bad to worse and thought it best to dissolve it and pave way for a proper election.

Wakili further pointed out that "There was one little problem (with the election of the previous executives), because our constitution states that there should always be an election. So, election was conducted.

"The national representative came because it is one of

our rules that a national representative will witness the election that is conducted. But, the one that was conducted last, was full of irregularities.

"So the person that came to conduct the election is a God-fearing person and a pastor. He saw it that he was not supposed to report such an election to the national body and the national body in their wisdom decided to let them be, because the state cannot be left like that without a leader and see if we can have results.

"But between then and now,

it was more or less like the situation was worsening. So, the national body decided today that they should come and dissolve that Interim government which they put together and constitute this one to serve for some months so that they can prepare a formal election."

He therefore charged members of the Interim Committee, to "unite the members in the state. Secondly they should be able to work in accordance with the rules and regulations of NAPPMED and thirdly, they should be able to incorporate

everybody who call himself a member of NAPPMED and should be added to our database. Inaugurating the Committee, President of the Kogi State chapter of NAPPMED, Muazu Abubakar, stated that the importance of NAPPMED, to the wellbeing of the people cannot be over-emphasised.

He argued that even though there has been a running battle between members of the association and other pharmaceutical associations to get rid of NAPPMED, it has become increasingly obvious that the services of NAPPMED cannot be ruled out in most cases.

At 44, Abia Liaison Officer Launches Foundation, Empowers Widows, Vulnerable Women

In a celebration that combined philanthropy with public service, the Abia State Liaison Officer in Lagos, Mrs. Ugochi Otti-Essienette, marked her 44th birthday by launching the Grace and Impact Foundation and empowering 44 women, comprising mainly widows and other indigent women.

The event, held in Lagos last Sunday, July 19, drew an array of dignitaries, family members, friends, sponsors, development partners, community leaders, members of the media and beneficiaries, who gathered to witness the formal unveiling of the foundation and its maiden outreach programme.

The beneficiaries received empowerment packages designed to support their livelihoods and improve their economic well-being, reflecting the foundation's commitment to reducing hardship among vulnerable groups.

Addressing guests at the launch, Otti-Essienette said the occasion represented more than a birthday celebration, describing it as an opportunity to express gratitude to God through service to humanity.

She noted that the decision to empower 44 women was symbolic of her 44 years of life, which she said had been marked by divine grace, invaluable lessons and opportunities to positively impact others.

"As I celebrate my 44th birthday, I have chosen not merely to mark another year of life, but to celebrate God's faithfulness through service to humanity," she said.

"The number 44 is more than

my age. It represents 44 years of grace, 44 years of lessons, 44 years of challenges overcome, and 44 years of opportunities to make a difference.

"That is why today we are reaching out to 44 women, reminding them that they are seen, valued and loved."

She explained that the Grace and Impact Foundation emerged from a long-standing vision to create a platform that would provide support for women, strengthen families, promote children's development and extend humanitarian assistance to disadvantaged communities.

Drawing from her experiences in public service, the Abia liaison officer said she had encountered numerous women struggling to provide for their families, as well as children whose aspirations were constrained by economic hardship.

According to her, such experiences reinforced her belief that meaningful societal transformation requires individuals to take deliberate action in supporting the less privileged.

She said the foundation would focus on empowerment, education, humanitarian interventions and sustainable programmes capable of improving lives and strengthening communities.

"Our mission is to provide support, empowerment, education, humanitarian assistance and opportunities that help individuals and communities thrive. We are committed to creating lasting impact, one life, one family and one community at a time," she stated.

John Angel Charts Global Future for DIFFbyDATS

TOYIN ADEBAYO
ABUJA

After nearly two decades of shaping the public image of some of Nigeria's most recognisable personalities, award-winning fashion stylist and designer John Angel is stepping into the spotlight with DIFFbyDATS, a luxury fashion brand he believes is ready to compete on the global stage.

Having spent 17 years building a reputation as a stylist and image consultant in Lagos, Angel said the launch of DIFFbyDATS marks a deliberate transition from working behind the scenes to establishing a fashion house with an international identity.

In a statement, the designer said the brand has matured sufficiently to serve both the Nigerian and global luxury markets, particularly targeting members of the Nigerian diaspora seeking premium tailoring rooted in Afri-

can identity.

"It is a positioning aimed as much at the Nigerian diaspora as at Lagos itself. DIFFbyDATS ships internationally, and the brand's next chapter depends on reaching Nigerians in London, Toronto and Atlanta who want tailoring that carries a specific cultural fluency while matching the precision of established European luxury houses," he said.

Angel explained that the philosophy underpinning the brand, Mute the Norm, challenges conventional perceptions of Nigerian luxury fashion by embracing understated elegance rather than flamboyance.

According to him, DIFFbyDATS focuses on structured tailoring, refined silhouettes and restrained colour palettes, prioritising craftsmanship and timeless design over excessive embellishment.

FRANCIS ONOIRIBHOLO
BENIN

The Chief Medical Director of the University of Benin Teaching Hospital (UBTH), Prof. Idia Ize-Iyamu, has successfully installed over 100 solar-powered streetlights to illuminate the hospital staff quarters and

Insecurity: UBTH CMD Lights Up Staff Quarters With Solar Powered Street Lights

surrounding areas for security enhancement.

According to Prof. Ize-Iyamu, who was represented at the unveiling ceremony by Dr. Philip Osho, Deputy Chairman of the Medical Advisory Committee (Clinicals), the

EJIKEME OMENAZU
LAGOS

Barrister Kenneth Udeze, the National Chairman of Action Alliance (AA), has threatened to commence contempt proceedings against Prof. Joash Amupitan, the Chairman of the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC), over the commission's continued failure to comply with Court of Appeal judgments recognising his leadership of the party.

Chief Udeze, who spoke exclusively to Sunday Independent, maintained that the Abuja Judicial Division of the Court of Appeal has, on multiple occasions since January 2024, ruled in favour of his leadership in a protracted internal dispute with a rival faction led by Adekunle Rufai Omoaje.

Udeze listed five separate rulings, including a January 2024 judgment dismissing an appeal by the Omoaje camp, a September 2024 judgment affirming him as National Chairman, a November 2024 ruling in a related suit, an April 2026 ruling from the

Action Alliance Threatens To Sue INEC Boss, Accuses Him Of Court Contempt

Makurdi Judicial Division, and a July 2026 ruling dismissing an application by the Omoaje faction seeking to change the party's legal representation in a separate appeal.

He stressed: "The import of these concurrent judgments is clear and unambiguous: the leadership of Chief Barr. Kenneth Udeze is the only valid, subsisting, and legally recognised leadership of Action Alliance," adding that "any other claim is without legal effect."

He disclosed his legal team had written to INEC in May and July 2026, attaching certified copies of the judgments and demanding that the commission reinstate his leadership's details on its website, but that INEC had neither responded nor acted more than two months later.

Citing Section 287(2) of the 1999 Constitution, which mandates that Court of Appeal decisions be enforced by all authorities, Udeze argued that INEC was

legally bound to comply with the rulings.

"We ask: how does a Professor of Law and Senior Advocate of Nigeria who heads INEC justify disobedience of valid, subsisting and binding judgments and ruling of the Court of Appeal," he said, adding that Action Alliance would "without further delay" commence contempt proceedings against Amupitan over the Commission's non-compliance.

He also called on the INEC chairman to "publicly explain to Nigerians" the commission's position and demanded the immediate restoration of his leadership's recognition on INEC's platforms.

The dispute over Action Alliance's leadership has run through Nigerian courts for more than two years.

The Court of Appeal's Abuja Division has repeatedly ruled in Udeze's favour in proceedings involving the Omoaje faction, including the July 2026 ruling

he cited, in which the appellate court described an application by the Omoaje camp as an abuse of court process.

The rival faction, however, disputes Udeze's account of the underlying leadership dispute. Omoaje has previously said his faction's National Think Tank committee, which he described as the party's highest decision-making organ, suspended and later expelled Udeze, a position he said courts had upheld in cases Udeze himself brought.

Omoaje had also called for an investigation into Udeze over allegations of impersonation relating to party membership records presented before the courts.

INEC, for its part, has previously stated it could not list Omoaje as chairman, while the Court of Appeal judgment recognising Udeze remained subsisting, though Action Alliance has separately accused the commission of inconsistency in how it has treated the matter.



Members of Ikeja Viva L'Amour Lions Club, the Class of 2026 graduates of De Laurel School, Olowoira, and some women of Olowoira Market, Lagos, during the club's multi-phased community intervention exercise at Olowoira, Lagos, recently.

Ikeja Viva L'Amour Executes Multi-Phased Intervention In Lagos Community

ring the road which currently is filled with mud.

The mud, she said, made it impossible for some sections of the market to be swept.

"This same market has been like this for over 40 years, it hasn't changed, like I said, it could be better."

"Government can come in and help them make it look more like a proper modern market despite the size, assist them to make it look bigger, build more stalls and more people can come in rather than go to Berger to buy things."

Speaking of the enthusias-

tic engagement of the market women, Nnamdi-Nwosu noted that they warmly welcomed the club's initiatives and rightly admitted that a cleaner market directly improves their daily working conditions and attracts more customers.

Mabel Toyobo, the immediate-past president of the club delivered a public health talk which focused on the critical link between proper waste disposal, disease prevention, food safety and the overall community well-being.

Rose Ashade, the Activity Chairperson of the event out-

lined the items donated to the market to include: heavy-duty industrial trash bins, brooms, rakes, and large-scale refuse bags.

She remarked that the items would assist in alleviating the financial burden of purchasing cleaning supplies out-of-pockets.

One of the market women while appreciating the club for their presence in the market disclosed that the place was now looking neater than it previously was and another thanked God for their coming and stated that they looked forward to seeing more of them in the future.

ISSUES

DR AYOBAMI DAVIES

Nigeria is at a political juncture again. The choice of Sen Kassim Shettima as running mate again in the 2027 presidential election has reignited one of our oldest and most sensitive fault lines: religion.

The APC presidential candidate has settled on a Muslim-Muslim ticket again which should be a deep worry to every Nigerian who believes in national cohesion. Personally from 2023 I have been against it. Not because of any bias against Islam, and not because competence doesn't matter.

I am against it because Nigeria is a multi-religious, multi-ethnic nation. For decades, our politics has deliberately balanced religion in the corridors of power for one simple reason: to keep this fragile country together.

The Data: A Deeply Divided Reality

We cannot pretend religion doesn't shape our political landscape. The numbers speak for themselves:

A Near-Equal Split: Demographic estimates consistently show Nigeria's population is almost evenly divided roughly 49.6% Muslim and 48.2% Christian.

The Voting Blocs: In the 2019 general elections, INEC recorded about 82.3 million registered voters. The predominantly Muslim North West and North East held over 32 million voters, while the predominantly Christian South East and South South held over 18 million. To win, a candidate must build a

Tinubu Going For A Muslim-Muslim Ticket: A Step Backwards For Nigeria's Unity



Tinubu

bridge between these massive blocs.

The Unwritten Code: Since the return to democracy in 1999, no major party has fielded a same-faith ticket and won. Obasanjo/Atiku, Yar'Adua/Jonathan, Jonathan/Sambo, Buhari/Osinbajo all maintained a religious balance. It is an unwritten constitutional buffer for stability.

Religion in Our Political DNA

In an ideal world, competence, integrity, and merit would be the only yardsticks for leadership. That is the Ni-

geria we all want. But, our political parties know we aren't there yet, which is why religious and regional balancing is practiced even at the state level: The South West:

From Lagos to Oyo, Ogun to Osun, governorship tickets are deliberately mixed. A Muslim governor almost always picks a Christian deputy, and vice versa.

The Middle Belt and North: In highly diverse states like Kwara, Kogi, Plateau, Kaduna, and Taraba, running a same-faith ticket is considered political suicide.

This is not accidental; it is active nation-building. It is a structural way of telling every citizen, "You are seen. You are represented."

Are There No Competent Northern Christian Politicians? One of the most troubling arguments used to justify a same-faith ticket is that a Muslim VP is necessary to secure Northern votes. But, the North is not a monolith.

The Middle Belt and large pockets of the North East and North West are home to millions of politically active Christians. From Plateau to Benue, Taraba to Southern Kaduna, and Gombe to Adamawa, there is no shortage of highly competent governors, senators, technocrats, and seasoned leaders who happen to be Christian.

To suggest that a major party cannot find a single qualified Northern Christian for the VP slot is a erasure of millions of citizens. It insults their capacity.

If 'competence first' is the true metric, then the search pool must be inclusive. Excluding a whole demographic on the grounds of 'electoral mathematics' completely defeats the merit argument.

Why a Same-Faith Ticket is Dangerous Now

It Signals Exclusion: At a time when insecurity is rampant and mutual suspicion is

at an all-time high, a same-faith presidential ticket will be read by millions as a deliberate shut-out. In politics, perception is reality.

It Fractures a Fragile Consensus: The unwritten rule of balancing the ticket has been our safety valve since 1999. Discarding it for short-term political expediency risks tearing the country's social fabric.

It Strips the Winner of Legitimacy: A president must govern over 200million highly diverse people. A balanced ticket gives both major religious blocs a sense of equity. Without it, nearly half the country will feel politically alienated from day one.

The Outcry from Church Leadership

The sheer volatility of this issue is evident in the unprecedented backlash from faith-based institutions in year 2023. Unlike the historic 1993 MKO Abiola/Kingibe Muslim-Muslim ticket—which a hopeful nation tolerated in a desperate bid to end military rule—the current political climate is far more fragile.

In 2023, Christian institutions did not stay silent. The Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN) and the Pentecostal Fellowship of Nigeria (PFN) fiercely rejected the proposal, openly warning that a same-faith ticket is a direct threat to the secular balance of the

state.

The aggressive resistance from the pulpit isn't just noise; it reflects a deep, grassroots anxiety among millions of believers who feel their place in the Nigerian project is being systematically devalued.

The Church and Christian Leaders must not keep silent in the upcoming elections of 2027. Their voices must be loud on this issue as it was in 2023.

Competence is Vital, But Inclusion is Non-Negotiable

We must vote on merit, but in a complex multinational state like Nigeria, competence without sensitivity to diversity is a political liability. True leadership is not just about policy; it is about trust and emotional safety.

Deeply divided democracies around the world rely on power-sharing arrangements to survive. Our version has been regional and religious balancing. To abandon it now, at our highest level of government, is an incredibly reckless gamble with our national unity.

President Tinubu has the right to choose his running mate. But, he also has a responsibility to the stability of the republic. A Muslim-Muslim ticket may be legally permissible, but in our current climate, it is politically tone-deaf and structurally dangerous.

We must build a Nigeria where a leader's faith no longer matters. But, we are not there yet. Until we are, statecraft demands that our leaders govern with both merit and inclusion in mind.

NEWS

FRANCIS ONOIRIBHOLO
BENIN

The Executive Director of Africa Network for Environment and Economic Justice (ANEEJ), Rev. David Ugolor, has called on Edo State Governor Monday Okpebholo and his Delta State counterpart, Sheriff Oborevwori to declare an infrastructure emergency on the Benin-Sapele-Warri expressway, which connects the two neighbouring states.

In an Open Letter to President Bola Tinubu, which

Ugolor Calls On Okpebholo, Oborevwori To Declare Infrastructure Emergency On Benin-Sapele-Warri Road

was copied Okpebholo, Oborevwori, the managing director of Niger Delta Development Commission (NDDC), and political leaders of the South-South region, Rev. Ugolor called for the establishment of a Joint High-Level Intervention Task Force in collaboration with the Federal Ministry of Works.

Ugolor urged President Tinubu to direct accelerated reconstruction of all failed

sections, remove administrative bottlenecks and ensure that adequate funding and effective supervision remain priorities until completion.

The activist further wrote: "The Federal Ministry of Works and the NDDC should publish comprehensive information on contracts, funding releases, implementation milestones and expected completion dates for projects along this

corridor. Public confidence grows when information is openly shared."

Her explained that there is no better opportunity for exceptional leadership as the Federal Government, Edo and Delta states governments are all led by the ruling All Progressives Congress (APC), an opportunity for seamless cooperation across these levels of government to resolve a challenge of immense regional

and national importance.

In the letter, titled, 'Rescuing the Benin-Sapele-Warri Corridor: A Test of Leadership and Cooperative Governance', Ugolor said that highway and its connecting corridors have deteriorated into one of the greatest infrastructure failures in Southern Nigeria.

He stressed that what should have been a strategic gateway to the Niger Delta has become a corridor of

hardship, insecurity and economic decline.

As a son of the Niger Delta and a civil society advocate who has spent more than three decades promoting transparency, accountability and sustainable development, Ugolor emphasised that he is of the strong opinion that silence is no longer an option.

He further lamented that every day, thousands of Nigerians endure hours of avoidable delays, damaged vehicles, escalating transport costs and significant economic losses.

OKEOGBUEHI
UCHECHUKWUJEME
ONITSHA

A youth development advocate, Dr. Ify Aronu, wants consolidation of the application of power shift across the federation.

Aronu reiterated that sustaining the dividends of democracy will enhance citizens' confidence in the political process, reduce unnecessary political tension, encourage mutual trust among the senatorial zones, and reinforce the idea that every part of the nation or state is an equal stakeholder in its future.

Youth Development Advocate Wants Cost-Saving Power Shift Across Nigeria

She equally noted that the application of the convention has helped in reducing election expenses by those who ordinarily join the contest in breach of power shift arrangement.

Speaking to newsmen in Awka, the Anambra State capital, Aronu pointed out that the greatest test of any successful system is not how it begins, but whether successive generations are willing to preserve it.

She pointed out that if the zoning arrangement has fostered a sense of belonging, and maintained public peace and political stability, then it

deserves to be strengthened rather than abandoned.

She suggested an enactment of legislation by the National Assembly and approved by the president to make the rotation of power across states of the federation compulsory.

The youth development promoter lauded the electorate in Anambra State for their political wisdom in sustaining the application, describing it as largely successful.

Examining the convention, particularly in Anambra State, she recounted that the zoning arrangement gained

momentum from the Peter Obi administration (2006 - 2014), through Willie Obiano to the current leadership of Professor Chukwuma Soludo who has ended his first tenure (2022 - 2026) and is now serving out his second term which elapses in 2030.

Aronu harped on the need to apply the convention: "As Professor Soludo once asked, 'If it is not broken, why mend it'. Indeed, if the zoning system is not defective, why discard it?"

"Since the creation of Anambra State in 1991, the pattern of political leadership has been representative

and inclusive. Even without a written zoning arrangement earlier on, the emergence of APGA under Governor Peter Obi (2006 - 2014) amplified the principle of rotational leadership.

Anambra South produced Dr. Chinwoke Mbadinuju (1999-2003) and later Chief Willie Obiano (2014-2022).

Mr. Peter Obi, whose administration laid the foundation for the party's zoning philosophy, emerged from Anambra Central, and his successor, Obiano, came from Anambra North, while the present governor, Professor Soludo, represents Anambra

South.

"This pattern reflects a deliberate effort to ensure that no senatorial zone is permanently excluded from the state's highest office."

She added: "The zoning arrangement advanced by the Peter Obi-led administration appears to be one of the most significant political innovations in Anambra State. Over the past two decades, the gentlemanly practice has blossomed into a respected convention that has ensured fairness, equity and inclusion of the three senatorial zones in central state governance."

SUNDAY
INDEPENDENT

THE MOST READ NEWSPAPER AMONG THE POLITICAL AND BUSINESS ELITE

Our View

VISION

To be Nigeria's First Truly Independent National Quality Newspaper

OUR MISSION

To produce a quality, vibrant and viable newspaper that will inform and form the nation's present and aspiring political, business, economic and cultural leadership; challenge and inspire the nation's journalists to advance and defend the public good; and deliver superior value to all stakeholders.

EDITORIAL POLICY

We shall be independent on all matters, but shall never be neutral on any matter, especially those concerning the well-being of Nigerians.

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Reflections On Nigeria's Fifth Constitutional Amendment (5)

This newspaper regrets the inability of the ninth National Assembly to kick-start the process of inauguration of state police. Given the security situation in the country – terrorist attacks in worship centres, bombings, killings, kidnapping for ransom, herdsmen's attacks, banditry and kidnapping for rituals – this medium repeatedly called on the national legislature to include state police in the constitution amendment exercise. Every successful federation operates a multi-layer policing system. Nigeria cannot an exception, especially in the face of gargantuan insecurity.

Nor are we impressed that none of the 35 Constitution Alteration Bills addressed the need to cut down the colossal cost of governance. The United States of America, for instance, with a population of 347 million (2025 estimate), has a Federal Cabinet of 25 members. It is most instructive that the US has just 15 ministries. But Nigeria, with a population of 237 million (2025 estimate), has a bloated

Federal Cabinet of about 50 members and 34 federal ministries! What is more, the names (and number) of the ministries keep changing!

Whereas the US Congress consists of 100-member Senate and 435-member House of Representatives, the National Assembly in Nigeria has 109 members in the Senate and 360 members in the House of Representatives! Why would the US, the model of our presidential democracy, have a Vice President that doubles as the Senate President while Nigeria, a very poor country, has a separate Senate President?

Again, it beats imagination why Section 147 (3) of the 1999 Constitution, which provides that "the President shall appoint at least one Minister from each State, who shall be an indigene of such State", has not been amended. We are of the considered opinion that Nigeria does not need more than 12 ministries and 12 ministers, two each from the de facto six geopolitical zones.

While the ideal would have been the enactment a new full-blown federal

constitution for Nigeria, this newspaper welcomes what amounts to a piecemeal devolution of powers and urges all the federating units to take full advantage of the provisions of the Fifth Alteration of the 1999 Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

We urge the 10th National Assembly to kick-start without further ado the process of constitutional amendment to establish state police, cut down drastically the number of senators and Representatives in National Assembly as well as amend Section 147 (3) of the 1999 Constitution.

The 10th National Assembly will also have to look into the derivation principle. It was once an entrenched provision in the federal constitution of the First Republic. Section 140 (1) of the 1963 Constitution provided that: "There shall be paid by the Federation to each Region a sum equal to fifty per cent of – (a) the proceeds of any royalty received by the Federation in respect of any minerals extracted from that Region; and (b) any mining rents

derived by the Federation from within that Region."

However, there may be no need for any dust over the failure of the proposal on administrative and financial autonomy for the local government to be part of the Bills that met the constitutional votes for presidential assent. In federalism, local government ought not to be a tier of government, as divisions of powers are between the central government and the federating states. Besides, local councils in Nigeria are disproportionately established by various military governments to favour one section of the country to the detriment of others. We call for further debates on the desirability or otherwise of the local government system being a subject in the federal constitution that draws resources from the federation account.

Finally, while we congratulate Nigerians on the milestone achievements in some powers that have now been devolved to the federating states, we should not rest on our oars until the country returns to a full-blown federalism.

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"Acquisition of arms has become synonymous with possessing voter's card... The worst scenario of electoral violence is the surge in arms proliferations." – Gani Yoroms, Researcher on Electoral Violence

Arms, arms everywhere" was the recent alarm raised by the Chief of Army Staff (COAS), Lieutenant General WaidiShaibu, which was featured, literally screaming, as the news headline of several newspapers.

Incidentally, it echoes a similar concern raised by yours truly in November, 2025 via an article titled: "Arms Proliferation and the Dangers Ahead". Before then was the one that came from the former military head of state, Gen. Abdulsalam Abubakar (rtd). Speaking in his capacity then as the chairman of the National Peace Committee, he estimated that over six million illegal weapons were in circulation across the country. He noted that this influx of weapons heavily fueled banditry and insurgency, directly contributing to over 80,000 deaths and the displacement of three million people. He had also previously warned about rising weapon stockpiles in the country late in 2018.

Unfortunately, the scary situation has worsened over the years. According to Shaibu, "there are arms everywhere" in Nigeria, revealing the influx and circulation of illegal weapons acting as catalysts as a massive driver of insecurity in the country. Obviously, these weapons fuel violent crimes such as kidnapping, banditry, and terrorism across the country. It also poses potential threats to the conduct of peaceful elections come 2027.

In fact, the recurring ugly decimal of the self-decimating and life-wasting menace of arms proliferation deserves our collective attention and more so, how to find lasting solutions to it at this testy and trying time of escalating insecurity ahead of the 2027 general elections. And with the dire desperation of the political actors to hang on to power, or grab and run away with it by all means possible through sordid gimmicks and gambits, all concerned hands must be on deck. The aim of course, is to save our ship of state from galloping into the stormy waters.

This is of serious concern because though there is no exact, real-time figure for the number of illegal firearms in Nigeria, official and intelligence estimates range from 6 million to 200 million circulating across the country. Intelligence Estimates: Regional intelligence from the UN Regional Centre for Peace and Disarmament in Africa estimate that up to 200 million illegal small arms and light weapons (SALW) are in circulation in Nigeria, representing about 80% of those in West Africa.

According to SBM Security Report, the number of small arms in circulation in Nigeria, in the hands of civilian non-state actors is estimated at 6,145,000, while the armed forces and law enforcement collectively account for 586,600 firearms.

The proliferation is exacerbated by smuggling, local artisanal manufacturing, and weapons unaccounted for by state armouries. For example, a previous audit revealed the Nigeria Police Force could not account for over 178,000 firearms.

To combat this, the Nigeria Police Force and the NCCSALW routinely run operations to recover, decommission, and destroy thousands of illicit weapons.

Though the military and police attribute the arms proliferation to three main factors such as armoury leakages: porous borders and trafficking of arms from the Sahel and the Chad Basin down south to both the North East and North

Western zones of the country, the evidences on ground point to the lack of success in reining in the forces behind the proliferation.

For his part of the government and law enforcement agencies they raised alarms that a significant proportion of the illegal arms in circulation originally slipped from legitimate state stockpiles due to weak armory oversight.

As at November 2025 Nigeria accounted for 70% of 11 million illegal arms and light weapons in West Africa, as made available by the National Center for the Control of Small Arms and Light Weapons (NCCSALW).

The consequences are dire, including those whose heinous crimes against humanity have made it possible for the United States President Donald Trump to accuse Nigeria of "Christian Genocide" and tag it a Country of Particular Concern (CPC). Amongst them are the Boko Haram, ISWAP, bandits, armed Fulani herders, kidnappers, Lakurawa and the new Mahmuda insurgents who keep unleashing horror and havoc on their defenceless victims. That is so in the mineral-rich states of as Zamfara and Plateau in addition to the fertile fields of Benue, Kwara, Oyo and Ondo.

The fact that illegal arms dealings are largely responsible for Nigeria's 2.2 million Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) and 26,000 refugees in neighboring countries, as revealed by Mr. Alex Ebimiebo, the South-South Zonal Director of the NCCSALW is disturbing.

He added that arms proliferation has also led to economic distortions, an increase in violence, crime, and impediment to peacebuilding. He was the man who raised alarm over Nigeria accounting for 70 per cent of illegal arms in the subregion.

Illegal weapons are also made available to the IPOB members in the South – East geo-political zone, and the oil thieves in the oil-rich Niger-Delta, South-South zone. But what really are the factors that have fuelled their proliferation and use?

With the Chief of Defence Staff not-

ing that West Africa holds over 500 million illegal arms, about 40% of which are in Nigeria is of serious concern. This widespread availability of weapons continues to fuel the activities of non-state actors.

With regards to the porous borders, despite intensified controls, illegal weapons are frequently moved through unmonitored land borders and ports. But of concern are the sustainable solutions to illegal arms circulation across the country.

To address this, security forces have launched operations to intercept these arms supply routes, while the National Centre for the Control of Small Arms and Light Weapons (NCCSALW) has been actively training personnel to strengthen armoury security and recover illicit weapons.

In terms of solutions, we need to involve the whole society in this fight against the challenge of arms proliferation. Since the NCCSALW center has a lot of programmes for collaboration with sister agencies, with advocacy and sensitisation programmes members of the general public should be frequently enlightened. As Oludude highlighted, there should be inter-agency collaboration to tackle the proliferation of arms because no single agency, regardless of its resources or dedication, could effectively tackle the complex challenge alone.

Of significance, is the need for the government to continue to invest in training, technology, and intelligence gathering. All of these will boost the capability of the security agencies to do away with illegal arms and ammunition. That is as rightly suggested by the Flag Officer Commanding (FOC) of the Eastern Naval Command, Rear Adm. Kennedy Ezete.

On the way forward, yours truly advocates for enhanced intelligence gathering, a robust arms mop-up by security agencies, socio-economic reforms to alleviate joblessness and poverty, and the prosecution of political figures who use arms and thuggery to rig elections. Prevention will be better than cure.

Nigeria's Struggle With Corruption

ABBAS ABUBAKAR

It is not debatable that Nigeria, in all its years of existence, has never seen the level of corruption it is witnessing today. The unmasking of corruption and corrupt people in Nigeria by the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission, EFCC, in recent weeks has made one to ask the question: to what extent shall we continue to suffer from corruption?

The successes the EFCC is recording in various courts within Nigeria are jaw-dropping. Just recently, the Commission successfully secured the final forfeiture of forty-eight properties scattered in Kaduna, Kano, Kebbi and the FCT. These properties, including a University, a radio station, hotels, recreational centres, agro-companies, valued at N212 billion, are allegedly linked to a former Minister of Justice and Attorney General of the Federation, Abubakar Malami.

Delivering judgment on the matter, Justice Joyce Abdulmalik of the Federal High Court, Abuja, held that the Commission had successfully established that the properties were reasonably suspected to be proceeds of unlawful activities and were not acquired with lawful sources of income.

Today, Nigerians wake up to yet another success story, one that nearly breaks the human jaw. Another court

in Abuja, presided over by Justice Jude Onwubuzie, in a judgement he delivered, granted the final forfeiture order of jewellery valued at N4.6b, eleven exotic cars, valued at N4.2b, \$50,000, and N30m to the federal government. The assets are allegedly linked to a business woman, Ms Aisha Achimugu.

Even though the late Professor Chinua Achebe, in his foreword on the book, *A Paradise For Maggots: The Story Of A Nigerian Anti-Graft Czar*, stated that "in its fifty years of existence, Nigeria has had its fair share of corruption, mediocrity, political ineptitude and ethnic bigotry; factors that have conspired to rob that potentially great country of its rightful place amongst the comity of se-

With the transfer of power from the military dispensation to a democratic era, it is believed that corruption is the greatest single bane of Nigerian society

rious advanced nations."

He further stated that "half a century of broken promises, systems and dreams have left this once 'beacon of hope of the African continent' a shambles. What has been missing in this West African nation's history is a concerted effort to develop checks and balances and produce Eliot Ness-like figures determined to keep criminality, in all its forms at bay."

Further, in the book, *Trouble with Nigeria*, Chinua Achebe argued that "corruption in Nigeria has passed the alarming and entered the fatal stage and Nigeria will die if we keep pretending that she is only slightly indisposed. It is true that corruption critically undermines economic development, it deepens poverty and erodes public trust. When corrupt people divert funds meant for development processes in sectors like healthcare, security, education and infrastructure, it restricts job opportunities and causes daily hardship on citizens.

"With the transfer of power from the military dispensation to a democratic era, it is believed that corruption is the greatest single bane of Nigerian society. As former President, Chief Olusegun Obasanjo who initiated the idea of EFCC described it, which occupied a greater section of his inaugural speech. His suspicion made him attribute cor-

ruption to 'widespread cynicism and total lack of confidence in government arising from bad faith, deceit and evil actions of recent administrations.'"

It is important to note that no society will achieve anything near its full potential if it allows corruption to become the full-blown cancer it has become in Nigeria. One thing that further led to the spread of corruption in Nigeria like a wildfire is that authorities allow it to fester unchecked and unchallenged and deliberately ignore the extant rules and regulations that punish corruption or help in the fight against corruption. There is no gainsaying the fact that even the international community believe that Nigeria is "an irresolvable corruption puzzle, a haven of institutionalised official sleaze and a country that nurtures and encourages citizens as criminals.

As we watch the EFCC prevent, investigate, and prosecute corruption cases in Nigeria, we should not just sit and watch as the event unfolds, we should also play our own part in the fight, because it start with us, individually and collectively; we must reject it in all its forms; we must stop it when we see anyone carrying it out; and we must also report it and those carrying it out.

Abubakar writes from Jab, Abuja via abbado01@yahoo.com

When 2026 Budget Drags The Church Into Politics

EJIKEME OMENAZU

The Church of Jesus Christ in Nigeria has been shaken into its roots. The nation's politicians in the Executive and the National Assembly are trying to drag the Church into their corrupt practiced.

Recently, it was revealed that the nation's 2026 national budget was padded to the tune of N8.05 billion. According to reports, the 2026 national budget includes an earmarked N8.05 billion for religious infrastructure, specifically allocating N1.91 billion for seven church projects and N6.14 billion for 52 mosque projects.

This allocation was uncovered through an analysis by Tracka, a public accountability platform by BudgIT, sparking widespread public debate regarding spending priorities amidst a large fiscal deficit.

According to the report, while Mosques were allocated N6.14 billion designated for 52 projects, Churches got N1.91 billion designated for seven projects.

Also, funds were found buried inside government ministries and agencies whose primary mandates have no connection to religious affairs. Allocations cover building and renovating worship centres, installing solar power systems, providing boreholes, buying musical instruments for churches, and building Imams' residences.

Also, some amount was said to have been allocated to construction of palaces of traditional rulers, and traditional worshippers in some states.

CSOs REACT

Already, civil society groups and political figures like Atiku Abubakar have publicly questioned the transparency of these expenditures, demanding the specific names of the beneficiary organizations and locations.

Also, bodies like the Northern Christian Association (CAN) have criticised the wide disparity in funding allocations between mosques and churches.

For instance, an unnamed church in Bende, Abia North Senatorial District of Abia State, is said to have been allocated N1 billion for the purchase of musical instruments, thereby raising the questions of who are the lawmakers from Bende or Abia North Senatorial District who might have influenced the allocation of such amount to a church in the area. And what is the name of the said church?

THE 2026 FEDERAL BUDGET

It would be recalled that Nigeria's 2026 national budget is N68.32 trillion (approximately \$50 billion). President Bola Tinubu signed the 2026 Appropriation Bill into law in April 2026 after the National Assembly raised the spending plan from the initially proposed N58.18 trillion.

The approved budget was dubbed the "Budget of Consolidation, Renewed Resilience and Shared Prosperity."

BUDGET BREAKDOWN

A breakdown of the budget shows Capital Expenditure: N32.20 trillion; Debt Servicing: N15.80 trillion; Recurrent (Non-Debt) Expenditure: N15.40 trillion, while Statutory Transfers is N4.80 trillion.

MEN OF GOD REACT

Archbishop Dr Joseph Adebayo, aka The Unstoppable Oracle, the Presiding Archbishop of the Lord's Triumphant Ministries & Towers Inc (Blessed Chapel), stated: "This



Tinubu



Akpabio



Okoh

For instance, an unnamed church in Bende, Abia North Senatorial District of Abia State, is said to have been allocated N1 billion for the purchase of musical instruments, thereby raising the questions of who are the lawmakers from Bende or Abia North Senatorial District who might have allegedly influenced the allocation of such amount to a church in the area. And what is the name of the said church?

is detrimental and an error. This amounts to dragging the name of the Lord in the mud, which is spiritually dangerous for anyone to do.

"Let them mention the names of those churches and Senior Pastors for confirmation. The churches that received such money should be profiled.

"To me, the Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN) should reject this nonsense and tell him to use the money to work for his people.

"The level of poverty in the country is alarming. Churches are not soliciting for money. We donate to the general public, give foodstuffs and ease transportation. Many churches supported many state governors during COVID-19 and other pandemic. May the Lord give us good leaders."

Rev Dr Tunde Elebute, General Overseer, International Christian Faith Mission, said: "When did the government start budgeting for the church? They should reveal the names of people and churches that have been collecting from them.

"What projects have they been undertaking for the church and where are the projects

located? Until the government responds to the above questions, I will not believe them. If the information is false, shame on the author of the news and their sources."

Bishop Dr. Herbert Ekechukwu, the Presiding Bishop, The Lord Of Glory Ministries, stated: "Section 10 of the 1999 Constitution states: 'The Government of the federation or of a state should not adopt any state religion.'

"Budget allocation to religious bodies blurs the line between state and religion and sets up a bad precedent. Churches and Mosques are not subject to public procurement laws.

"Money given to religious institutions through national budget can hardly be tracked. This opens room for padding.

"The question here is: Why churches and Mosques? What of traditional worshippers, NGOs, and schools.

Within churches and Islam who decides which church or mosque gets what? Then non religious citizens are excluded.

"When 'religious allocation' becomes a line item, it becomes a slush fund. Lawmakers and agency heads can insert fake churches and Mosques, inflate figures or projects that never exist. This normalises padding.

"Religious leaders will be turned into contractors, compromising prophetic roles of holding government accountable. Churches then become department of government."

Pastor Dr Victor Mathew (JP), Lead Pastor, Divine Channel Ministries International, Ikeja, Lagos, stated: "It is very painful that the Tinubu administration keeps extending its frontiers of corruption using different formats. It is unfortunate.

"So many issues are wrapped into this very despicable act. It is very fraudulent to insert over N8.05 billion for religious bodies through different agencies.

"Well, to me, the government can support religious bodies. But, it should be done transparently. Members of these religious bodies are also Nigerians. The fact is: Both the federal and state governments do sponsor pilgrimages.

"As a Christian leader, the disparity in allocation of over 80 percent Muslims and the balance to Christians is not acceptable.

"It goes to show that the Muslim-Muslim ticket is at work because there is no justifiable reason for such lopsided and unfair allocation. This imbalance must be addressed and I feel CAN should take it up.

"The Tinubu administration should in the future, if they want to empower religious

bodies, be sincere about it. A very disturbing angle to the whole thing is that the National Assembly saddled with the constitutional responsibility of over sighting the MDAS during budget defence never interrogated these allocations.

"It is very embarrassing that this National Assembly members have consistently refused to clothe themselves in glory, accepting whatever the Executive brings to them without question.

"In summary, these allocations were not really meant for religious bodies, but are conduits to siphon money using Churches and Mosques as a front."

LEGAL OPINION

Barrister Olalekan Festus Ojo, Managing Partner, Platinum & Taylor Hill LP, one of the nation's major law firms, a human rights lawyer and promoter of social justice, stated: "This revelation is constitutionally offensive, morally reprehensible, and demands the strongest condemnation from every Nigerian regardless of religious affiliation.

"Section 10 of the 1999 Constitution is unambiguous. Nigeria is a secular state. No government institution shall adopt any religion as a state religion. The appropriation of public funds by Ministries, Departments, and Agencies (MDAs) for the construction of mosques and churches is therefore not merely fraudulent budget padding, it is a direct violation of our constitutional order.

"That MDAs would brazenly insert such allocations into a national budget, apparently confident of escaping scrutiny, speaks to the systemic failure of our appropriations oversight architecture.

"The National Assembly's budget committees must be held accountable for this monumental dereliction of legislative duty.

"To Christian and Islamic leaders, I say this plainly: reject these funds completely, publicly, and immediately. Any religious leader who accepts public funds for the construction of worship centres is not merely complicit in constitutional violation; they are selling the independence and integrity of their religious institutions for government patronage.

"The church and the mosque that depend on government money inevitably become instruments of government influence.

"True religious leadership demands financial independence from the state. Speak out, reject the funds, and demand prosecution of those who inserted these fraudulent allocations. Silence is complicity."

Believing

How All My Siblings And I Found Ourselves In Ministry – Apostle Ebuka Nwachukwu

Can our readers meet you?

My name is Ebuka Nwachukwu. I am the Senior Pastor of Rhema Mountain Cathedral, located at Umunya, Oyi Local Government Area, Anambra State.

Congratulations for a successful Convention tagged 'Let Me Pass'. You are one of the speakers. How would you describe the impact of the programme on the attendees?

The 'Let Me Pass Programme' has been a major programme of Rhema Deliverance International Centre, Lagos, in the past 15 years. It is a programme of liberation. A programme of deliverance where those in bondage are, through the power of the Holy Spirit, are set free from the shackles of the enemy and repositioned on the strategic moves of God in their lives.

The impact of the programme over the years has been unprecedented. It is very impactful and that is why you saw the large crowd that came for the event. It is a programme we have annually and the testimonies have been unparalleled. It has been intimidating all to the glory of God.

This is not a product of man's wisdom. It is the manifestation of the living God. And anywhere the Spirit of God is, the Bible said there is liberty. So, the impact of the programme has been wonderful. All to the glory of God.

On the testimonies that come out of such programmes, we have recorded a lot. Members are getting better and better. We give God all the glory.

We learnt that all ministers at the convention, including you, are from the same father. What inspire you to be a minister of God?

All the Speakers during the 'Let Me Pass' programme are from the same father. We are a family of Levites. We have such families in the Bible: The family of Aaron and Moses in the Bible. The Bible says, "In the last day, I will pour my Spirit upon all flesh", not on the Levites, but on all flesh. In the Old Testament, it was selected few designed to manifest the glory of God. It is not so in the New Testament. In Joel 2:28 and the Acts of Apostles 2:17 where Peter said the prophesy of Joel had come to pass. In their time, God said: "I shall pour my Spirit upon all flesh. Your sons and daughters shall prophesy and your old men shall dream dreams. Your young men shall see vision." Peter said: "This prophesy is now happening in my very eyes." This is wonderful. It is not an arrangement of human wisdom, but by choice of God, even before the foundation of the world.

My father got born again in the 80s, after he was miraculously healed of a sickness. He told God: "I have come to discover that you are real". He had the revelation of call of God in his life. He went to Bible School. He later became a pastor in the service of God. God saw his faithfulness. One day, God told him in a vision: "All your biological children are priests. They would be men of God. They would serve me."

My father woke up in that revelation and told God: "Lord, I am sorry. Lord, I am not going to convince anybody to come into the ministry. Tomorrow, they would not blame me that they wanted to be doctors and lawyers, professors and that I destroyed them." My Father said: "You have to go to them individually and convince them. Some are in the medical schools some are about to be called to the Bar. Others are already doing well in business."

God being merciful and kind, He went to us individually. We had different encounters. We told our father individually about our encoun-

Apostle Ebuka Nwachukwu is the Senior Pastor of Rhema Gospel Church, Anambra State. He is one the clerics who ministered at the 15th edition of Rhema Deliverance International Mission held in Lagos recently. He spoke with **EJIKEME OMENAZU** on how he and his siblings are into ministry, eve as he proffered some advice to young ones going into ministry. Excerpt:



Nwachukwu

ters. Our father said: "Are sure about it?"

Everyone of us had different encounters. The first born came to our father that he had an encounter with God. My Father asked: "Are you sure about it? My father already knew. Then all of us had different encounters.

Our father then told us about his encounter and revelation he had. He said our encounters with God were manifestation of what God told him. It was not our father that stage managed our coming into ministry.

Today, all his children are priests. We are six in the family five boys and one girl. All of us, including the girl, are working for the Lord. It is not a product of man's

wisdom, but the grace of God and calling of God. We yielded to that call. And that is why you see all of us successful in the Ministry. It is not about joining our father's in business, but us being called individually; everyone with his own specific ministry. We return all the glory to God.

Since you are called into the ministry, who and what has been motivating and inspiring you?

Since my call to ministry, it has been a wonderful experience. Men of God struggle in ministry when they do not understand their calling and when they have lost touch with God. The moment you lose touch with God, ministry be-

comes boring. Once you lose the glory of His presence, ministry becomes like you going for your normal business. You are now serving God by experience and not by revelation.

My motivation and inspiration in the work with God is that every day there is something new. Every day you have a revelation. Every day you learn. So, every day comes with new revelation. The fellowship of the Holy Spirit is the sweetest thing on earth. This has been my motivation and inspiration and seeing the impact in men's lives. The visible result that is bringing into men's lives, into families and into communities... You can only rejoice in the Spirit that God is using you to change lives and change destinies. Lives that are been transformed has been my motivation. When I see people whose lives were meaningless, people whose condition were terrible and coming in encounter with God, their lives are suddenly changed. They become better human beings. That is our job in the work we are doing for God. God has been my inspiration.

If you put your motivation on Nigeria economy, it will collapse. Even if you put your motivation on American economy, it will still collapse. Even America economy at some point collapsed.

If you put your motivation in human beings, even human beings will fail you one day.

Jesus is my inspiration and He is my motivation and He has never disappointed. That is the reason why the Bible says: "Keep looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of your faith".

What would be your advice for Nigerian youths who are aspiring to go into ministry?

My advice for the Nigerian youths who are aspiring to go into the ministry is: Tell them that ministry is not a money making venture, because, the rascality in the ministry we see today is just on the premise that ministry is a money making venture.

You see youths thronging into the ministry without been called. One, even if you are called by God, you still need to be taught. You still need to learn. There are procedures in the work of God. You can say: "I have a vision for God". You jump into the ministry. It is not done like that. There are still the procedures to go through. Training, you need to go through before you are certified that you are ready for the work of the ministry.

It did not just start today. Even in the Old Testament, they had the School of Prophets under Elisha. They had the Sons of the Prophets. These were people called by God, but they were being trained.

Every aspiring youth should ensure they are called. He that called them is faithful (1Thess 5:24), but if they are not called and see ministry as a money making venture, they will end up becoming charlatans in the ministry, causing all kinds of problems and commotion in the Body of Christ. It is like seven sons of Sceva seeing Paul making it in the ministry. They wanted to do well like Paul. They ended being disgraced.

Ministry is not done by human analogy. It is of the Spirit. Everyman must know and understand their calling. That is my candid advice for the Nigerian youths aspiring to come into ministry.

My father got born again in the 80s, after he was miraculously healed of a sickness. He told God: "I have come to discover that you are real". He had the revelation of call of God in his life. He went to Bible School. He later became a pastor in the service of God. God saw his faithfulness. One day, God told him in a vision: "All your biological children are priests. They would be men of God. They would serve me

Believing

EJIKEME OMENAZU

The Centre for Righteous Living (CRIL), a prominent Lagos based non-governmental organisation, has issued a public warning to the ruling All Progressives Congress (APC) and the administration of President Bola Ahmed Tinubu to avoid anti-people policies and budget mismanagement that risk alienating potential voters ahead of the upcoming general elections.

Speaking through a statement signed by the Chairman of its Caretaker Committee, Dr. Olatunji Abolade, CRIL urged the government to beware of "enemies within" whose policy proposals and fiscal decisions threaten to pitch the administration against the Nigerian electorate.

The warning follows widespread public outrage over two recent policy issues: the proposed Federal Road Safety Corps (FRSC) Amendment Bill, 2026, which criminalises preaching in commercial vehicles, and the controversial allocation of N8.05 billion for religious infrastructure projects in the 2026 Appropriation Act amid a massive national fiscal deficit.

Reacting to the Senate's passage of the Federal Road Safety Corps (Amendment) Bill, 2026—which imposes a N50,000 fine, six months' imprisonment, or both on individuals preaching, hawking, or trading inside public transit, CRIL advised President Tinubu to withhold his presidential assent.

While reaffirming CRIL's support for road safety regulations, Dr. Abolade emphasized that peaceable religious expression inside commercial buses is a constitutionally protected right under freedom of religion and expres-

CRIL Warns Federal Government Against Anti-People Policies Ahead Of Elections



Abolade

sion.

"Commercial buses have for decades served as platforms where Christians share brief messages of hope, encouragement, and prayers with willing passengers, which Nigerians need to keep moving about this time," noted Dr. Abolade wondering placing Christian evangelism in the same category as commercial hawking. He warned that peaceful proclamation of the Gospel should never be criminalized.

Furthermore, CRIL also criticised the proposed N50,000 fine for street hawkers, arguing that mobile trading is a direct byproduct of widespread economic hardship, poverty, and unemployment.

The organisation urged the Federal Government to adopt humane alternatives, such as designated trading

zones and economic empowerment programmes, rather than penalising vulnerable citizens struggling to survive.

On the alleged N8.05 Billion budget allocation for religious infrastructure, CRIL also raised strong objections to budget tracking reports by Budget's Tracka, revealing that "N8.05 billion was earmarked across 59 line items in the 2026 Appropriation Act for constructing, renovating, and equipping churches and mosques."

The projects, according to the appropriation bill, include solar installations, mini-grids, sound equipment, and residences, come despite a N31.45 trillion national fiscal deficit.

CRIL expressed deep concern over why religious infrastructure projects were inserted into various Ministries, Departments, and Agencies (MDAs) whose statutory mandates have no connection to religious affairs.

It also accused the Senate of funding imbalance which "Out of the N8.05 billion allocated, N6.14 billion was assigned to 52 mosque-related projects, while only N1.91 billion was allocated across 7 church-related projects.

"Hiding religious projects within unrelated MDA spending plans opens avenues for budget padding and the conversion of public funds into private pockets," He explained.

"This imbalance raises serious concerns about equity, fairness, and equal treatment of all Nigerians regardless of religious affiliation," Abolade

warned.

"At a time when public facilities are severely lacking, hiding worship centre renovations in MDA budgets looks like corrupt practice.

"We urge the government to thoroughly audit the budget, stop these allocations, and direct funds toward critical public infrastructure."

The Centre for Righteous Living concluded by urging President Bola Ahmed Tinubu and the National As-

sembly to pause, listen to the pulse of the nation, and engage civil society and faith leaders in broader consultations before signing controversial bills into law or releasing funds for non-essential expenditure.

CRIL reaffirmed its commitment to the rule of law and responsible religious conduct while calling on the federal government to defend Nigeria's democratic values and prioritise the welfare of its citizens.



Rev and Rev Mrs Badejo

WYBF Marks 5th Annual Memorial Lecture With Focus On Next- Generation Leadership

The Wilson and Yinka Badejo Foundation (WYBF) will host the 19th Annual Lecture and the fifth edition of its Memorial Lecture on Wednesday, August 5, 2026, at the Nigerian Institute of International Affairs (NIIA), Lagos.

This year's theme, 'Raising Responsible Next-Gen Leaders: Character, Leadership and the Future of Nigeria', marks five years of impactful discussions and reflections on leadership and character development in Nigeria.

According to the organisers of the event, the lecture aims to inspire and equip the youth with the necessary tools to navigate the complexities of leadership in an ever-evolving society, which comes at a critical time when the nation demands nation-building, ethical governance, and youth development.

The organisers stated: "The lecture plans to explore how to cultivate responsible leaders for a brighter future and inspire thought-provoking discussions on values, visionary leadership, and accountability in Nigeria's next generation, featuring scholarship awards, celebration of leadership excellence, and networking.

According to them, the keynote speaker for the 2026 lecture is Mrs. Debola Deji-Kurunmi, a renowned leadership development expert, author, conference speaker, and founder of the Debola Deji-Kurunmi Foundation, known for her work in transforming young Africans into ethical leaders.

They said the guest of honour will be Mr. Tunde Lemo, a distinguished banker, financial expert, institutional leader with insight on governance, former Deputy Governor of the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN), and currently the Chairman of Titan Trust Bank.

They continued: "The Mother of the Day will be Rev. Dr. Mrs. Shade Aboyeji, a respected mother, minister, mentor, and model largely acknowl-

edged for her exemplary leadership and family values.

"The WYBF's Annual Memorial Lecture, now in its fifth year, has become a flagship platform for thought leadership, bringing together policymakers, business leaders, clergy, educators, young professionals, and career youths to foster responsible leadership and nurture young leaders for a significant impact on society.

"The 2026 edition will examine how character formation, values-based leadership, and mentorship can shape more responsible leaders of tomorrow in Nigeria.

"The lecture will inspire participants to engage actively in nation-building and is open to the public, welcoming youth, organisations, and civil society groups to participate in raising the next generation of responsible leaders dedicated to society.

"As part of the activities during the 2026 annual lecture, and in continuation of building on the legacies of the founders, who are forced to reckon with and tireless in the service of the kingdom, WYBF will provide opportunities for the educational advancement of brilliant, disadvantaged students through the award of scholarships and support arrangements.

"After a thorough screening exercise, WYBF has successfully selected some indigent students from various public higher institutions across the country who will be given the scholarship.

"The 2025 lecture Keynote Speaker was Mr. Fela Durotoye, a renowned values champion, leadership expert, executive coach, and President of Gemstone Nation Builders Foundation, with Dr. (Mrs.) Cecilia Ibru, the Chancellor of Michael and Cecilia Ibru University, as the Special Guest of Honour, and the wife of a former President of Nigeria, Chief (Mrs.) Bola Obasanjo, as the Mother of the Day.

Again, Archbishop Adebayo Mobilises Top Christian Clerics To Pray For Nigeria

EJIKEME OMENAZU

His Eminence, Dr. Joseph Olagoke Adebayo, the Presiding Archbishop of The Lord's Triumphant Ministries and Towers Inc., Lagos, yesterday, Saturday July 25, 2026, mobilised top men of God to pray for the nation.

This was the latest edition of the meeting of 'The Fathers of Faith Of Nigeria' which included top Nigerian Christian leaders at home and all over the world to pray for Nigeria until something positive begin to happen.

Speaking in a pre-event interview with Sunday Independent on the latest edition Archbishop Adebayo stated: "This edition comes up this Saturday

July 25, 2026 (yesterday), with the theme: 'Supernatural Turn-Around' (taken from Psalm 126:1).

"The programme is held twice a month. It is a global online meeting. It is only God that has the capacity to turn things around.

"When we sincerely call upon Him, He would turn our bad governance to good governance, insecurity to security."

He maintained that the programme, which was by divine instruction, will help to usher in positive changes in the affairs of Nigeria.

The programme started at 6.Pm (Nigerian time) and involved several Nigerian men of God many of them living in Europe and USA.



Adebayo

Pope: Do Not Forget Those Most In Need

Pope Leo XIV encourages Christians not to forget about the sick, the elderly and those who are suffering during the summer season, in the July/August edition of the Italian magazine, Piazza San Pietro.

The Pope was responding to a letter sent by Maurizio from Rome, who asked how he can live the summer months in a way that deepens and enriches his faith.

In his letter, Maurizio highlights the current turbulent times affected by wars and instability but also by a world that is "faster and more efficient than ever, but often superficial and distracted."

"I often wonder how it is possible to live and nurture a more conscious and authentic spirituality—one that can translate into concrete acts of love and responsible respect for others," Maurizio reflects.

He tells the Pope that as the summer holidays approach, he wants to live them not only as a period of rest but also as a moment to "rediscover a deeper dimension" of his inner self, in order also "to rediscover an authentic space for encountering God the Father."

Maurizio thus concludes the letter by asking the Pope for his thoughts and advice on this.



Pope Leo XIV

The Pope's response firstly remembers "those who cannot even enjoy a brief period of rest because they are crushed by burdens of every kind."

"Let us think of the sick, of those who have lost hope in life, of those overwhelmed by the pain of losing loved ones, of the victims of war, hatred, terrorism, and violence, of those persecuted for their faith and for justice, of prisoners, of those who have lost their jobs or their homes, and of migrants who are not welcomed with humanity," the Pope emphasises.

He notes how holidays should be for everyone a time of respite from work and worries in order to experience genuine friendship and company, as a foretaste of the communion of the Kingdom of God.

In order to strengthen one's faith, he thus calls all Christians to "make use also of the summer to live out the Gospel of peace and mercy."

EDITOR'S NOTE

Dear Pastors, Church Leaders, and Believers, to promote your church programmes and events such as Crusades, Thanksgivings, Birthdays, Special Announcements, Prayer Programmes, Launchings, Book Presentations, etc, please, contact: 08060766311.

Believing

Happy National Disability Independence Day

Today, July 26th, is National Disability Independence Day. It marks the 1990 signing of the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), which protects people with disabilities from discrimination. The purpose of the U.S. Equal Employment Opportunity Commission was to promote equal rights, community inclusion, and accessible infrastructure, especially for persons with disabilities.

Likewise, the International Day of Persons with Disabilities is celebrated annually on December 3rd. It was proclaimed in 1992 by the United Nations General Assembly to promote the rights and well-being of persons with disabilities. On this very day, persons with disabilities are not only celebrated in United States of America but all over the world. Today we are joining the United States of America to advocate for the independence of Persons with disabilities.

Persons with disabilities are individuals with long-term physical, mental, intellectual, or sensory

impairments that hinder their full participation in society on an equal basis. An estimated 1.3 billion people worldwide experience significant disability. This total represents about 16% of the global population, or 1 in every 6 individuals. Here in Nigeria, about 35 million to 35.5 million persons live with disabilities, based on the global benchmark of 15% applied to national population data.

Persons with disabilities face major daily obstacles including social stigma, physical inaccessibility, and high rates of unemployment. These barriers limit their freedom and equal participation in society. Unfortunately the 1999 Constitution of Nigeria does not explicitly mention or use the word "disability," leaving the protection of persons with disabilities (PWDs) to general fundamental rights and separate specific legislation.

Section 42 of the Constitution guarantees freedom from discrimination, but it lists only sex, religion, place of origin, political opinion, and ethnic group—omitting disability.

Chapter II of the Constitution addresses state social objectives, but these provisions are non-justifiable and cannot be enforced in court. Hence, Persons With Disabilities have to rely on general human rights provisions under Chapter IV for their protection.

Legislative bills and acts concerning persons with disabilities face major hurdles, including poor implementation, weak enforcement mechanisms, and severe underfunding. Despite legal frameworks like the Discrimination Against Persons with Disabilities (Prohibition) Act, structural, financial, and societal barriers continue to limit true inclusion.

However, unfair treatment, abuse, or isolation of individuals based on any disability, carrying fines up to N1,000,000 for corporate bodies and prison terms for individuals. Employment quota Mandates all public organizations to reserve at least 5% of all employment opportunities for persons with disabilities.

Fr. John Damian Adizie, PGB

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Building Accessibility requires public buildings, walkways, and vehicles to be modified with-in a transitional period to allow easy access for people with physical impairments. Established the National Commission for Persons with Disabilities to oversee education, healthcare, and civil rights enforcement.

The National Commission for Persons with Disabilities (NCPWD) is a federal agency established by the Government of Nigeria to eliminate discrimination and safeguard the rights of over 35 million Nigerians living with disabilities. Formed in August 2020, the commission is tasked with implementing the provisions of the Discrimination Against Persons with Disabilities (Prohibi-

tion) Act of 2018. The agency operates under the supervision of the Federal Ministry of Humanitarian Affairs, Disaster Management and Social Development.

As we celebrate this year's National Disability Independence Day we wish to use this medium to Highlight the benefits of integrating individuals with disabilities into every part of political, social, economic, and cultural life. And we wish to remind persons with disabilities that even if the whole world rejects you, you should never reject yourself and moreover, there is ability in disability. (Follow: Apostle of Divine Mercy @ Tiktok.com and Altar of Divine Mercy Eucharistic Adoration @ facebook and YouTube.com)

Revival Or Entertainment?

There was a time when the church in Nigeria trembled under the weight of revival. Men travelled long distances, not because a famous preacher was advertised, but because they heard that God was visiting a place. Congregations gathered with broken hearts. Posters and banners adorned every street, processions were significant. Sinners wept openly. Altars became rivers of repentance. Prayer meetings overflowed. The fear of God rested upon communities, and lives were transformed without sophisticated publicity. The evidence of revival was not excitement alone. It was holiness, righteousness, restitution, and a burning passion for Christ.

Today, the landscape is changing rapidly. The contemporary church appears to be standing at a dangerous precipice, crossroads where revival is gradually being replaced by entertainment. Many assemblies have become masters of production, yet strangers to divine visitation. Lights have become brighter, sound systems louder, stages more attractive, and programmes more elaborate, but the question remains, where is the brokenness that

once produced genuine revival?

Entertainment appeals to the senses. Revival convicts the soul. Entertainment excites the emotions. Revival transforms the heart. Entertainment attracts spectators. Revival raises disciples. The tragedy of our generation is that many believers can no longer distinguish between emotional excitement and spiritual awakening. They mistake applause for anointing, noise for power, and large crowds for divine approval.

The Nigerian church has become increasingly competitive and commercialised. Ministries compete for visibility, followers, online influence, and larger auditoriums. Sermons are carefully designed to hold attention, but not necessarily to provoke repentance. Worship is sometimes choreographed more for performance than for the presence of God. The sanctuary is gradually becoming a theatre where excellence is celebrated, while brokenness before God is quietly disappearing.

This is not an argument against excellence. God deserves our best. He deserves beautiful worship, organised

services, and effective communication. Yet excellence without the Holy Spirit produces polished emptiness. A perfectly organised service cannot replace one genuine move of God. The church must never become so professional that it loses its dependence upon heaven.

One of the greatest casualties of this shift is the prayer altar. Many churches now spend more hours rehearsing music than seeking God. Workers receive technical training but little spiritual preparation. Ministers become skilled communicators while neglecting the secret place. The result is a generation that knows how to perform ministry without carrying spiritual authority.

The consequences are visible across our nation. Churches continue to multiply, yet corruption multiplies. Religious gatherings increase, yet violence spreads. We produce more conferences, yet fewer transformed communities. We celebrate church growth while the moral foundations of society continue to weaken. Something is fundamentally wrong when the church grows numerically but

THE APOSTOLIC TOWN CRIER

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loses its prophetic influence.

The early church possessed none of the advantages we enjoy today. They had no sophisticated auditoriums, no digital platforms, and no elaborate productions. Yet kingdoms trembled because heaven confirmed their message with power. They turned cities upside down because they had first allowed God to turn their own hearts upside down.

Young people across Nigeria are desperately searching for authenticity. They are tired of empty religious performances. They want to encounter a God who still heals, delivers, restores, convicts, and transforms lives. They are looking for churches where truth is preached without compromise, where holiness is honoured, and where prayer is more important than popularity.

The church must therefore examine itself honestly. Have we become

entertainers instead of intercessors? Have we become performers instead of proclaimers? Have we become experts in attracting crowds while failing to prepare souls for eternity? These are uncomfortable questions, but they are questions that heaven is asking.

Revival has never been manufactured by technology, advertising, or human ingenuity. Revival is born upon the altar of repentance. It begins when preachers weep before they preach, when believers hunger more for God's presence than for public recognition, and when the church chooses holiness above popularity.

Nigeria does not need another season of religious entertainment. Nigeria needs another visitation from God. Until the church longs more for His presence than for applause, revival will remain a memory instead of becoming our present reality.

What's Wrong With Getting Pregnant Before Marriage?

Adanna is pregnant and about to get married but those close to her are frowning at her decision to become pregnant before the wedding. From the look of things, she may not get to have the church wedding of her dreams because she is expecting. Her pastor has refused to conduct their wedding, while some family members have made her feel as though she has committed a grievous sin. She now wants to know if it is really wrong to get pregnant before the wedding.

"I am currently pregnant, and my wedding is in September. My baby bump is not obvious yet but my body has already started changing. The people around me know I'm pregnant, and you know how quickly this kind of news spreads. My parents are devoted members of the Lord's Chosen Church. I didn't tell them myself because I think they heard it from my aunt. Instead of being happy, they are more concerned about what people in their church will say. They want us to move the wedding date closer before my pregnancy becomes obvious. They are acting as if I have committed a terrible sin. My father is more relaxed about it. He said as long as the man is ready to marry me, that

is all that matters. But my mother keeps giving me long lectures, asking why I couldn't wait until after the wedding before getting pregnant. To make matters worse, my pastor said he can only conduct a church blessing and not a proper wedding. According to him, after the blessing we can go ahead with our reception, but there will be no normal wedding ceremony or church protocols. He said it should serve as a warning to other couples that if they get pregnant before marriage, that is the kind of ceremony they should expect. As I write this, I feel really sad. The only thing keeping me strong is my husband-to-be. We had our traditional marriage last week, and he told me that even if we don't do any other ceremony, that alone is enough for him. Still, I have always dreamed of wearing a white wedding gown. He keeps encouraging me and says we will find a way to make it happen. Apart from my mother and my pastor, everyone else has been happy for me. In fact, they treat me with so much care. They don't want me to stress myself, and some of my family members have even volunteered to help with shopping and other wedding preparations.

"So, I want to ask: is it really wrong to get pregnant before your wedding? The pregnancy was not an accident. For almost a year, we had been trying to conceive without success. I wasn't taking contraceptive pills because we intentionally wanted to see if I could get pregnant before the wedding. We both went for medical tests and found out that I had an infection and hormonal imbalance. My fiancé also had an infection that needed treatment. That experience scared him. He insisted that he wanted us to be sure we could have children before getting married. We both took our medications, kept trying, and after several months, I finally became pregnant. I am genuinely happy about my pregnancy, but my mother's constant comments and disappointment are beginning to make me question myself."

Dear Adanna, You cannot control how people react to a situation because everyone is entitled to their own opinion. The important thing is that both of you are doing the right thing by getting married. With time, everyone will adjust and move on. As for the church, every denomination

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has its expectations and moral standards for its members. When someone falls short of those expectations, there are usually consequences. Your pastor is simply trying to use your situation as an example to discourage others from doing the same. I believe that deep down, he is genuinely happy that both of you have chosen to make things right. If you ask me, I would say that God has not made anyone the judge of another person. So, no, I don't believe you are wrong. Focus on your upcoming wedding, surround yourself with positive people, stay away from negative energy, and enjoy this beautiful season of your life. You are doing well.

Hello readers, thanks for reading through. You can inbox your opinions or share your own experiences.

THE LITERARY ORBIT

VAMBA SHERIF

The first time I read Yambo Ouologuem's novel, *Bound to Violence*, I was shocked by the fury and seeming lack of restraint with which he wrote the story. Yet at the same time, his inventive style struck a chord with me, although I could not immediately explain why. I discovered the novel by chance at an antiquarian bookshop in Eindhoven, where I was living after my arrival in the Netherlands as a refugee fleeing the First Gulf War in Kuwait. The novel was tucked among books that had nothing to do with Africa, lined up alphabetically in a row as could be expected in bookstores or libraries. It was at that antiquarian bookshop that I encountered this book written by a man with a name that sounded Nigerian at first. The cover of the English translation was eye-catching: it was black with an image of a carved wooden mask impaled by a spear. The subtitle was noteworthy and revealing: *A savage, panoramic novel of Black Africa*.

I had previously thought that I knew the majority of novels by writers from Africa. I had grown up with, among others, Heinemann's African Writers Series, which began with the publication of the seminal *Things Fall Apart* by Chinua Achebe, who became the first editor of the series. I had read Heinemann masterpieces including works by Sembene Ousmane and Ngugi wa Thiong'o, and the only novel by Cheik Hamidou Kane, *Ambiguous Adventure* (1961), one of my all-time favorites. But I had never heard of this particular writer. Who was Yambo Ouologuem? Despite the discovery, the intriguing image on the cover, and the provocative subtitle—an emerging author such as myself was always in search of the new and unknown in literature—I approached the book with trepidation. My fear was that—just as in other books about Africa written mostly but not exclusively by Western writers—I'd find in this a story that would only perpetuate stereotypical depictions of Africa. A story that justifies colonialism, the looting of an entire continent, slavery, and other iniquities. And in fact, Ouologuem's work, with its portrayals of profuse violence and devastating wars, with its profanities, did appear to live up to my frightened expectations—which caused me to stop reading, abruptly, after my first attempt. Still, the novel would not let go of me. There was something about the work that tempted me to overcome my initial resistance, set aside my assumptions, give the book a chance, and immerse myself in the story.

One day, I adjudged myself ready for this reading experience, open to whatever it would bring. I picked up the novel again and started to read. A unique, almost overwhelming experience. I tumbled through the world of the author; every page and every paragraph presenting me with a deluge of stunning images, each one more astonishing than the last. Violence was juxtaposed with unparalleled beauty; an original image was followed by an even more unusual one. As if the writer were on a mission to compel me and the world to acknowledge his genius, to share in his fury, resentment, love, bewilderment.

I read about an African empire, Nakem, and its dynasty of ruthless and devious rulers, the Saifs, who employed every means to hold onto power from their rise in the thirteenth century to their fall in the twentieth. I had something unique here in my hands, I thought. Like any writer confronted with a formidable work, first a huge

In Search Of Ouologuem

My journey—on the surface, an attempt to trace my heritage—had in fact been driven all along by a deep longing to meet the man and hear his story.



Yambo

sense of admiration came over me, followed by profound jealousy. But more beautiful than all of this was the wonderful feeling that, thanks to my curiosity about the marvels of literature, I had somehow discovered this work. Ouologuem became my writer. There was that feeling that the author is addressing his words exclusively to you, that he is entrusting you with his secrets, love, anger, and sense of wonder. The Senegalese novelist Mohamed Mbougar Sarr must have had the same feeling when he read Ouologuem for the first time, which then birthed his Goncourt Prize-winning novel *The Most Secret Memory of Men*. In Sarr's 2021 novel, a Senegalese writer, Diégane Latyr Faye, goes in search of T.C. Elimane, an elusive compatriot whose book had been celebrated in an earlier time only to be undone by controversy and disgrace, and who subsequently disappeared into a "chosen, radical exile".

Speaking of wonder, here is Ouologuem describing the love scene between Tambira and Kassoumi, two of the characters in *Bound to Violence*. Listen to this song:

"The leaves murmured as a light breeze brushed over them; naked in the tall grass, they mingled their sighs in consent. Transfigured and half delirious, conscious of nothing but their possession of each other, of their profound penetration, they lay enlaced, saturated with the mingling of their bodies, the drunkenness of their movements, raving, panting, tense from head to foot with passionate expectation. The woman carried the man as the sea carries a ship, with a light rocking motion, which rises and falls, barely suggesting the violence below. In the course of their voyage they sobbed and murmured; their movements accelerated, generating an unbearable force. The man groaned, he allowed his weapon to go faster, deeper, stronger between the woman's thighs. The venom spurted; and suddenly they felt suffocated, on the point of explosion of death – an instant of intolerable joy, chaste and wanton – terrifying. They awoke from it vibrant, maddened, silent; weary and drained, with a humming in their ears, sated, obsessed, for they still felt possessed one by the other."

Apart from the exuberance of the writing, Ouologuem did something

unheard of in African literature. Born and raised in the predominantly Muslim country of Mali, Ouologuem had foregrounded a given that many people in West Africa, if not in the entire continent, live with: the presence of Jewish people in society, and of Jewish clans who are a centuries-long part of the African reality. In my family on my mother's side, the Dukulys, members claim to be direct descendants of Jacob. Ouologuem no doubt grew up with stories of the Jewish presence in Africa, and these must have inspired him to write about an African-Jewish dynasty that ruled over the fictional kingdom of Nakem-Ziuko. The name sounded mythical, like music in my ears.

Here is the author telling us about that dynasty:

"The Lord – Holy is His Name! – showed us the mercy of bringing forth,

The first time I read Yambo Ouologuem's novel, *Bound to Violence*, I was shocked by the fury and seeming lack of restraint with which he wrote the story.

at the beginning of the black Nakem Empire, one illustrious man, our ancestor the black Jew Abraham al-Heit, born of a black father and of an Oriental Jewess from Kenana (Canaan), descended from Jews of Cyrenaica and Tuat; it is believed that she was carried to Nakem by a secondary migration that followed the itinerary of Cornelius Balbus."

Literature has a universal power of expression, and the work of one author can influence that of another, as is the case with *Bound to Violence* and *The Most Secret Memory of Men*. Indeed, the whole history of literature is the

attempt by one author to respond to the work of another. That's why the answer given by the African American writer Ralph Wiley to a question from Saul Bellow was so telling. "Who is the Tolstoy of the Zulus?" Bellow asked. "Tolstoy is the Tolstoy of the Zulus. Unless you find a profit in fencing off universal properties of mankind into exclusive tribal ownership," Wiley replied. It being true that literature belongs to us all, Ouologuem was prepared to fully leverage that freedom by making use of many different influences in his work, as if he felt at home in the literature of any time and place. By exploring Jewish mythology, which was part of his reality, the writer was also indicating that he was influenced by Jewish tradition and writers, among many other influences, foremost being his African tradition.

But it was exactly for this interconnective approach—this inclusion of many literatures in his work, the liberty he took with these influences—that he was accused of plagiarism. The accusation came three years after the publication of the novel and immediately after the English translation in 1971. The response of the literary world was swift and decisive. The man who had appeared on various media outlets in Europe and America, and who was feted and heralded as the future of African literature, had turned out to be a fraud, according to the accusation—a plagiarist masquerading as an intellectual. *Bound to Violence* was promptly pulled off the shelves across Europe and America. The allegations were that Ouologuem had taken, verbatim, passages from Maupassant, the Bible and the Quran; and from many other writers, including André Schwarz-Bart's *The last of the Just*, and Graham Greene's *It's a Battlefield*. Doors were shut in Ouologuem's face; he was shunned by the very public he had impressed and shocked with his prose. Every attempt by the writer to explain himself failed. In his defense—he had to say something—he reportedly said that he had used quotation marks around the contentious passages, so that the reader would know that they did not belong to him. He might have claimed that the passages he used from other writers and weaved into his own work were an attempt to play with influences—a new way of writing. But no one was listening. The damage had

been done, and it was final.

Unique works of literature trigger deep amazement, and some suspicion: is this the work of a single mind? This must have been especially so in the case of a young black man who exhibited arrogance and confidence on every page. Ouologuem was not yet thirty when he authored his remarkable novel. No doubt, some felt that something did not add up and that there were things concealed from critics and readers pertaining to his work—a secret, a scandal. Another work by a gifted African writer was also a source of much controversy: *The Radiance of the King*, by Camara Laye. The Guinean faced accusations that he was not the real author of the 1954 novel, supposedly because the work was too singular for someone of Laye's background and education. Perhaps part of the negative responses to these two writers had to do with the period, and the prejudice regarding achievements by people who had endured a history of colonial subjugation and slavery.

But these examples, especially in Ouologuem's case, betray a failure of the literary establishment: the rush, sometimes, to erase or silence a writer who does not conform to established norms. A writer who does away with these norms, who sidesteps or crushes them underfoot, is bound to be misunderstood or punished for these bold transgressions. And if such a writer happens to come from among the formerly colonized—from a world that's often presented in a negative framing—the punishment is severe. And few have been as misunderstood as Ouologuem. Many in his African tradition failed to understand him. Here was a writer who, in biting satires, seemed to mock the efforts of African intellectuals and artists who, faced with blatant racism in the West, fell back on the only option left to them. They took pride in their histories, which had been dismissed as absent or bereft of great deeds; and took pride in the color of their skin (denigrated or undervalued next to European beauty standards). Thus the Négritude Movement was born. Its founders, the Nardal sisters Paulette and Jeanne, Léopold Sédar Senghor, Léon Damas and Aimé Césaire, sang the African past into life.

Continues in GUERNICA (www.guernicacamag.com), September 17, 2025.

THE LITERARY ORBIT

APRIL DÁVILA

Let's be honest about something: the fact that writing is hard has nothing to do with how talented you are, how many ideas you have, or how much you want to have finished your novel. Writing is hard because your human brain, the one that's been running and updating the biological human survival software for roughly 200,000 years, is genuinely convinced that putting words on a page might kill you.

This is not a metaphor.

Every time you sit down to write, you're doing something your brain registers as socially risky. Translating private thoughts into language means exposing yourself to judgment and for most of human history, judgment wasn't just uncomfortable, it was dangerous. Research done by Naomi I. Eisenberger in 2004 explored how our brains evolved to fear social pain. Getting rejected by the group meant you didn't eat. Being humiliated in front of the clan meant you might not make it through winter.

Your nervous system remembers all of this, even now, as you try to write your next chapter. The brain's job is to keep you alive, so it does what it does best: it spots the threat and steers you away from it.

Which is why, the moment you sit down to write a difficult scene, you suddenly realize you need to reorganize your sock drawer, or walk the dog, or replace your windshield wipers. Anything but write.

Now consider that sitting down to write requires a great deal of focus, so you're also working against your brain's natural tendency to daydream, ruminate, and spiral. The regions of the brain involved in this kind of mental goofing off are called the Default Mode Network, a term coined by Marcus Raichle. For writers, undirected mental energy can (ideally) be a source of creativity, but left to its own devices, the mind does not naturally drift toward gratitude and wonder. It gravitates toward threat. Which brings us to one more biological reality that makes writing hard: negativity bias.

Your brain is specifically wired to give more weight to the bad stuff than the good. Social psychologist Roy F. Baumeister talked about this in his paper "Bad is Stronger than Good." An ancestor who forgot about the beautiful flowers by the lake? Fine. An ancestor who forgot about the lion down by the lake? Well, they're likely not an ancestor, as they probably didn't live long enough to reproduce. Giving our attention to the potentially painful or fatal has helped us, as a species, to survive as long as we have.

What's more, it's not just external negative factors that our brain hangs onto. We have a remarkable ability to remember and re-live emotional pain. A study done by Zhansheng Chen in 2008 showed that social pain is remembered more intensely than physical pain. This explains why you can remember the time you fractured your arm without actually reliving the throbbing discomfort, but if you reminisce on a broken heart, there might still be tears. All of which circles us back around to the reality that our brain sees writing as quietly dangerous.

So here we all are, sitting down to write with brains that are actively scanning for danger; absolutely certain that the sentence we just typed is terrible, and pretty sure it will be the end of us.

None of this is pathology. It's all just part of being human.

Here's the good news: once you understand why your brain responds to writing the way it does, you can

Why Writing Feels So Hard (And How To Make It Easier)

April Dávila on the Neuroscience Behind Writer's Block and What We Can Do to Conquer It



April Dávila

train your mind to work with you, not against you. With a little practice you can learn to recognize your subconscious responses to perceived threats, consciously remind yourself that you can do hard things, then get on with the writing. So how do we do that?

As a writing coach, the practice I invite all of my clients to try is called Insight Meditation, and before you dismiss this as woo and click away, hear me out. It's a remarkably simple practice and it will make a world of difference in your writing life. All you have to do is sit comfortably, close your eyes if you'd like, and choose something to rest your attention on (your breath, the sounds in the room, a mental countdown from ten to zero). We call this the anchor. Then you just notice when your mind wanders, which it will, constantly. When you realize that it's wandered, you let the thought go and come back to your anchor. That's it. That's the whole practice. (If you'd like some support in giving this a try, you can check out a free collection of meditations I've created just for writers at ScribblingBuddha.com.)

Every time you dismiss a distraction and return to your anchor, you're building the mental "muscle" of focus. Scientists are still researching the specific connection between focus and creative flow, but anecdotally, nurturing focus seems to be the first step in dropping into that wonderful, coveted mental state where the words come easily, the hours disappear, and your inner critic goes quiet. Even though it can sometimes feel like magic, flow is a predictable response to the right conditions.

It's science.

Back in 1990, Hungarian-American psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi wrote the book *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience* in which he talked about his research around the experience of "flow." He used that word precisely because it came up over and over again when he spoke to artists, athletes

they knew exactly what to do next at any given moment and that they felt a great sense of calm and ease, even while doing something that was demonstrably difficult.

In his continued research, and specifically in his work with Jeanne Nakamura in 2002, Csikszentmihalyi theorized that the human brain has finite processing power of about 120 bits per second. That's literally about a million times slower than the computer you're reading this on. And your puny human processing power gets used up quickly. You use about half of it just listening to someone talk.

Now consider that focusing on a challenging task (like writing) aggressively sucks up processing power and as it does, your brain simply doesn't have the ability to do all the things it usually does behind the scenes. Keeping track of time is one of the first things to go. Your brain knows that's not super important, so as excess processing power runs low, your inner clock winds down for a bit. Pretty quickly after that, you run out of neural processing power to maintain the internal yapping of your inner critic. Get focused enough and the part of your brain that is in charge of keeping track of the boundaries of your physical body start to diminish, which leads to a sense of expansiveness and connectedness. This degradation of more complex brain functions is what neuroscientists call transient hypofrontality, a phrase coined by Dr. Arne Dietrich. (You can watch his TEDx talk about it here.)

You may have experienced tran-

sient hypofrontality through the use of a drug like LSD or psilocybin. With chemical assistance the brain can slam pretty hard into transient hypofrontality, which makes you pretty useless for anything but staring at the stars in awe. But a less aggressive dip into this mental state (through the practice of meditation, for instance), can land you into a more gentle (and instantly reversible) altered state of mind wherein much of the activity of the prefrontal cortex is temporarily offline, but you can still follow a thought. In this state, you experience the benefits of decreased self-criticism and increased creativity (aka flow).

The best part? You can train yourself to nurture this state of mind and drop into a state of creative flow at will. Not occasionally, not when the conditions align, but reliably, on purpose, every time you sit down to write. It's as simple as sitting still for 10 minutes, right before you begin your writing.

When you practice mindfulness meditation before writing, then move directly from your meditation into your work, you carry that heightened state of focus right to the page. Errant thoughts will still arise (the laundry, the email, the certainty that your opening scene is a disaster) but in a mindful state, those thoughts are observable. You can notice them, recognize them for what they are (your brain doing its overprotective thing), and let them go. Then keep writing.

Over time, this practice changes something fundamental. Mindfulness doesn't eliminate fear or self-doubt, I want to be honest about that. What it does is change your relationship to those experiences. The urge to abandon your work starts to feel less like a command and more like background noise. The inner critic becomes less like an authority figure and more like that one colleague who sends too many emails. You don't have to respond.

I can't promise this practice will make writing effortless, but I can say with certainty that if you establish a regular meditation practice, you will write more and suffer less.

You will begin to see that you can feel doubt and keep writing. You can feel vulnerability and keep writing. You can feel fear and keep writing. The goal isn't to reach some mythological place where you're above it all. Every serious writer I know has to negotiate with resistance from time to time, but when you can recognize the resistance as ordinary, as the utterly common human response to doing something challenging, and write anyway? Well, that changes everything.

April Dávila

April Dávila is an award-winning author, speaker, and writing coach. Publishers Weekly called her debut novel, *142 Ostriches*, a "vivid, uplifting debut" and the book went on to win the WILLA Award for Women Writing the West. Writer's Digest listed her blog (at aprildavila.com) as one of the Best 101 Websites for Writers and she is the creator of the Sit Write Here writing coaching program, helping writers quiet their inner critics, overcome writer's block, and edit more effectively. Her new book, *Sit Write Here: 6 Mindfulness Practices to Help you Write More and Suffer Less* is out this summer from St. Martin's Essentials.

Source: LITERARYHUB (<https://lithub.com/>), July 22, 2026.

Undirected mental energy can (ideally) be a source of creativity, but left to its own devices, the mind does not naturally drift toward gratitude and wonder. It gravitates toward threat.

and other people engaged in demanding, creative work. What he found was that flow happened when the skill level of the individual was perfectly balanced with the difficulty of the task at hand. When the artist or athlete was highly focused on meeting the challenge, time seemed to stretch. They reported that

Osun Guber: Averting Political Violence

EJIKEME OMENAZU

Osun State has been at a boiling point over the August 15 governorship elections. Palpable tension has been in the state for some months now over the coming governorship election.

Background To Current Situation

Indeed there has been tension in the state since the last local government election, which was then won by the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP), Governor Ademola Adeleke's former political party. But, the former leaders of the local governments, who are of the All Progressives Congress (APC), the party that controls the Federal Government, held to their positions, even as the winners of the local government elections (PDP members) were not allowed access to the funds following an alleged intervention by the Attorney General of the Federation.

Since then, there has been no love lost between Governor Adeleke and the APC stalwarts in the state who are reportedly backed by Almighty the Federal might.

Adeleke's Move To Accord Party

Then, following the split of the PDP and Governor Adeleke jumped ship and resolved to pursue his second term dream under the Accord Party. Adeleke, expectedly, converted the PDP's structure in the state to Accord Party, his new party. His entrant into the party reinvigorated the Accord Party in the state as a party to beat in the Osun State. Interestingly, following the split of the PDP nationwide and the conversion of the party's structure to Accord Party, PDP now has no candidate in the coming governorship election, while the Accord Party inherited the hostilities between the APC and PDP.

Candidates In The Election

Governor Adeleke will square up against Hon. Bola Oyebamiji, the candidate of the All Progressives Congress (APC) in the August 15 governorship election.

According to a list released by the independent National Electoral Commission (INEC), 14 political parties will be taking part in the election.

According to the document published by INEC, Governor Adeleke will contest the election on the Accord Party's platform, with Kola Adewusu as his running mate.

Olanrewaju Farinloye, is the governorship candidate of the Action Alliance (AA), while Fadahunsi Olaniyi is listed as the deputy governorship candidate.

For the African Action Congress (AAC), Esan Olajide will contest as its governorship candidate, with Bello Yekeen as running mate.

The African Democratic Congress (ADC) also has Salaam Folasayo as its governorship candidate and Agiri Temitope as the deputy governorship candidate.

For the Action Democratic Party (ADP), Adeagbo Yemisi is the governorship candidate, and Atanda Babatunde is listed as the deputy governorship candidate.

Mrs Adeagbo is the only female governorship candidate on the list. Aside from her, the only other woman among the candidates is Mrs Agiri, who is running as deputy governorship candidate on the platform of the African Democratic Congress (ADC).

The list also shows Bola Oyebamiji as the governorship candidate of the All Progressives Congress (APC). Others are: All Progressives Grand Alliance (APGA), Allied Peoples Movement (APM), Action Peoples Party (APP), Boot Party (BP), New Nigeria Peoples Party (NNPP), Peoples Redemption Party (PRP), Young Progressive Party (YPP), and Zenith Labour Party (ZLP).

Battle For Supremacy

Thus a stage was set for the battle for suprem-



Adeleke



Oyebamiji

Thus a stage was set for the battle for supremacy between the Accord Party and the APC, which is hell bent on snatching the state from the grip of Governor Ademola Adeleke. This has led to attacks by political warlords in the state. So far, several people have lost their lives, many injured by political thugs. Political campaign material and party properties, including party offices, party flags and billboards, especially those belonging to Accord Party have been destroyed

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Osun Police Boss In Adeleke's Black Book

However, the police in the state have been accused of looking the other way while mayhem continued to reign in the state between the Accord Party and APC stalwarts. The Osun State Commissioner of Police (CP), Ibrahim Gotan, has been accused of being used by the Federal backed APC to undermine the influence and authority of Governor Adeleke.

Already, the governor has asked Police Inspector General, Olatunji Disu, to redeploy CP Gotan and bring in another officer who is apolitical to man the Osun Police Command during this troubled time. So far, IGP Disu is yet to fulfill the wish of the governor.

IGP Disu's recent visit to Osun State did not produce the needed peace as it ended up being a platform for blame games between the APC and Accord Party, over who has been behind the political thuggery in the state.

Attempt To Hijack Osun NURTW

Last Monday, matters came to a head when an attempt was made to hijack the state's chapter of the National Union of Road Transport

Workers (NURTW).

The action stemmed from the plot to ensure that those who will be used to transport electoral materials during the August 15 elections are under the whims and caprices of a political party.

This led to shootings at the motor parts and garages on Osun State, during which many were believed to have been injured. The plot to take over the executives of the NURTW stems from the fact that the union members were always hired by the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) to carry election materials and electoral officers during elections.

As one of the media houses reported the action: "Attempt by factions of the National Union of Roads Transport Workers (NURTW), Osun State chapter to cause mayhem in Osogbo, on Monday through forceful takeover of motor parks, have been thwarted by the operatives of Osun State Police Command:

"Suspected thugs loyal to the two factional chairmen, namely Nurudeen Alowonle and Ka-zeem Oyewale, popularly known as Asiri Eniba, engaged each other in a gun duel, which caused tension and disruption of commercial activities around Old Garage area of Osogbo as traders and passerby scamped to safety.

"However, timely intervention of Police quelled the clashes as the hoodlums were dispersed by the security agents, who fired several warning shots to restore normalcy.

"This was just as Governor Ademola Adeleke, in a statement by his spokesperson, Olawale, condemned the violence, called on the security agencies to arrest Asiri Eniba and other alleged All Progressives Congress (APC) thugs, who he claimed led the attacks on motor parks.

"According to the statement, "The governor condemned the repeated shootings and scarring of innocent residents at old garage and motor parks at Osogbo and decried a situation where police allegedly provided cover for Asiri Eniba and other APC thugs involved in the disruption of public peace.

"I have personally called the attention of the Inspector General of Police and other service chiefs to these open attacks on public peace. I demand immediate arrest of Asiri Eniba for this open defiance of public security act."

"The governor who questioned what manner of protest will target innocent commuters at motor parks said his administration may review its support for NURTW at Osun motor parks."

A Lawyer's Passionate Appeal To Stakeholders

Moved by the need to ensure a peaceful governorship election on August 15, 2026, an Osun State-born human rights lawyer, Barrister Olalekan Festus Ojo, has written an open letter to all political stakeholders in the state.

In the open letter, which he dispatched to Sunday Independent, he said he was concerned that Osun State is becoming a theatre of war because of the coming off-season governorship election.

Barrister Ojo, in the letter which touches all the stakeholders, urged the Osun political warlords to sheath their swords as the August 15 governorship election draws nearer.

Barrister Ojo, a promoter of social justice, in the letter maintained that Osun State must not be allowed to become a killing field, but a beacon.

Ojo, Managing Partner, Platinum & Taylor Hill LP, one of the nation's major law firms, in the open letter, stressed the imperative of a peaceful Osun State.

He said he wrote the letter, as an open statement with the utmost urgency, driven by genuine alarm at the deteriorating pre-election security situation in Osun State and by his solemn duty as a legal practitioner, a democrat, and a proud son of Osun State to speak truth without fear, when the lives of his people and the integrity of their democratic rights are threatened.

Ojo stated: "The forthcoming Osun State governorship election is one of the most consequential electoral events on Nigeria's immediate political calendar.

"It must be conducted in an atmosphere of peace, freedom, and genuine democratic competition. What is currently unfolding in Osun State, targeted political killings, organised thuggery, destruction of opposition properties, and credible allegations of security force complicity, represents a direct and existential threat to that imperative. I

Politics

...Why Osun Should Not Be Turned Into Killing Field



Disu



Amupitan



Ojo

CONTINUED FROM P.17 →

will not be silent.

"I address myself first and most forcefully to the political actors, parties, candidates, financiers, and party officials, on all sides of the Osun State governorship contest."

Ojo stated that the blood of Aderugba and every other Nigerian killed or maimed in Osun State's pre-election violence cries out for justice and demands that every political actor in this state make an immediate, unconditional, and public commitment to non-violence.

According to him, "No governorship seat, no political office in the entirety of this republic, is worth a single Nigerian life."

"Any politician, party official, or financier, who deploys, arms, funds, or directs thugs to intimidate, attack, or murder political opponents or innocent citizens are committing a grievous criminal offence under the Criminal Code Act, the Electoral Act 2026 and the Violence Against Persons (Prohibition) Act 2015. The law will find them. It must find them."

"I call on Governor Ademola Adeleke, as the Chief Security Officer of Osun State within the constitutional framework, to deploy every lawful instrument of government to protect all political actors, voters, and ordinary citizens regardless of their party affiliation. Democratic legitimacy cannot be claimed selectively."

"I equally call on all opposition candidates and their supporters to commit publicly and verifiably to peaceful conduct throughout the campaign and election period. Violence perpetrated in the name of any party or candidate is a crime, full stop."

"Party leaders at the national level, the APC National Chairman, the PDP National Chairman, and the leadership of every party fielding candidates in Osun State, must issue unambiguous directives to their state structures that electoral violence will not be tolerated, and that any member found to have sponsored or participated in violence will face immediate expulsion and criminal prosecution without the protection of party machinery."

Advice To INEC

Barrister Ojo also has some advice to the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC). He said the electoral umpire must place Osun State on its highest pre-election alert status with immediate effect.

According to him, the deteriorating security environment in Osun State is not merely a law enforcement matter; "it is a direct threat to the integrity of the electoral process that INEC is constitutionally mandated to conduct, protect, and defend."

"I call on INEC to deploy additional electoral officers to Osun State immediately to monitor the pre-election environment; establish a dedicated situation room for real-time tracking and documentation of electoral violence incidents and violations; publicly warn all political parties that evidence of sponsored violence will be considered in the assessment of their candidates' conduct;

engage with the security agencies at the highest level to demand proactive rather than reactive security deployment; and be unequivocal in its public communications that any election conducted under a climate of widespread intimidation and violence will not be certified as reflecting the free will of the Osun State electorate."

"INEC's credibility as an institution rests on its willingness to defend the integrity of the process it superintends. Osun State is a test of that credibility. INEC must not fail."

The Police Force, IGP

The lawyer took time to address the Nigerian Police Force and the The Inspector General Of Police (IGP).

He said: "I address the Inspector General of Police, IGP Olatunji Rilwan Disu, with the directness that this moment demands."

"The allegations of police complicity in the pre-election violence in Osun State, allegations that have been made publicly, specifically, and with supporting accounts from multiple credible sources, cannot be wished away or managed through press releases."

"They demand urgent, independent, and transparent investigation. The IGP must immediately redeploy the Osun State Commissioner of Police as called for by Governor Adeleke, and as demanded by the manifest failure of the current security architecture in the state to protect lives and property."

"A Commissioner of Police, who has lost the confidence of the host community, against whom credible allegations of partisan conduct exist, and under whose watch citizens are being killed with apparent impunity, cannot provide the neutral, professional security environment that a free and fair election requires."

"The replacement Commissioner of Police must be someone of demonstrated professional

integrity, with no political associations or loyalties to any of the contesting parties, and with a clear, public mandate to protect every voter, candidate, and observer in Osun State without fear or favour."

"I further call on the IGP to deploy a Special Electoral Security Task Force to Osun State comprising officers drafted from outside the state, operating under direct IGP oversight, and mandated to arrest and prosecute any person, regardless of political affiliation or social standing — found to be engaging in electoral violence or intimidation."

"The Police Act 2020 and Section 214 of the 1999 Constitution (as amended) place a non-negotiable obligation on the Nigeria Police Force to protect life and property."

"In Osun State today, that obligation is being visibly dishonoured. The IGP must restore it."

To The National Peace Committee

"I call with great urgency on the National Peace Committee, chaired by former Head of State, General Abdulsalami Abubakar, to intervene immediately and directly in the Osun State pre-election crisis."

"The National Peace Committee's interventions have historically contributed to de-escalating electoral tensions at the national level."

"The situation in Osun State demands that the same attention, urgency, and moral authority be brought to bear at the state level without delay."

"I specifically call on the National Peace Committee to convene an emergency peace summit bringing together all governorship candidates, party leaders, traditional rulers, religious leaders, and civil society representatives in Osun State; facilitate the signing of a binding Peace Accord by all candidates and their parties, with specific, enforceable commitments against violence, hate speech, and the deployment of thugs; establish a monitoring mechanism to track compliance with the Peace Accord through the election and results

period; and publicly call out any party or candidate found to be violating the terms of the Accord."

"The moral weight of the National Peace Committee is one of Nigeria's most valuable democratic assets. It must be deployed in Osun State now, before more blood is shed, not after."

To Yiaga Africa, Independent Election Observers

"I call on Yiaga Africa, the foremost domestic election observation organisation in Nigeria, and all accredited independent election observers, domestic and international, to immediately scale up their pre-election observation presence in Osun State."

"The pre-election period is not a passive waiting room for election day, it is itself a critical phase of the democratic process in which the conditions for a free and fair vote are either established or destroyed."

"What is happening in Osun State during this pre-election period is destroying those conditions in real time, and it must be documented, reported, and publicly disclosed with the rigour and courage that Yiaga Africa has consistently demonstrated in its electoral observation work."

"I specifically urge Yiaga Africa to deploy its Parallel Vote Tabulation and observation infrastructure to Osun State immediately; document all incidents of pre-election violence, intimidation, and security force misconduct with specificity and evidence; issue interim public reports on the pre-election environment without waiting for election day; engage directly with INEC, the police, and political parties on observed violations; and alert the international observer community, including the African Union, ECOWAS, the European Union, and the United States Embassy, to the security concerns in Osun State so that adequate international observation resources are mobilised."

"The presence of credible, vigilant, and vocal observers is itself a deterrent to electoral violence. Yiaga Africa's presence in Osun State at this moment is not optional, it is a democratic necessity."

Appeal To People Of Osun

"I conclude with a direct message to the people of Osun State, my people, the Omoluabi people whose cultural identity is rooted in honour, dignity, and the highest standards of human conduct."

"Do not allow your state to be defined by the violence of political thugs acting in the service of power-hungry politicians."

"Your vote is your power; your voice is your right, and your life is sacred and irreplaceable. No candidate, no party, and no political interest is worth your blood or your fear."

"I call on every stakeholder, political, institutional, civic, traditional, and religious, to rise to this moment with the moral courage it demands."

"The eyes of Nigeria and the world are on Osun State. Let what they see be the triumph of democracy over violence, of the people's will over the will of thugs, and of the rule of law over the rule of fear. Osun must not become a killing field. It must become a beacon."

I specifically call on the National Peace Committee to convene an emergency peace summit bringing together all governorship candidates, party leaders, traditional rulers, religious leaders, and civil society representatives in Osun State; facilitate the signing of a binding Peace Accord by all candidates and their parties, with specific, enforceable commitments against violence, hate speech, and the deployment of thugs; establish a monitoring mechanism to track compliance with the Peace Accord through the election and results period; and publicly call out any party or candidate found to be violating the terms of the Accord

Osun 2026: Oyebamiji's Momentum Ahead Of August 15

ANDREW UTULU

The APC flag bearer in the August 15, 2026 Osun off-cycle election, Asiawaju Munirudeen Bola Oyebamiji has embarked on an aggressive grassroots campaign anchored on policy proposals and a development agenda.

This has attracted endorsements from market associations, artisans, religious organisations, traditional institutions and community groups. SUNDAY INDEPENDENT examines Oyebamiji's campaign strategy, and the growing coalition of support that will swing votes to the APC in the election.

With less than one month to the August 15, 2026 governorship election in Osun State, political activities have intensified across the state as candidates make their final push to win the confidence of voters.

While the contest remains a straight battle between the ruling Accord Party led by Governor Ademola Adeleke and the opposition All Progressives Congress (APC), political observers say the race has entered a decisive phase where campaigns, endorsements and grassroots mobilisation may ultimately determine the outcome.

Among the developments attracting attention is what many within the APC describe as the growing momentum behind its governorship candidate, Asiawaju Munirudeen Bola Oyebamiji (AMBO).

Since emerging as the APC standard-bearer, the former Managing Director of the National Inland Waterways Authority (NIWA) has embarked on an extensive statewide campaign, visiting communities, traditional institutions, religious leaders, professional associations, market groups and artisans to market what he calls the Osun Prosperity Agenda.

Unlike campaigns dominated by personality attacks, Oyebamiji has consistently attempted to frame the election around governance, economic revival and institutional reforms. At virtually every campaign stop, he argues that Osun requires a new direction built on prudent management of resources, infrastructure renewal, job creation, improved education and healthcare delivery.

The APC candidate has repeatedly maintained that his aspiration is driven by a desire to reposition Osun as one of Nigeria's most economically viable states.

According to him, governance under his administration would focus on measurable outcomes rather than political rhetoric.

"My decision to contest for the governorship seat was deliberate and intentional. We have assembled a team of professionals to examine every critical sector of the economy with a view to making immediate interventions in power generation, education, healthcare delivery, agriculture, industrialisation and workers' welfare.

"Our objective is simple, to stimulate economic growth, at-



Oyebamiji

tract investments, create jobs and improve the quality of life of every resident of Osun State," he said.

Development-Centred Agenda

Throughout his campaign, Oyebamiji has identified electricity as one of the pillars of his economic blueprint, arguing that reliable power supply is fundamental to industrial development, small businesses and youth employment.

He has also promised to invest heavily in education through improved infrastructure, teacher development and enhanced learning outcomes, while pledging to strengthen the state's healthcare system by expanding access to quality medical services across urban and rural communities.

Agriculture occupies another strategic position in his campaign manifesto.

According to the APC candidate, modernising agriculture through mechanisation, value-chain development and access to finance will not only improve food security but also generate employment opportunities for thousands of young people.

Security also features prominently in his campaign.

He has consistently argued that sustainable economic growth cannot thrive in an environment where investors and residents do not feel safe.

Consequently, he has pledged to strengthen collaboration among security agencies, traditional institutions and community policing structures to improve security across the state.

Oyebamiji has equally promised to create an investor-friendly environment by simplifying government processes, supporting small and medium-scale enterprises and encouraging private

sector participation in infrastructure development.

"We will be fair, transparent and accountable. Government resources will be distributed equitably across all communities without discrimination.

"Our administration will be people-centred, development-driven and inclusive because every part of Osun deserves quality governance," he stated.

Building Political Capital Through Endorsements

Beyond articulating policy proposals, the APC candidate has continued to expand his political base through endorsements from influential groups and organisations across the state.

Political analysts note that while endorsements alone do not determine election outcomes, they often shape public perception, energise party supporters and strengthen grassroots mobilisation.

One of the most visible endorsements came from traders at the popular Igbonna Market in Osogbo.

Thousands of market men and women gathered at the market square to publicly identify with the APC candidate.

Speaking during the event, the Babaloja-General of Osun State, Chief David Iyiola, represented by the Otun Babaloja of Igbonna Market, Chief Muideen Ajao, and the market secretary, Mrs. Okunoye Temitope, said the traders were convinced that Oyebamiji possesses the experience and leadership qualities required to improve the state's economy.

"We are convinced that Oyebamiji has the competence, capacity and experience to transform Osun State.

"We believe his administration

will improve the welfare of traders, create a better business environment and restore economic prosperity.

"Our members across markets in Osun will mobilise massively in support of his candidature," the traders declared.

Religious Community Backs APC Candidate

The Muslim community has also expressed confidence in Oyebamiji.

President of the Osun State Muslim Community, Alhaji Mustapha Olawuyi, described the APC candidate as a devout Muslim whose humanitarian activities have positively impacted many people over the years.

"Oyebamiji is known to us as a committed Muslim whose contributions to the propagation of Islam, support for the Muslim Ummah and humanitarian causes cannot be quantified," Olawuyi said.

He, however, maintained that the organisation remained non-partisan despite acknowledging Oyebamiji's longstanding relationship with the Muslim community.

Support from Artisans

The Nigerian Automobile Technicians Association (NATA), Osun State chapter, also endorsed the APC candidate.

According to the association, Oyebamiji's economic vision places strong emphasis on vocational skills, entrepreneurship and technical development, areas they believe are essential for reducing unemployment and empowering artisans.

The association expressed confidence that an AMBO administration would create policies favourable to skilled workers and small businesses.

Traditional Institutions Join the Movement

Another significant boost to the APC campaign came from the endorsement of the three major ruling houses in Osogbo-Sogbode, Matanmi and Lahanmi.

Leaders of the ruling houses said they reached the decision after consultations among stakeholders concerned about the future of Osogbo.

Speaking on behalf of the ruling houses, Prince Agboola, Prince Yekini Oyeniyi and Prince Tafa Olugbeja alleged that Osogbo had suffered political and developmental setbacks in recent years.

The traditional leaders also expressed concerns over boundary-related issues affecting the ancient town and called for leadership capable of protecting Osogbo's historical identity and accelerating development.

They pledged to mobilise support for the APC candidate during the August 15 election.

Cooperative Movement Throws Weight Behind AMBO

The Ere Ododo Muslim Cooperative Society, a non-interest cooperative organisation committed to poverty reduction and economic empowerment, also endorsed Oyebamiji.

Responding, the APC flag bearer said the cooperative's philosophy aligns with his economic agenda centred on inclusive growth, financial inclusion and community development.

"This endorsement is not merely symbolic. It demonstrates growing confidence in our collective vision to build a prosperous Osun where opportunities are available to everyone regardless of social status or location," he said.

Politics

Nigeria's Challenge Not Scarcity Of Resources But Quality Of Governance – Bolaji O. Akinyemi

How do you feel clocking 60?

Thank you. I believe the best way to answer that question is to begin with the philosophy upon which I have built my 60th birthday celebration. I was born in 1966, when Nigeria's life data painted a sobering picture. According to the World Bank and the United Nations Inter-agency Group for Child Mortality Estimation, Nigeria's under-five mortality rate in 1966 was approximately 281 deaths per 1,000 live births. In practical terms, more than one in every four Nigerian children died before reaching the age of five. Life expectancy at birth was only about 42 to 44 years. Looking at those statistics today, I recognize that my journey to 60 is first and foremost an act of God's mercy.

Yet my survival is not only a personal testimony; it also reminds us that progress is possible when nations invest in healthcare, education, public institutions and human development. Data is more than numbers. It tells the story of people's lives, their hopes and their opportunities.

That is why I have deliberately chosen not to celebrate my birthday in isolation. My 60th birthday is a platform for national reflection. If data tells the story of our lives, then we must honestly ask ourselves: What story is Nigeria's data telling today?

Turning 60 is not merely a celebration of age; it is a celebration of purpose. I see this season as an opportunity to move from success to significance. My greatest passion now is to invest my experience in nation-building, leadership development and mentoring younger generations who will inherit the Nigeria we are shaping today.

It is therefore fitting that I am presenting my book, 'Global Leadership Code: Donald J. Trump – A Case Study, alongside the inaugural National Citizens' Dialogue. Every milestone should create value for society. That is why this year's conversation is themed: 'Data Is Life: Government's Roles and the Citizens' Pacts'. My prayer is that every Nigerian will come to appreciate that when we respect data, we make better decisions; when we make better decisions, we build stronger institutions; and when institutions become stronger, the quality of life for our people improves.

You have been one of the voices speaking truth to power. How do you feel about the reactions of people in authority to critics?

Speaking truth to power has never been a comfortable assignment, but it is an indispensable responsibility in every democracy. History teaches us that societies make progress when leaders are willing to listen to honest counsel, even when it is uncomfortable. Unfortunately, many public officials still interpret constructive criticism as political hostility. I think that is a costly mistake. Criticism offered in good faith is not an attack on government; it is an investment in better governance. My interventions have never been driven by personal interests or partisan sentiments. They have always been guided by principles of justice, accountability and nation-building. Governments are temporary, but institutions are permanent. If we strengthen our institutions today, future generations will inherit a more stable and prosperous Nigeria. Leadership should never fear scrutiny. Rather, it should welcome in-

Dr Bolaji O. Akinyemi is several things in one. Apart from being a gospel Apostle, the Christian activist is a prolific writer. Dr. Akinyemi, is the Chairman, Board of Trustees (BoT), Project Victory Call Initiative, aka PVC Naija, and Convener, The Apostolic Roundtable (TAC), and the author of the book, 'Global Leadership Code: Donald J. Trump as a Case Study'. In this interview with **EJIKEME OMENAZU**, he speaks on his 60th birthday among crucial issues of national importance. Excerpt:



Akinyemi

formed criticism as an instrument of continuous improvement.

What is your take on the state of the nation currently?

Nigeria is passing through a difficult, but decisive period in its national journey. Economic pressures, insecurity, unemployment and declining confidence in public institutions have created genuine hardship for many citizens. Yet, I remain hopeful because I have always believed that nations do not change by accident. They change when visionary leadership meets responsible citizenship.

Our greatest challenge is not merely the scarcity of resources, but the quality of governance. We need institutions that are transparent, leaders who are accountable and citizens who are actively engaged in shaping public policy. This conviction inspired our 'Life's Data Advocacy initiative'. Evidence-based governance must replace guesswork in public administration. Reliable data should guide budgeting, security, education, healthcare and economic planning.

Nigeria possesses extraordinary human potential. If we combine visionary leadership with institutional reforms and informed citizen participation, I believe the future can be far brighter than our present realities.

As the nation gets ready for the 2027 general elections, what are your worries?

My greatest concern is that we may once again allow personalities to dominate the conversation while

neglecting policies and ideas. The 2027 elections should become a national conversation about the future we want to build rather than merely a contest over political offices. Nigerians deserve campaigns that present measurable solutions to insecurity, unemployment, education, healthcare, constitutional reform and economic growth.

Political parties must deepen internal democracy because democracy cannot flourish nationally if it is absent within the parties themselves. Citizens also have important responsibilities. We must reject vote-buying, violence and ethnic or religious manipulation. Our votes should reflect competence, character, capacity and integrity.

Often remind people that the highest office in any democracy is neither the President nor the Governor. The highest office is that of the Citizen. Once Nigerians embrace that truth, our democracy will become stronger and more accountable.

How do you see the way the courts, rather than political parties and democratic institutions, are shaping Nigeria's democracy?

The increasing role of the judiciary in determining political outcomes is largely a symptom of institutional weakness elsewhere. Political parties frequently fail to comply with their own constitutions, while internal disputes that should have been resolved administratively eventually find their way into the courts. The judiciary has an indispensable constitutional

responsibility, but courts should primarily interpret and uphold the law, rather than routinely determine political leadership. Our democratic institutions must become stronger. Political parties should respect due process, while INEC must continue to protect its independence and credibility. A mature democracy is one in which internal conflicts are resolved fairly within political institutions before judicial intervention becomes necessary.

Don't you think that the various controversial rulings of the courts are doing more harm than good to the polity and even confusing the political elite and INEC?

Public confidence in the judiciary depends not only on the quality of judgments but also on their consistency and predictability. When similar cases produce conflicting outcomes, uncertainty grows and confidence in the justice system declines. Political actors become confused, electoral institutions face implementation challenges and citizens begin to question whether justice is truly impartial.

Nigeria therefore requires continuous judicial reforms, timely resolution of electoral disputes and clearer constitutional provisions that minimise conflicting interpretations. Justice must not only be done; it must be seen to be fair, impartial and consistent. Predictability strengthens democracy because it reassures citizens that the rule of law, rather than individual discretion, remains the ultimate guide for resolving political disputes.

With the continued split in the PDP, don't you think the party risks losing its participation in the coming general elections?

Every political party that neglects unity, discipline and internal democracy places itself at serious electoral risk. The challenge before the PDP extends beyond winning elections. It must restore confidence among its members, rebuild public trust and demonstrate that it can offer Nigerians a credible alternative. Healthy democracies require vibrant opposition parties. Competition encourages innovation, strengthens accountability and improves governance.

The lessons from the PDP's current challenges should not be ignored by any political party. Internal injustice eventually produces external political consequences. Political victory is rarely sustained where fairness, transparency and discipline are absent. The future of every party depends on its willingness to place institutional integrity above individual ambitions.

Osun State has been enmeshed in crisis over the August 15 governorship election with reported killings, thuggery and destruction of campaign materials. What is your advice to stakeholders, including security agencies and INEC?

Every election should deepen democracy, not diminish our humanity. No political office is worth the life of a single Nigerian. I therefore appeal to all political parties, candidates and

supporters to conduct themselves with restraint and responsibility. Elections are temporary, but the relationships among our people must endure long after the votes have been counted. Security agencies must remain impartial, professional and proactive. They should protect every citizen equally without fear or favour while dealing decisively with those who sponsor or perpetrate violence. INEC must continue to uphold transparency, fairness and credibility throughout the electoral process. Public confidence in elections depends largely on the integrity of the electoral umpire.

Traditional rulers, religious leaders, civil society organisations and the media also have important responsibilities. They should consistently promote peace, discourage hate speech and encourage issue-based campaigns. The true winner of any democratic election should be the people. That victory is meaningful only when the process is peaceful, credible and accepted by all stakeholders.

What is your take on the ongoing moves towards the creation of State Police?

I have consistently supported the establishment of State Police as part of a broader constitutional restructuring of Nigeria. Our present policing structure places enormous responsibilities on a highly centralised system that cannot effectively respond to the security realities of such a large and diverse federation. However, State Police should never become instruments of political intimidation or persecution. Strong constitutional safeguards are essential. There should be independent oversight, transparent recruitment, professional training, sustainable funding and strict accountability mechanisms.

Technology must also become central to modern policing through intelligence gathering, surveillance systems, digital crime analysis and effective collaboration among all security agencies. If properly designed and responsibly managed, State Police will strengthen community policing, improve response times, enhance intelligence gathering and contribute significantly to safer communities across Nigeria.

What is your closing remarks?

Nigeria's future will not be determined solely by those who hold political office. It will be shaped by citizens who insist on accountability, leaders who choose service above personal ambition and institutions that consistently uphold justice and the rule of law. As I celebrate sixty years of God's faithfulness, my message to Nigerians is simple: never lose hope in our country. Nations are built by people who refuse to surrender to despair.

If we embrace integrity, evidence-based governance, institutional reforms and active citizenship, I believe Nigeria's greatest chapters are still ahead of us. Together, we can build a nation where leadership is earned through competence, sustained by character and ultimately measured by the lives it transforms.

Our greatest challenge is not merely the scarcity of resources, but the quality of governance. We need institutions that are transparent, leaders who are accountable and citizens who are actively engaged in shaping public policy. This conviction inspired our 'Life's Data Advocacy initiative'. Evidence-based governance must replace guesswork in public administration. Reliable data should guide budgeting, security, education, healthcare and economic planning

Nigeria Needs Reforms That Prioritise Production, Job Creation, Welfare – Udeze

Chief Barrister Kenneth Udeze is the National Chairman, Action Alliance (AA). In this interview with **EJIKEME OMENAZU**, he speaks on the 2027 general elections, involvement of the courts in the nation's politics, the discovery of a fake federal agency and the electoral violence in Osun State, among other crucial issues. Excerpt:

You tried to run for an elective position. What is the situation now? Are you still involved in the 2027 race?

Yes, I remain in the trenches. Leadership is service. While I focused on stabilising Action Alliance after the legal battles, we are now fully mobilising for 2027. I am consulting with stakeholders across the country. Whether I personally contest or not will depend on what the party and the people demand. The priority now is to field credible candidates who can rescue Nigeria at all levels.

What is your take on the state of the nation currently?

Nigeria is at a crossroads. The economy is biting hard, insecurity persists, and public trust in institutions is low. Nigerians are resilient, but resilience alone cannot feed families. We need urgent economic reforms that prioritise production, job creation, and welfare. The government must listen more and govern less by propaganda.

As the nation gets ready for the 2027 general elections, what are your worries?

My biggest worries are three. INEC's independence - it must resist pressure and obey court judgments. Security - elections cannot thrive where lives are not safe. Money politics - if we don't curb vote-buying, democracy will remain a bazaar. 2027 must be about ideas, not intimidation.

How do you see the way the courts, rather than the political parties and democratic institutions, are shaping the nation's democracy?

It is unfortunate, but true. Because internal democracy in parties has collapsed, and INEC sometimes fails to enforce its own guidelines, aggrieved members run to court. Courts are now referees and players. That is not healthy. Strong parties with internal mechanisms will reduce judicialization of politics.

Don't you think that the various controversial rulings of the courts are doing more harm than good to the polity and even confusing the political elite and INEC?

Some court rulings do create confusion, especially when they contradict each other or come late. But, the fault is not only with the courts. It starts with impunity in parties and agencies that ignore the law. My case with Action Alliance is an example. The Court of Appeal was clear and affirmed me as Chairman, yet some still pretend. INEC must obey court orders without delay. Rule of law is not optional and the commission is not doing my leadership any favor by obeying court orders.

With the recent court decisions in your favour as the authentic National Chairman of Action Alliance (AA), to what extent is the party getting ready for the 2027 general elections?

Action Alliance is ready. The



Udeze

Nigeria is at a crossroads. The economy is biting hard, insecurity persists, and public trust in institutions is low. Nigerians are resilient, but resilience alone cannot feed families. We need urgent economic reforms that prioritise production, job creation, and welfare. The government must listen more and govern less by propaganda

courts have settled it. We have started reinvigorating state executives, opened membership drives, and set up our 2027 strategy committee. Action Alliance will contest across board - Presidency to Councillorship. Nigerians are tired of the same old parties. Action Alliance offers a credible alternative anchored on justice, jobs, and security.

Osun State has been enmeshed in crisis over the August 15 governorship election with reported killings, thuggery and destruction of campaign materials. What is your advice to the stakeholders, including security agencies and INEC?

This is unacceptable. I call on se-

curity agencies to be neutral and decisive. Arrest and prosecute thugs, no matter their party. INEC must ensure a level playing field. To politicians: Osun people's lives are more important than your ambition. And to the people: don't sell your future for peanuts. Let your vote count peacefully. What is happening in Osun is a shame and a threat to democracy. Reports of killings, thuggery, destruction of campaign materials, and intimidation of voters ahead of the August 15 election are unacceptable.

My view is that politics should not cost lives. No ambition is worth the blood of an Osun son or daughter. Politicians who sponsor thugs

must be named, shamed, and prosecuted. Security Agencies must be neutral. The Police, DSS, and Civil Defence must deploy early, be visible, and act decisively. Selective enforcement will only worsen the crisis.

INEC must guarantee a level playing field. The commission must ensure materials are not hijacked and that results reflect the true will of the people. Voters must resist inducement. Osun people should not sell their future for rice and N2,000. Your PVC is your power. Action Alliance condemns this violence in totality. We call for immediate peace meetings with all party leaders, traditional rulers, and security chiefs before August 15. If we normalise this, 2027 will be worse.

Osun needs peace, not blood. Nigerians need real institutions, not fake ones. And Nigeria needs security reform, not political policing. We at Action Alliance will keep speaking truth to power.

My advice is simple: Obey the law, be neutral, and protect the people. To INEC: Be truly independent. Update your records in line with court judgments and party constitutions. Do not recognize illegal factions. The credibility of 2027 starts with you. Nigerians must believe their votes will count. To security agencies: Your duty is to protect lives and property, not parties. Be professional and non-partisan. Arrest thugs and sponsors of violence no matter how highly placed. Without security, there can be no credible election. To the Judiciary: Nigerians still have faith in the courts as the last hope. Please deliver timely, consistent, and courageous judgments. Avoid conflicting rulings that confuse the polity. Justice delayed is democracy denied. 2027 must not be about rigging, violence, or technicalities. It must be about the will of the people. All three institutions hold the key.

What is your take on the ongoing moves towards the creation of the State Police?

I support it with safeguards. Centralised policing has failed us. Governors need powers to secure their states, but we must legislate to prevent abuse. There must be proper funding, training, and oversight by state assemblies and civil society. State Police is not a silver bullet, but it is a necessary reform.

What is the shape of politics in the South East in general and Imo State in particular?

The South East is politically awake but frustrated by insecurity and marginalisation. People want development, not rhetoric. In Imo, the hunger for good governance is high. Action Alliance is building structures there to offer that alternative. 2027 will be a referendum on performance, not party logos.

What is your take on the discovery of a fake federal agency operating within the federal Secretariat complex in Abuja?

The recent discovery of a 'fake federal agency' operating and defrauding Nigerians is another evidence of institutional decay. My view is that this is not just fraud. It is institutional capture.

The development shows some security lapse. How can a fake agency operate, issue ID cards, and collect money for months without detection? It shows poor intelligence gathering.

It also is evidence of the nation's unemployment crisis. Many youths are desperate. Fraudsters prey on that desperation by promising fake jobs in 'federal agencies'. Government must create real jobs. The development is also evidence of verification failure. Nigerians must be able to easily verify any federal agency online. MDAs and the Ministry of Information must publish an official list and warn the public.

Also, very important is the issue of prosecution. The sponsors of this fake agency must be prosecuted publicly. If we treat this as 'one-off', more will spring up before 2027 to be used for election fraud. The government must restore public trust. When people no longer believe what is 'federal', democracy is in trouble.

How do you see the current moves to create State Police?

Action Alliance supports the move to create State Police, but with strict safeguards. Why do we need State Police? Centralised policing has failed. The Inspector General of Police (IGP) in Abuja cannot respond on time to kidnapping in Imo, banditry in Zamfara, or cult clashes in Osun. Governors are Chief Security Officers (CSOs) with no command over police. That is a joke.

But, the people's fears are real. So, I have few proposals on this. First, there should be constitutional safeguards. State Police must be in the Constitution, not by executive order. There must be clear separation from the governor's political office.

Secondly, there must be provisions for funding and training. States must be mandated to fund, train, and equip to national standards. There should be no militia in uniform in the name of the State Police.

The State Police must have a proper oversight. The State Houses of Assembly, Judicial Commissions, and Civil Society must oversee operations of the State Police in the various states to prevent abuse for political opponents.

Again, State Police must have National Coordination. There must be a framework for collaboration with Federal Police, Army, and DSS on terrorism and interstate crime.

The bottom line is that the State Police is not a magic wand, but it is a necessary reform. If we do it right, it will reduce response time, create jobs, and improve local intelligence. If we do it wrong, governors will use it as a private army for 2027 elections.

Politics

The Long Civil Rights Movement

SHEHRYAR FAZLI

“The white cracker who wrote the national anthem knew what he was doing,” says the Black nurse Belize in Tony Kushner’s *Angels in America*, set in the 1980s. “He set the word ‘free’ to a note so high no one can reach it.”

This statement may sound overly despairing to someone keen to reconcile America’s high principles to the daily experience of living in the nation, as Belize’s (white) interlocutor Louis is. Whatever the turpitudes of the Reagan administration, whatever the horrors of the AIDS epidemic, for Louis the nation has kept its holdings in the sacred honor that carried the Revolution, twenty years after the fulfillment of Black civil and political rights.

Belize’s line could have been the epigraph for the scholar Brandon M. Terry’s new book *Shattered Dreams, Infinite Hope: A Tragic Vision of the Civil Rights Movement*, a powerful dissent from the romantic view of American history in general and the civil rights movement in particular. He tests the mainstream historiography of that struggle as an exemplary political action whose success incorporated “the excluded into this healthy political sphere and the mainstream of social life.”

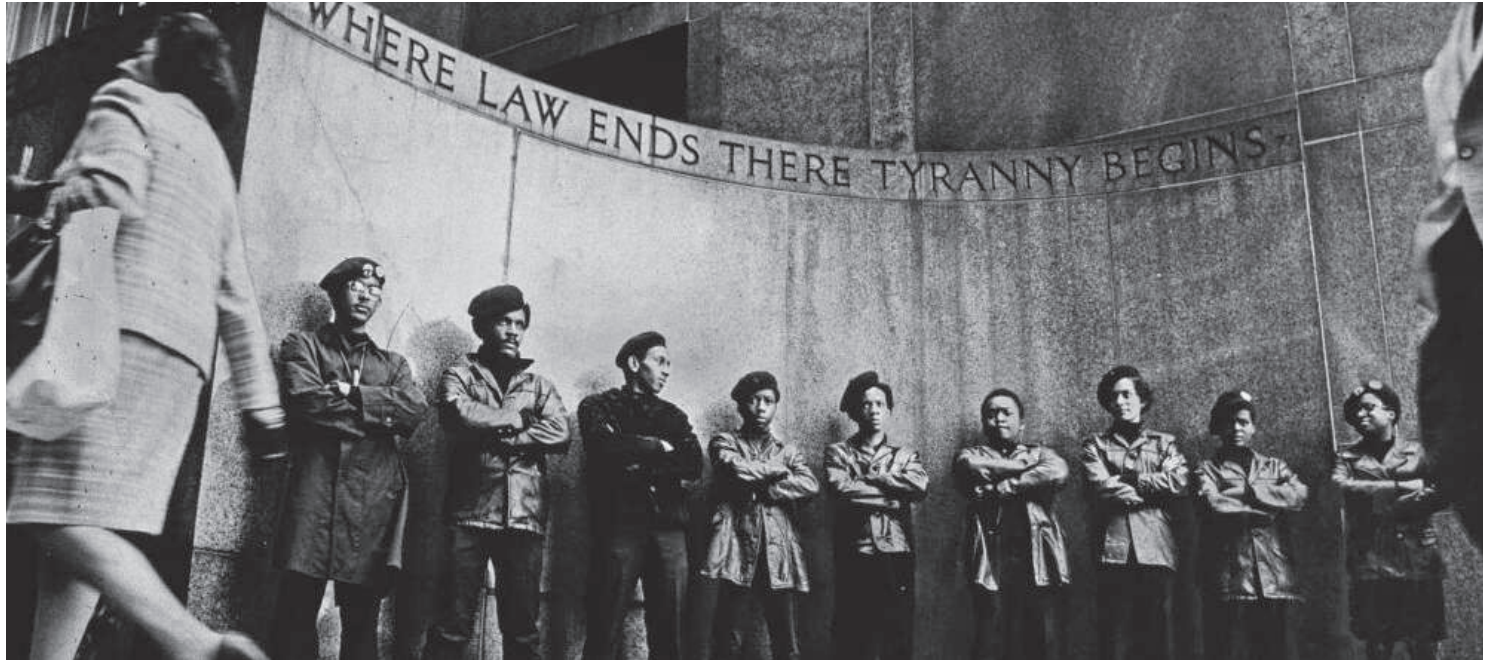
In the romantic vision of the movement, the 1950s and 60s saw civic struggle, court rulings, and legislation defeat white supremacy in a reckoning with the past that would place the US firmly ahead of the Soviets in moral terms. It would also authenticate the promise of the Constitution, which in 1787 was “meant to mark the start of a new era, in which the course of history might be made predictable and a government established that would be ruled not by accident and force but by reason and choice,” as historian Jill Lepore wrote in her book, *These Truths*.

So ingrained is the belief in the constitution’s reflection of a political ideal, high above the facts on the ground, that no less a learned liberal commentator than Ezra Klein was surprised, in a 2019 interview with Lepore, to learn that today’s Electoral College was a byproduct of slavery. Through an eccentric formula, the Southern states were able to deny slaves the vote while leveraging their numbers to enhance the representation of Southern states in Congress and, through the Electoral College, the vote for the presidency. For the state population totals, Black slaves would count as three-fifths of a citizen.

Though he doesn’t discuss the three-fifths compromise, which was abolished after the Civil War, Terry gestures towards its legacy when he argues, “Diffuse exhortations to unity find no institutional soil on which a critique of those features that make the presidential elections, the Senate, and judiciary appointments biased towards largely white rural areas [can] flower.” If America was the only country in which a Black man with a funny name could rise to the top, as Barack Obama said in his 2004 keynote Convention speech, liberals have been slow to accept that the claim of an improbable rise to power applied with at least equal force for Donald Trump, who lost the popular vote by some 3 million.

Current Republican efforts to reverse the legislative gains of the 1960s, backed by a Supreme Court seemingly hellbent on dismantling Black voting rights, provides an easy target of liberal contempt and finger-pointing. To sincerely confront racial injustice in America, however, is to contend with the ways in which white supremacy has adapted to and recovered from its defeats in Democratic as well as Republican administrations.

When civil and voting rights laws formally ended segregation in the South, the old regime of second-class citizenship assumed less visible form. In *The New Jim Crow*, Michelle Alexander explored how mass incarceration, disproportionately affecting Blacks and accelerated by Clinton-era reforms, had let segregation in through the back door: “Once you’re labeled a felon, the old forms of discrimination—employment discrimination, housing discrimination, denial of the right to vote, denial of educational opportunity, denial of food stamps and other public benefits, and exclusion from jury service—are



Activist members of the Black Panthers stand with arms folded during a demonstration in New York City, on April 11, 1969. © Neal Boenzi/New York Times/Getty

In the romantic vision of the movement, the 1950s and 60s saw civic struggle, court rulings, and legislation defeat white supremacy in a reckoning with the past that would place the US firmly ahead of the Soviets in moral terms

suddenly legal.” Terry doesn’t spend as much time on mass incarceration as he might have, but Alexander’s thesis—that the American justice system is not a neutral mechanism enforcing laws passed by the people’s representatives, but a “stunningly comprehensive and well-disguised system of racialized social control”—would have underscored his argument about how a vast architecture of racial domination remains intact.

As a philosophical intervention on how we use memory and history in debates over justice, *Shattered Dreams* isn’t short on jargon. Terry uses significant intellectual muscle to build his case and, in doing so, often overexerts himself. Early sections are devoted to deep readings of Kant, Rawls, Mill, Arendt, and others. These pre-ludes are never uninteresting but their contributions to Terry’s core argument can escape the reader. A long chapter on Kant’s notion of judgment and the “aesthetic experience of beauty” for example, seems an elaborate route to Terry’s point about how we think about the civil rights movement’s exemplarity.

Where the philosophical backdrop assumes more relevance is in the discussion of Rawls and civil disobedience. For Rawls, civil disobedience is justified when laws and practices violate a common “sense of justice”: segregation, denial of equal voting rights, and other forms of racial discrimination. But Rawls draws the line on economic inequality, which in a just constitutional order is the domain of representative politics. The assumption here is that economics is up for debate, fundamental rights are not. Standing in opposition to the narrow Rawlsian idea of civil disobedience is Martin Luther King, Jr., for whom that very order, as he wrote in 1967, is ridden with “the ‘congenital deformity’ of racism that has crippled the nation from its inception.” For King, a radical economic transformation was as legitimate a cause for mass agitation as desegregation or voting rights. Resource distribution wasn’t a matter of legitimate political difference but basic to democratic citizenship.

One contrasting vision to romanticism is a politics of despair that Terry refers to as

“Afropessimism,” which sees the movement as a failure and civic struggle as therefore futile. If this most emblematic example of participatory politics yielded only superficial gains, the argument goes, and intergenerational poverty, mass incarceration, and de facto segregation in neighborhoods and public schools continue to be imposed on Black lives, what point is there in engaging with the system? The absence of redemption, however, doesn’t make this framework any less teleological. As Arendt said, “Progress and Doom are two sides of the same medal; that both are articles of superstition.”

Terry finds Afropessimism as unproductive as romanticism. The tragic vision that he advocates for instead is one that accepts the civil rights movement’s “splendid failures,” that antagonisms remain embedded in the body politic, without ever losing faith in the power of civic action. This vision draws together “the centrality of serious conflict, the potential significance of defeats, the contingency of history, and the responsibility of historical actors.”

To understand segregation and civil rights in economic as well as political terms is to get to the heart of Terry’s “tragic vision” of the movement. The “long civil rights historiography” he espouses takes as its origin not the fight for equality in the South, starting with the Supreme Court’s 1954 *Brown v Board of Education* decision that ruled segregation of public schools unconstitutional, or the Montgomery Bus Boycott a year later, but the Great Migration that began in the early twentieth century, which eventually saw some six million Blacks flee the American South to northern cities for political freedom and economic opportunity. The reshaping of the industrial workforce that followed enabled a new era of labor activism, led by figures such as A. Philip Randolph, that merged class and race interests. Moreover, the urban Black vote in the north became a new political dynamic that helped compel Franklin Roosevelt to ban racial discrimination by defense contractors in 1941 and Harry Truman to desegregate the military in 1948.

However, northern cities fought to contain the demographic and political earthquake of the Great Migration by devising more discreet forms of second-class citizenship. In the 2014 article “The Case for Reparations,” Ta-Nehisi Coates wrote of the ways that predatory white lenders replaced “the acquisitive warlords of the South” as the agents bent on seizing properties from Black owners in cities like Chicago, abetted by redlining and other discriminatory policies that denied Black migrants equal access to housing. It’s this systematic subversion of Black economic security and uplift that makes less defensible the view of civil rights as “a self-reflexive ethical transformation that restored the American creed to pride of place,” in Terry’s words.

An analogy can be found in post-apartheid

South Africa. The country’s liberal 1996 constitution was once deemed the apotheosis of the country’s democratic transition. But the constitutional settlement, including strong protections of private property, failed to reverse fundamental features of class domination, leaving countless black South Africans without access to opportunity and true social emancipation.

In the “master narrative,” the civil rights era peaked with the mid-60s legal victories and then, following King’s assassination in 1968, gave way to “a spasm of militancy and ‘identity politics’ that crested under the sign of Black Power [marking] the embittered denouement of the civil rights movement,” as Terry writes. The liberalism associated with King and civil rights has its foil in the Black nationalism of various political and intellectual programs, most prominently Marcus Garvey’s self-determinationist politics of the early twentieth century, the Nation of Islam’s separatist creed, and the revolutionary militancy of the Black Panthers. By the late 1960s and 1970s, the nationalists who accused integrationists of being Uncle Toms had replaced their ostensible rivals at the center of Black political struggle.

Terry contends that despite the resentments between Black nationalists and integrationists “the substantive positions on both sides after the legislative victories of civil rights grew remarkably similar on some fronts.” Once civil rights are framed to include economic justice, dignity, and political and democratic power, the disagreements over principled nonviolence between a Stokely Carmichael and a Reverend King appear less robust. Instead, they speak more to the complexity of Black political life than does a neat integrationist/nationalist dichotomy that saw one movement yield to the other. Similarly, King’s democratic socialism—which condemned capitalism’s failure to distribute wealth fairly and urged the state to pursue economic justice alongside racial equality—and Malcolm X’s “Black capitalism”—which emphasized self-sufficiency, Black entrepreneurship, and freedom from economic dependence on white institutions—ultimately converged in their pursuit of economic and political dignity.

In the liberal discourse, the binary between integrationism and Black Power is a moral one, between moderation and excess, respectively Terry sees this as a product of narrative forms—in his words, “emplotment”—that assume false ethical clarity and flatten the intricate texture of Black political struggle by ignoring the civil rights movement’s own compromises and imperfections. One of the decisions he focuses on is that of using the children of Birmingham in a 1963 march for desegregation, where they were subjected to fire hoses and attack dogs.

Continues in THE IDEAS LETTER (www.theideasletter.org), February 19, 2026.

The Cost Of Staying Connected: How Nigerian Telecom Subscribers Are Being Shortchanged

DEBORAH EWEJE

For millions of Nigerians, making a phone call, sending a text message or accessing the internet has become an exercise in frustration. Calls drop without warning, data bundles disappear faster than expected, internet speeds crawl despite active subscriptions, and customers often pay for services they never fully receive.

Yet, every month, subscribers continue to spend billions of naira on telecom services.

The growing dissatisfaction has triggered one of the biggest consumer protection interventions in Nigeria's telecommunications sector, with the Nigerian Communications Commission (NCC) compelling operators to compensate millions of affected customers.

A Pattern of Consumer Complaints

Across Nigeria, complaints against telecom operators have followed familiar patterns: Frequent dropped calls, Slow or unstable internet services, Failed SMS deliveries, Unexplainable depletion of data bundles, Network congestion during peak periods and Difficulty obtaining refunds or resolving complaints.

These complaints have dominated social media, consumer advocacy platforms and traditional news reports for years, with users accusing operators of charging for services that fail to meet advertised standards.

The frustrations became even louder after telecom tariffs increased early last year, with many subscribers arguing that higher prices were not matched by improved quality of service.

Why Subscribers Feel Shortchanged

Industry experts say the problem goes beyond isolated technical faults. They highlighted some cardinal factors that are impeding seamless services by the telecom operators. These are:

Network Congestion: Nigeria's telecom industry has witnessed rapid subscriber growth. With over 187 million active subscriptions, existing network infrastructure has struggled to keep pace with rising demand, especially in densely populated urban centres. Heavy traffic often overwhelms available capacity, resulting in dropped calls and slow internet speeds.

Infrastructure Deficit: Although operators invested more than N2.5 trillion in network upgrades during 2025, according to the NCC, the country still faces significant infrastructure gaps. Base stations remain insufficient for Nigeria's growing digital economy, while fibre



Bosun Tijani, Minister of Communication

deployment, power supply challenges and insecurity continue to hamper network expansion.

High Operating Costs: Telecom companies have repeatedly cited soaring diesel prices, foreign exchange volatility, equipment import costs and vandalism as major obstacles to improving service quality. Maintaining thousands of base stations on diesel-powered generators significantly increases operating expenses, leaving operators balancing infrastructure investment with profitability.

Weak Consumer Redress: Historically, subscribers who experienced poor service rarely received compensation. Many consumers complained that customer service channels were slow, complaints went unresolved, and proving financial loss from failed services was almost impossible. This lack of accountability reinforced the perception that subscribers paid the price while operators bore little consequence for poor performances.

Regulatory Intervention

Responding to mounting public dissatisfaction, the NCC introduced one of its strongest consumer protection measures.

In March 2026, the regulator directed mobile network operators to automatically compensate subscribers whenever net-

Nigeria's telecommunications sector remains one of the country's most critical digital infrastructure industries, underpinning banking, commerce, education, healthcare and government services. As reliance on digital connectivity grows, expectations are also rising

work performance falls below prescribed Quality of Service (QoS) benchmarks.

Rather than requiring individual complaints before refunds are issued, operators are expected to identify affected users and credit them with airtime based on their average spending patterns in locations where service standards were not met.

The compensation framework covers: Dropped voice calls, Failed SMS, Interrupted data sessions. Other measurable service failures linked to poor network performance.

Millions Receive Compensation

The policy has already produced measurable results with NCC disclosing that over 75 million subscribers received compensation from telecom operators, describing it as one of the largest consumer redress exercises in Africa's telecommunications industry.

Several subscribers acknowledged receiving airtime credits through SMS notifications from their network providers.

However, reactions have been mixed. While many welcomed the move as a step towards greater accountability, others argued that the compensation amounts are far less when compared to the inconvenience suffered.

Operators Defend Their Position

Telecom operators maintain that they are investing heavily

to improve network quality. According to the NCC, mobile network operators invested over N2.13 trillion in network infrastructure in 2025, while tower companies contributed another N373.8 billion. These investments supported thousands of new and upgraded telecom sites nationwide. The regulator acknowledges these efforts but insists that investment alone cannot excuse poor customer experience. It has warned that enforcement actions will continue until the Key Performance Indices (KPI) achieve measurable improvements.

What Subscribers Can Do

The NCC has outlined a formal complaint process for consumers experiencing poor service. Subscribers are advised to: Report the issue to their telecom operator, Obtain a complaint or "trouble ticket." Allow the operator the stipulated time to resolve the issue and Escalate unresolved complaints to the NCC through its toll-free line (622), email or online consumer channels.

The regulator says operators that fail to address legitimate complaints within prescribed timelines may face sanctions.

Beyond Compensation

Consumer advocates argue that compensation should not become a substitute for reliable service. Instead, they say Nigeria's telecom industry requires sustained investment in fibre infrastructure, additional base stations, improved power solutions, stronger regulatory oversight and greater transparency in billing practices. Industry analysts also believe operators should provide clearer explanations of data usage, improve customer support and publish network performance metrics to rebuild consumer confidence.

Nigeria's telecommunications sector remains one of the country's most critical digital infrastructure industries, underpinning banking, commerce, education, healthcare and government services.

As reliance on digital connectivity grows, expectations are also rising.

The NCC's compensation policy represents an important shift from simply regulating operators to actively protecting consumers. But the true measure of success will not be the number of airtime refunds issued, it will be whether Nigerians eventually stop needing compensation because the quality of service has improved.

Until then, many subscribers will continue to ask the same question: if they are paying more for connectivity, why are they still getting less?

Business

NITDA, NAWOJ Partner To Boost Women's Digital Inclusion Across Nigeria

The National Information Technology Development Agency (NITDA) has partnered with the Nigeria Association of Women Journalists (NAWOJ) in a strategic move aimed at advancing women's digital inclusion and drive the nation's transformation agenda. Demographics

The Director of Corporate Communications & Media Relations at NITDA, Hajia Hadiza Umar, in a press statement yesterday, said the partnership was cemented during a courtesy visit to NITDA Director-General, Mallam Kashifu Inuwa Abdullahi, by a NAWOJ delegation led by National President Comrade Aishatu Ibrahim, who introduced the agency to the forthcoming Women in Security (WINSEC) Summit & Awards 2026.

Mallam Abdullahi, represented by the Director of the Stakeholders Management and Partnerships Department, Dr. Aristotle Onumo assured the association that NITDA would not only participate in the confer-

ence, but also support the success of the conference. Engineering & Technology

Abdullahi hailed the NAWOJ for creating a platform for peace-building, dialogue on security and women's inclusion, which he described as one of the critical areas NITDA was focused on to ensure that more women obtained digital literacy and skills under the National Gender Inclusive Strategy.

Beyond NITDA's plan to participate in the conference, the NITDA DG noted that a robust partnership between the organisations would engender meaningful opportunities and initiatives through which many more women could access digital literacy.

"Inclusivity is the key to everything we do at NITDA. We clearly defined that 40 per cent of our programmes must recognise the issue of gender. We ensure that women are adequately represented and positioned to benefit greatly from the programmes that we organise in the agency. "We graciously accept to par-

ticipate actively in that conference. Apart from acquiring skills among journalists themselves, partnership with NAWOJ will also serve as a platform through which we can also reach out to various women's groups across the federation," Abdullahi said. Enterprise Technology

Earlier, Comrade Ibrahim commended the NITDA DG for his visionary and transformational leadership which had continued to position NITDA as the catalyst for Nigeria's digital economy through its various programmes.

She explained that the Women in Security (WINSEC) Summit and Awards 2026 was an initiative of NAWOJ designed to promote collaboration among government institutions, security agencies, technology experts, the media, and other stakeholders to address contemporary security challenges.

According to Comrade Ibrahim, the association also aimed to recognise outstanding individuals and institutions that had demonstrated excellence in

security, governance, and innovation while fostering meaningful dialogue on the role of technology in building a safer and more resilient Nigeria.

"We deeply appreciate your exemplary leadership, passion for innovation, and unwavering commitment to building a digitally empowered Nigeria. We respectfully invite the agency to partner with NAWOJ in making this landmark initiative a success. Demographics

"We look forward to establishing a long-term partnership with NITDA that will empower women journalists with cutting-edge digital skills, support digital inclusion and contribute to innovation, digital literacy, and human capital development," the NAWOJ president added.

Both organisations expressed optimism that the meeting would lay a solid foundation for a rewarding partnership agreement with specific and clearly defined objectives that will support digital inclusion and contribute to innovation, digital literacy, and human capital development.

MTN Nigeria Opens Entries For Next Afrobeats Star Season 2

MTN Nigeria has unveiled Season 2 of its reality music competition, Next Afrobeats Star (NAS), following the success of its inaugural edition, which discovered and rewarded some of Nigeria's brightest emerging music talents. Produced in partnership with Ultima Studios and ONErpm, the competition returns with an expanded prize package and a renewed search for Nigeria's next Afrobeats star.

Commenting on the return of the show, Emamoke Ogoro, General Manager, Brands and Communication, MTN Nigeria, said Next Afrobeats Star reflects the company's commitment to empowering young Nigerians by creating platforms that transform talent into opportunity.

"Season 1 was our proof. Our contestants did not simply gain

exposure; they released original music now available on major global streaming platforms. They left the competition owning their intellectual property, with industry credentials and meaningful relationships in a music industry that now knows their names.

"As we return for Season 2, the most significant change is not the size of the prize; it is the size of the door it opens. We are opening that door even wider by connecting grassroots talent to a national stage," she said. She added that, beyond entertainment, the initiative reflects MTN Nigeria's commitment to creating opportunities for young Nigerians through creativity, innovation and strategic partnerships that support the country's growing creative economy.

Stakeholders Advocate Policy Reforms, Grassroots Innovation To Bridge Nigeria's Digital

The Nigeria Information Technology Reporters Association (NITRA) held its Innovative and Scientific Conference on Thursday at Citi Height Hotel, Ikeja, Lagos, bringing together government agencies, industry leaders, and policymakers to explore strategies for bridging Nigeria's digital divide through scientific innovation.

Themed "Bridging Nigeria's Digital Divide With Scientific Innovation," the conference featured a panel discussion titled "The Place of Policy and Infrastructure in Nigeria's Quest for Global Competitiveness through Scientific Innovation: Roles of Different Stakeholders in Grassroots Mobilisation."

Industry leaders identified multiple taxation, prohibitive right-of-way costs, and inconsistent state-level policies as major obstacles slowing infrastructure rollout. One panelist noted that transporting bandwidth from Lagos to Canada is cheaper than delivering services to other parts of Nigeria due to transport access limitations. He explained: "When we talk about right of way limitation, it plays on cost of providing services to some subnationals. Some states say right of way is free, but when they give you free right of way, they add other elements—development charge, education levy, infrastructure fee—and all of that makes a mess of the free right of way." He called for harmonised policies to ensure affordable internet access across the country.

Another panelist, representing telecoms operators, stressed that policies must not favour only dominant players. "Policy should not get higher; it's just for the food. That's why the policy is not for instance, cyber security will not work," he said, adding that regulatory engagement with the industry had seen some improvement.

A representative of a private sector innovation fund shared insights from supporting young innovators through essay competitions and grants. "We believe that by helping people think—helping the educational system, people in secondary school, primary school—from that young age, they think wide and broadly about what

innovation looks like. By opening up those eyes at that young age, the older they become, they can fall into these opportunities." He stressed that innovators exist everywhere, including rural villages, and need exposure to thrive.

On cybersecurity capacity building, a panelist emphasised grassroots talent development. "Part of what we are known for is the development of local talent. We don't just import talent or rely on experts from overseas. We bring in interns from schools, and they go through the element of understanding what cybersecurity is." He suggested rehabilitation over incarceration for young cyber offenders: "We need to find a way to retain them. Not necessarily put them in jail, but ensure we have programs to harness their talents."

A representative from the computer society sector outlined a roadmap starting from primary education. "If Nigeria is going to be globally competitive, we start from primary school level. At that level, we need to teach them early—bring coaching, robotics to them. Our schools should not just be examination centers; we should make our schools innovation clubs," he said, citing the recent launch of an AI university portal in Lagos that builds a digital talent pipeline from primary school to university.

On the role of regulation, a media analyst cautioned against over-regulation. "Regulation must come with discussion. In the first phase, regulators should be looking at how to build things so they don't stifle innovation. If you bring so much regulation, that stifles innovation," he said, noting that Nigeria is currently considering AI regulation and must strike the right balance.

On infrastructure protection, a panelist stressed the need for community awareness. "When infrastructure is not protected, who will feel the brunt of it? The regulator will feel it, the operator will feel it. When locals need money, they go and vandalise sites. We need to do a lot more public awareness. People need to own their behaviour—even on social media, they need to have the conscience that they own their behaviour."



Uzoma Nwagba, Managing Director/CEO, Nigerian Consumer Credit Corporation—CREDICORP (left); Taiwo Oyedele, Minister of Finance and Coordinating Minister of the Economy (second left); Amaka Ezenwenyi, YouthCred beneficiary (second right), and Abubakar Atiku Bagudu, Minister of Budget and Economic Planning, during the launch of YOUTHCRED for Entrepreneurs at the Ministry of Finance in Abuja, on Wednesday.

Contest For N50m Begins As Betano, The Next Titan Nigeria TV Show, Unveils Season 11

JUSTUS ADEJUMOH

Betano-The Next Titan Nigeria, an Entrepreneurial Reality Show designed to inspire the entrepreneurial spirit of young Nigerians has unveiled its Season 11 in Lagos as young Nigerians with entrepreneurial spirit are set to battle for a grand prize that comes with the 10-week intensive programme.

The new season unveiled at a pre-season press conference in Lagos on Thursday, is expected to run for 10 weeks and will begin with auditions in Abuja, Lagos, Port Harcourt, and Enugu before contestants advance to the next stage.

The 10-week competition will begin with auditions in Abuja, Lagos, Port Harcourt, and Enugu before contestants advance to the next stage.

In his opening remarks at this year's edition themed 'Be The Relentless', Mide Akinlaja, the Executive Producer of The Next Titan Nigeria, said it would be the biggest in the programme's history, with expanded opportunities and a more engaging competition.

Akinlaja said the importance of the initiative which is in its 11th year, lies in igniting entrepreneurial spirit and showcasing the possibility of entrepreneurship in transforming lives with just an idea that can be scaled to greatness.

According to him, "The programme has a powerful vision to search and discover promising entrepreneurs, availing them with practical knowledge, connecting them with business leaders as mentors and judges, while inspiring millions of Nigerians to see

entrepreneurship as a pathway to economic prosperity.

"Betano-The Next Titan Nigeria Season 11 is the unveiling of the fresh opportunities, innovative ideas, and a renewed commitment to enterprise development in Nigeria. Our vision is simple, but bold: to create a platform where young Nigerians with passion, creativity, and determination could be discovered, challenged, mentored, and empowered.

Explaining how the programme would run, Mide said: "Beginning this August, we shall take our auditions to Abuja, Lagos, Port Harcourt, and Enugu, searching for exceptional entrepreneurial talents from every corner of our nation. From these auditions, the top 50 will proceed on intensive three-day entrepreneurship boot-

camp before the top 20 contestants are selected to compete in the Titan House through weekly business tasks, mentorship sessions and boardroom eliminations.

The entrepreneurial reality show will produce a winner of a N50 million grand prize.

In his remarks, Daniel Lambert, senior business development advisor for Betano in Africa, said the company's partnership with The Next Titan reflects its long-term commitment to Nigeria.

"We have been supporting this laudable initiative for the past decade, and this reflects the company's commitment to supporting entrepreneurship and initiatives that create lasting social and economic impact. Supporting another season of Betano-The Next Titan shows our long-term commitment to Nigeria, our continual focus on innovation and our ambition to invest in partnerships that make a meaningful contribution to the communities where we operate."

Foreign Affairs

Germany's Love Letter To Nigeria Came With Hard Truths! Dr. Wadephul And The New German Playbook For Nigeria

BISHOP DR JOSEPH IGHALO-EDORO

Germany came calling on Tuesday and Nigeria had to listen. Wadephul's message was one of candour and beyond diplomatic dinners. It was a courtship that had just been reinforced by Berlin. Diplomatic dinners are usually remembered for polished courtesies, carefully measured language and the predictable exchange of compliments that define international relations. They rarely produce moments that compel a foreign affairs writer to leave the hall thinking less about protocol and more about the shifting architecture of global politics. That was my experience in Lagos as I joined diplomats, government officials, members of the diplomatic corps, business leaders and invited guests at a dinner in honour of Germany's Foreign Minister, Johann Wadephul. What unfolded before me was not merely another ceremonial engagement marking sixty-five years of diplomatic relations between Nigeria and Germany. It became a compelling lesson in the changing language of diplomacy, where friendship is celebrated without concealing uncomfortable realities and where partnership is strengthened by honesty rather than flattery. Germany came bearing praise for Nigeria, but it also came bearing difficult truths. That combination made Wadephul's address one of the most thought-provoking diplomatic speeches delivered on Nigerian soil in recent times.

His opening reflections were those of a partner speaking with confidence about a relationship that has matured beyond symbolic diplomacy. Germany's engagement with Nigeria, he noted, has grown steadily across energy, engineering, machinery, manufacturing, education, technology, culture and commercial exchange. These are not sectors chosen by accident. They represent the very foundations upon which modern economies are built. Germany has long been recognised as one of the world's industrial powerhouses and Nigeria remains Africa's largest economy by potential. The message was unmistakable. Berlin increasingly sees Abuja not merely as another African capital but as an indispensable strategic partner whose success carries implications for the wider continent.

One statistic particularly caught my attention. Wadephul revealed that the number of Nigerian students studying in Germany has quadrupled during the past decade. That single observation deserves more attention than it may initially receive. It reflects a relationship that is quietly moving beyond trade balances and diplomatic communiqués into the realm of human capital development. Every Nigerian student who passes through a German university returns home with knowledge, technical skills, professional networks and exposure that ultimately enrich Nigeria's development. In an era where the global economy is increasingly driven by innovation rather than raw mate-



Johann Wadephul, Foreign Affairs Minister, Federal Republic of Germany.

rials, educational diplomacy may prove more valuable than many commercial agreements signed with elaborate ceremonies.

The minister also displayed an appreciation of Nigeria that extended beyond economics. He spoke enthusiastically about the extraordinary influence of Nigerian music across the world and cited Burna Boy as an illustration of how Nigerian creativity has become one of the country's most effective diplomatic ambassadors. It was an acknowledgement that soft power has become one of Nigeria's greatest international assets. Long before official delegations arrive in many countries, Nigerian music has already entered homes, stadiums, streaming platforms and concert arenas. Culture has succeeded where conventional diplomacy often struggles. It has created admiration for Nigeria among millions who may never have visited Africa. That recognition from Germany's chief diplomat demonstrated a sophisticated understanding of how nations now project influence in the twenty-first century.

Yet the evening was never intended to remain an exercise in celebration. The warmth of Germany's affection for Nigeria was accompanied by a direct appeal that immediately altered the tone of the gathering. Speaking about Russia's continuing war against Ukraine, Wadephul abandoned diplomatic ambiguity. He expressed deep concern over reports that some Nigerian youths have allowed themselves to be recruited into Russia's military campaign. Then came the sentence that instantly defined the evening. Putin is not worth dying for. Those words were delivered without hesitation and without the protective language that diplomats often employ when discussing sensitive geopolitical issues. It was one of those rare moments when diplomacy deliberately surrendered caution in favour of moral clarity.

Whether one agrees entirely with Germany's position or not, the significance of the statement cannot be ignored. It reflected

He reminded his audience that friendship between nations is strengthened not by comfortable silence but by the courage to speak difficult truths with respect. That combination of admiration and candour may well become the defining character of the next chapter in Nigeria-Germany relations

Europe's determination to keep international attention focused on Ukraine while simultaneously warning vulnerable young Africans against becoming expendable participants in a conflict that neither originated on African soil nor advances Africa's interests. Wadephul's appeal was directed as much at economic desperation as it was at geopolitics. In societies where unemployment and limited opportunities create fertile ground for foreign recruitment, the promise of financial reward can easily overshadow the value of life itself. Germany's foreign minister challenged that dangerous calculation.



German Ambassador to Nigeria, Annet Gunther, and Consul-General in Lagos, Daniel Krull.

As I listened, I found myself reflecting on how dramatically diplomacy has evolved. There was a time when foreign ministers confined themselves almost exclusively to discussions of treaties, borders and bilateral agreements. Today's diplomacy is remarkably different. It speaks about education, migration, technology, culture, climate change, artificial intelligence, youth development, misinformation and even music. It recognises that international influence no longer belongs exclusively to governments. Universities, artists, entrepreneurs, innovators and ordinary citizens have become actors in foreign policy. Wadephul's address reflected that modern understanding.

The timing of Germany's renewed engagement with Nigeria is equally significant. Africa has become one of the principal theatres of global strategic competition. Europe seeks stronger partnerships. China continues expanding its economic footprint. Russia actively pursues political and security relationships across the continent. The Gulf states are investing aggressively. India, Türkiye, Japan and South Korea are all increasing their presence. Against this backdrop, Germany's message in Lagos was both diplomatic and strategic. It was a declaration that Nigeria occupies an increasingly important place within Berlin's long-term calculations for Africa.

Perhaps the most encouraging dimension of the evening was the confidence Germany expressed in Nigeria's future. Wadephul repeatedly returned to the country's greatest resource, its people, particularly its youth. He saw talent where others often see problems. He recognised opportunity where pessimists see only crisis. He celebrated a generation capable of producing globally celebrated musicians, internationally competitive students, innovative entrepreneurs and future industrial leaders. Yet his optimism was accompanied by a challenge. Talent alone is insufficient if it is diverted into conflicts that do not belong

to Nigeria or consumed by forces that exploit vulnerability instead of rewarding potential.

That is why I left the dinner convinced that the evening was about far more than Germany. It was ultimately about Nigeria's choices in an increasingly fragmented international order. Will Nigeria leverage its youthful population, expanding cultural influence and growing educational partnerships to become one of the defining powers of the twenty-first century, or will its greatest resource continue to be undermined by unemployment, insecurity, brain drain and external manipulation? That question lingered long after the speeches ended.

Diplomacy achieves its highest purpose when it transcends ceremony and provokes reflection. Germany's love letter to Nigeria was genuine. It celebrated partnership, education, industry, culture and shared prosperity. Yet every sincere relationship also requires honesty. Wadephul praised Nigeria without romanticising its challenges. He celebrated its promise while warning against its vulnerabilities. He reminded his audience that friendship between nations is strengthened not by comfortable silence but by the courage to speak difficult truths with respect. That combination of admiration and candour may well become the defining character of the next chapter in Nigeria-Germany relations. If so, the dinner in Lagos will be remembered not simply as another diplomatic engagement, but also as an evening when a partnership found its voice, and truth found a place at the table.

It was a night when Germany's Ambassador to Nigeria, Annet Gunther, an amiable and solemn personality with her co-host in Lagos, the Consul General of the German Consulate, Mr. Daniel Krull, calibrated the truths of their diplomatic prowess with regards to the personalities invited to the dinner, including captains of industries, culture, education, technology, diplomats, music, politics and arts and sports. A hall that Germany has friends in Nigeria.

Public Service

Gov. Bago's Determination To Light Up Niger

As part of strategies to attract investors, create jobs and speedy development of Niger state, our correspondent, Chinwendu Nnadozie, in this report, beams the searchlight on the bold steps Governor Mohammed Umar Bago has taken to prove critics wrong that he is unable to lighten the state through alternative sources of power by demonstrating his administration's resolve to end AEDC monopoly in the power sector with multi-million dollar solar powered energy that will speed up industrialisation.

Niger state and the federal government recently launched what is believed to be Nigeria's biggest solar-powered industrial park as part of not only ending monopoly in the sector by the Abuja Electricity Distribution Company (AEDC), who for years failed to provide credible electricity supply for private and industrial/commercial needs but making a major shift to clean industrial energy that will meet the needs of customers. By this partnering with federal agencies and private companies, Niger state under Umaru Bago led administration is building solar-powered industrial parks with rural mini-grids, and panel manufacturing plants that will guarantee reliable electricity across the state.

The Minister of power, Joseph Tegbe, while commending Governor Bago for what he described as industrial statesmanship, said the allocation of 500 hectares of land to the company will drive unprecedented economic development in parts of the state and also leave lasting legacies by attracting massive international and local investments to the state.

The land allocation, according to Tegbe, is an act of "industrial statesmanship and demonstration of the state's commitments towards attracting private investment and creating lasting economic opportunities".

Tegbe further pointed out that, "The most enduring legacy of governance is not limited to physical infrastructure but included industries, investments and jobs creation through strategic decisions."

Handing over the land during the ground breaking ceremony at Dikko in Gurara Local Government Area (LGA), Governor Bago described the initiative as the beginning of a landmark project that would reshape the industrial landscape and expand opportunities for the good people of Niger state.

"What we are witnessing today is more than mere ceremony; it is a



Gov. Mohammed Umar Bago

clear declaration of our unwavering commitments towards transforming Niger state into a leading investment destination of choice for sustainable economic growth. An indication that our vision of building a New Niger is not only a promise, but is steadily becoming a reality".

"And this is going to open up industrialisation here, taking advantage of our gas resources from the AKK pipeline, as well as our vast land for the development of solar powered energy. Niger state hosts four hydro-electricity power dams: Kainji, Jebba, Shiroro, and Zungeru, and if well managed the state will have no reason to complain about unstable power supply for domestic and industrial purposes, and in addition is one of the advantages we have."

To also underscore Niger state's commitments to industrial development, Governor Bago told his guests and business partners that his administration will declare and gazette 200, 000 hectares of land from Dikko community to Tafa LGA, around communities bordering Kaduna state to establish industrial hubs.

The Federal Executive Council (FEC), due to the importance and magnitude of the project, wasted no time in approving a \$160 million financing package for the Niger State Solar Energy Development Project (NSSED), a landmark initiative designed to expand electricity access and accelerate Nigeria's renewable energy drive, and that of Niger state in particular.

The project's financing arrangement entails \$150 million facility from the Islamic Development Bank (IsDB) and \$10 million in counterpart funding from the Niger state government.

All things being equal, the project will deliver a 100-megawatt solar power plant in Niger state, significantly boosting electricity supply in rural and urban communities across the 25 LGAs.

Governor Bago also declared that the project is expected to enhance power reliability, diversify Nigeria's energy mix, and support agriculture, agro-processing, industrialisation, and as well climate change mitigation efforts.

The approval of the financing package followed months of collaborations between Niger state government and the IsDB.

The Governor had, in January 2026, hosted the IsDB project preparations

The initiative, described as a major breakthrough, is also bringing to an end years of prolonged blackout across the state

team for the Niger Solar Electrification Project (NGA1063), during which feasibility studies, environmental reviews, and social impact assessments commenced.

It should also be noted that the Bago administration enhanced the deployment of solar mini-grids and other renewable energy solutions whereby over 180 communities that had endured decades without meaningful electricity supply are now enjoying almost 24-hour solar powered energy.

The initiative, described as a major breakthrough, is also bringing to an end years of prolonged blackout across the state.

Also, beyond rural communities, the state government out of frustration due to endless excuses from the AEDC transitioned key public institutions including; Government House, Minna General Hospital, IBB Specialist Hospital, Niger State Water Board and several other ministries, Agencies, Boards and parastatals to independent solar powered systems.

The project, spearheaded by the Abuja Steel Mills Limited, it was gathered, a subsidiary of the African Industries Group, will be powered by a dedicated 200-megawatt solar mini-grid designed to supply electricity to a sprawling industrial park and integrated steel manufacturing complex in Niger state.

Away from the traditional manufacturing facilities that depended largely on electricity supply through the national grid, the Abuja Steel Mills project is designed to operate entirely on self-generated renewable energy,

thereby making it one of the continent's most ambitious experiments in clean-powered heavy industry that will guarantee power supply to customers outside Niger state. Some of the officials described the off-grid approach as a deliberate business and industrial strategy aimed at guaranteeing reliable power supply, reduction in production costs and as well insulate operations from the chronic electricity shortages that for decades constrained growth and development of Nigeria's manufacturing sector.

Speaking with journalists, Governor Bago said the solar powered project is clear demonstration that renewable energy can move beyond just powering homes and small businesses to supporting large-scale, energy-intensive industries such as steel manufacturing. Embedded generation whereby industrial facilities produce electricity for their own use, Bago said the project when completed will offer manufacturers greater predictability, operational efficiency and long-term cost savings while at the same time reducing pressure on the national grid.

Governor Bago said, "This project when completed and fully functional will drastically reduce dependency on national grid, create thousands of jobs, and as well transform Dikko and its environs into one of Nigeria's major industrial and economic hub".

The project, coming at a time Nigeria's power sector needed checks despite installing electricity generation capacity of over 13,000 megawatts, Bago argued that Nigeria has struggled for years to deliver stable electricity supply, with actual generations endlessly fluctuating and falling below customer's demands due to a number of factors including infrastructures deficits, transmission constraints and as well, gas supply challenges.

It is also worthy of note that unreliable energy supply significantly increases costs of production for industries, many of which had relied heavily on diesel-powered generators to sustain operations thereby causing unprecedented rise in the production of goods and services to the Nigerian populace.

This unreliable energy supply also prompted successive administrations to have increasingly turned to renewable energy and decentralized electricity systems as part of broader efforts to collectively improve energy access towards economic growth and development.

Nigeria's energy transition plan targets towards achieving net-zero carbon emissions by the year 2060 and significantly increasing share of renewable energy in the country's electricity mix, and the federal government has also promoted mini-grid development, embedded generation and as well private sector participation as key pillars for expanding power supply to unlock economic potentials.

Speaking on the efforts by Governor Bago to guarantee reliable electricity supply, the Special Adviser on Digital Media and Public Communications, Mallam Abdulberqi Ebbo said that beyond its implications for the steel industry, the project is expected to stimulate economic activities in parts of Niger state, create jobs, attract ancillary industries and strengthen Nigeria's position as a destination for green industrial investments.

Ebbo also stated that, "The project signals emerging development model for investors and policymakers alike in which industrial growth and clean energy transition are pursued simultaneously, offering a new pathway to address Nigeria's long-standing energy and manufacturing challenges".

Also, in their respective remarks, the Minister of Steel Development, Prince Shuaibu Abubakar and his Minister of State for Industry, Trade and Investment counterpart, Senator John Enoch, commended Governor Bago for his vision offering such vast expanse of land to the company and expressed optimism that the project would revolutionize the state's industrialization.

They added that the 500 hectares of land would significantly support the industrialisation of not only Niger state but also the entire country.

Also, the Group Chairman of African Industries Group (AIG), Raj Gupta, had earlier described the allocation of 500 hectares to Abuja Steel Mills Limited as "historic". "It is not just an opportunity to build industry and create jobs, but for me, its main purpose is to develop, uplifting and as well empowering the people".

"The project will be the largest. We already have the largest solar power installation in the country and, with this, we would perhaps have the largest in Sub-Saharan Africa. That puts Nigeria not only on the world steel map but also on the global renewable energy map".

The CEO/ Chairman Niger State Electricity Regulatory Commission (NSERC), Engr. Mohammed Sharu, while commending Governor Bago for the partnership he said yielded significant result, expressed optimism that the Commission will regulate electricity generation, distribution, supply, and as well related market activities across Niger state.

According to him, "The establishment of the NSERC marks an important milestone in Niger State's transition to transparent and sustainable electricity sector. We will focus on governance systems, regulatory continuity and as well consumer protection for efficient, safe, reliable and sustainable electricity supply in parts of Niger state".

Among the dignitaries that witnessed the ground-breaking ceremony included; the Minister of Power, Joseph Tegbe, Minister of Steel Development, Prince Shuaibu Audu; Minister of State for Industry, Senator John Owan Enoch, Governor Bago and some members of the State Executive Council (SEC) and as well, top management of the African Industries Group.

How Man City Lead In Third Successive W'Cup Payouts As Barca, Arsenal Trail

Manchester City top the list of distributions to clubs under FIFA's Club Benefits Programme (CBP) for the third World Cup in succession, calculations, The Athletic has found.

To go alongside the largest World Cup in history, FIFA will also share out more money than ever before to clubs that release players for participation.

The CBP pot for 2026 sits at \$355million (£265m), a 70 percent increase on the \$209m paid to clubs whose players competed in each of the past two World Cups, in Russia in 2018 and Qatar in 2022.

Of that \$355million, \$250m will be allocated in respect of players who performed at this summer's engorged 48-team finals. Unlike in previous iterations, FIFA are also rewarding clubs that released players for qualifiers, too, with \$100m allocated there. The remaining \$5m, or whatever is left after administrative costs related to implementing the programme, will "be allocated to the benefit of club football".

The Athletic's calculations cover that primary \$250million tranche of payments and find, just as in 2018 and 2022, Manchester City come out on top. It is estimated their representation at the 2026 finals has earned them \$4.4million (£3.3m).

FIFA pays out on the basis of how many days finals participants are at the competition, with clubs entitled to roughly \$5,000 per day, per player, between the mandatory release date of May 25 and the day after their national team's last match in the competition.

City benefited from six players making it to the World Cup's semifinal last week: Rayan Cherki, Marc Guehi, Nico O'Reilly, John Stones and James Trafford were each present in Miami for penultimate Saturday's third-place play-off between France and England, while Rodri started in Spain's 1-0 win against Argentina in the final last Sunday.

The world's already richest clubs pepper the top of the list—FC Barcelona, second four years ago, are also second this year—which stands to reason given it is their players who are most likely to feature on the world stage.

By reckoning, Man City earned over \$1million more than the next highest-earning English club, Arsenal, though that was impacted by the latter reaching the Champions League final. That took place on May 30, five days after the mandatory release date; clubs playing in cup finals were, quite rightly, allowed to release players later, though that naturally reduced their CBP earnings.

It is reckoned Arsenal's figure would have been almost \$500,000 higher in other circumstances, but of course, they earned much more than that from reaching European club football's showpiece.

It was that found it was not just the usual English suspects high up the



Man City 19 players

list. Crystal Palace, with 12 players at these finals, were the Premier League's third-highest earners (\$2.7million) by The Athletic's calculation; Sunderland, whose players scored eight goals this summer, a mark only four clubs topped, were the sixth-highest in England and 13th-highest overall (\$2.2m).

Premier League clubs contributed

around 13 percent of this summer's 1,248 players, more than any other division in world football and, correspondingly, hoovered up more money than anywhere else. It is estimated the 2026-27 Premier League crop will receive \$34.2million from the CBP, well ahead of the next-highest: Germany's Bundesliga, with \$18.8m.

Yet even as the richest clubs enjoy the largest share of the spoils, the amounts they receive will pale in comparison to the cost of employing the same players who've generated those sums. City's \$4.4million might top everyone else, but it is a fairly paltry sum when set alongside a full club wage bill in 2024-25 of around \$608m (£468m).

In 2018, The Economist found the biggest clubs were significantly underpaid by the CBP relative to the cost of employing players over the time they were away at the World Cup.

The Athletic's calculations should serve as a good guide, but are unlikely

Sports

Asia Tops Non-European Earners

CONTINUED FROM P27

to be perfect.

One complicating factor is those instances where players moved clubs during the tournament. Take England winger Anthony Gordon. He completed a move to Barcelona, which was announced on May 29, meaning Newcastle United held his registration for less than a week after the mandatory release date. Thus, The Athletic adjusted allocations for several high-profile transfers during this World Cup, but its figures will not have captured them all.

A further muddying of matters arises from players who did not feature in this World Cup but were intended to. Players initially released but then replaced, usually by injury, will generate money for the clubs, as will their replacements. Arsenal's Jurrien Timber, replaced by RB Leipzig's Lutsharel Geertruida in the Netherlands' squad, was one such instance. Again, The Athletic adjusted wherever possible but, with fees paid out based on dates and it not always clear when a player was replaced, there's every chance our estimate isn't 100 percent accurate. And, of course, there's that \$100million qualifying pot.

As mentioned, FIFA has introduced significant nuance to the programme this time around, rewarding clubs not just for their players' participation in this summer's finals in the United States, Canada and Mexico but also for any player who was selected in a matchday squad for any of the 905 qualifying games that determined the 48 participating teams this June and July. On top of that, clubs of those who were named in squads for the three host countries in their 10 friendlies before this summer's finals will also receive payment.

That translates to 42,320 individual



FC Barcelona players



Arsenal players

allocations to be made across pre-finals games alone, with the \$100million of that \$355m CBP pot apportioned to qualifying participation working out at \$2,362 per player, per match. Due to limitations on available data, The Athletic has not been able to generate a reliable estimate of how that \$100m will be apportioned.

FIFA disclosed a full breakdown of payments following each of the last two World Cups, and is expected to again in 2026. That will, however take some time; clubs have until September 10 to review a preliminary list of relevant players on FIFA's own platform, which must then be reviewed by member-associations by October 31. Thereafter, FIFA will conduct its own review before paying out.

Wherever the full \$355million winds up, it is a safe bet that, just as before, the lion's share will go to European clubs. UEFA teams earned 76 percent of each of the 2018 and 2022 pots, and we project they'll take home the majority of the \$250m allocated on the back of this summer's finals too.

Estimate from The Athletic puts the European's take at 70 percent which, while still far beyond any other confederation, is a noticeable drop from four years ago.

The fall is explained in large part by FIFA's expansion of this summer's tournament to 48 national teams. In comparison to Qatar 2022, just three of this year's extra 16 sides hailed from Europe, meaning 13 were drawn from other confederations, including five from CAF in Africa.

While that doesn't mean individuals for the new entrants all play for club sides in their home nation's confederation, it has brought more clubs

into the fold than previously. We count 451 clubs among those due a payout from this summer, up from 440 in 2022. A total of 175 of the clubs in line for a 2026 CBP payment are from non-UEFA confederations, with the Asian Football Confederation leading the way (73 clubs).

That number will surely grow once the \$100million qualifier pot is divvied up, though so too will the take of the elite clubs, whose players were plenty present in the two-year build-up to this summer's extravaganza.

The scale of the 2026 World Cup and the revenues it has generated meant FIFA had to increase the amounts payable to clubs whose players ultimately produced the product on the pitch. The already rich reap the most, though the thin spreading of payments means the payouts are relatively miserly for the game's elite. Not least when their players have generally had to spend even longer away than usual due to the enlarged tournament, and in often soaring temperatures too.

Europe's big five divisions, as ever, top another monetary list, but there is at least a spread of recipients beyond that. We estimate \$149million of the \$250m finals pot will go to 784 different clubs across 100 different leagues.

For some, even at what look like low levels, the money will make a difference. Braintree Town, currently playing in England's sixth tier, were placed under a transfer embargo as recently as May due to financial troubles, but will be one of the lowest-ranked beneficiaries of this year's CBP payouts. The inclusion of their 36-year-old defender Tommy Smith in the New Zealand squad has generated, we reckon, around \$171,000 (£127,000) for the non-League club.

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Former World No.1 Broke After Husband Betrayed Her Of €52m Fortune



Arantxa Sanchez-Vicario of Spain in action during the Tennis Masters Series in Miami, Florida in 2002

Former tennis World No.1 and Grand Slam winner, Arantxa Sánchez Vicario, has provided new details on how she lost her reported €52 million fortune and was fortunate to escape having to go to prison. Arantxa Sánchez Vicario went on trial in 2023 along with her now-ex husband Josep Santacana accused of hiding assets to avoid paying bank debts. The fraud accusations dated back as far as the early 1990s. Sánchez Vicario, who won four Grand Slam titles during her illustrious career, was handed a two-year suspended jail sentence and ordered to pay back no less than nearly €9 million to a bank in Luxembourg. The Spanish tennis-darling revealed on a Spanish TV show Universo Callejo that she had lost her entire fortune, which she estimated to be about €52 million and blames her former husband for her financial misery. "I trusted him because he was the father of my children," she said. "I fell blindly in love... he really isn't the person I thought he was." "I focused on playing tennis and never handled my own financial affairs because I didn't know how. I trusted my

husband... and the money vanished. I was left to shoulder the entire burden." Arantxa Sánchez Vicario and Josep Santacana were married for 11 years and have two children together. Sánchez Vicario revealed that she avoided going to jail because she accepted the judge's orders to pay 50 per cent of all future earnings towards the massive debt to the bank. "I am complying when deep down I was a victim," she said. "It was a shock. I had to go to therapy because I couldn't believe it. It was like waking up from a dream and thinking, 'This can't be happening to me'." The Spanish tennis star who especially excelled on clay won three French Open titles, the first in 1989 at just 17 years old. Known for her relentless grit, the International Tennis Hall of Fame inductee captured four Grand Slam singles titles, six women's doubles titles, and four mixed doubles titles in total. Caja Mágica, which hosts the Madrid Masters tournament named a court after her in 2002 after her retirement but the name has since been removed. Sánchez Vicario today works as a tennis coach in the USA, and continues to pay half her wages to the debt.

Navratilova's Return, An Olympic Legacy: Remembering Prague's Pivotal 1986 Fed Cup

Stvanice, an island on the river in Prague, has always been a sporting paradise. For many years, it was home to an ice hockey stadium that hosted the World Championship, where the national team won its first gold in 1947, and right next to it, the stands of an iconic tennis arena were built. It was this arena, now the host of the upcoming Livesport Prague Open, that in July of 1986 hosted one of the most memorable tournaments of all time. Let's travel back to a time when Czechoslovakia was still gripped by the Iron Curtain. It was already starting to rust, but some things were still hard to imagine. However, tennis was one of the few areas where you could get a taste of the fresh breeze from the Western world. The communist regime was slowly crumbling, and in three years, the Velvet Revolution would arrive. And the Czech tennis school was celebrating success. In the 1980s, fans were thrilled by the Davis Cup triumph of the men's team, Ivan Lendl was following in the footsteps of Jan Kodes with Grand Slam glory, and Hana Mandlikova was one of the world's top players. In 1985, the nation also won the biggest team competition in women's tennis, then known as the Federation Cup, in Japan, and were to defend their title on home turf a year later. The format at the time was very similar to football's World Cup, with 42 teams of four arriving in Prague to compete for the trophy, and virtually every top female tennis player in the world was there. The crowd admired the divine Argentine Gabriela Sabatini, Bulgaria were led by the performances of the Maleeva sisters, and the main star of the German team was world number three Steffi Graf. The story of the then 17-year-old rising superstar is definitely worth mentioning. Graf had to skip Wim-

bledon due to a mysterious illness, but she wanted to make up for it in Prague and win her country's first team trophy. However, after leading her team through two knockout rounds, she could only watch the quarter-finals from the bench. "Steffi Graf, the best West German tennis player, broke her toe on Thursday when a sun umbrella fell on her foot. She was getting her rackets ready for practice when, in strong winds, the umbrella structure tipped over and the table landed on her foot," reported the Los Angeles Times correspondent from the scene. "X-rays revealed a broken toe on her right foot. It's unclear when she'll be able to play again." The Germans, with substitute Bettina Bunge, managed to edge out the Bulgarians, but in the semi-finals, they couldn't get past the USA. And so, partly due to Graf's bizarre injury, Stvanice got a final that was both a dream and unwanted: Czechoslovakia vs USA. For a rematch of the previous year's



In 1986, Navratilova returned to Prague representing the USA

final in Japan, the American team brought the best they had. The main star was world number one Martina Navratilova, supported by number two Chris Evert, with world number five Pam Shriver ready as backup. And, of course, it was an emotionally charged match-up. Navratilova was returning to her homeland after 11 years in exile, and during those years, the communist regime had tried to erase her name from memory. The media avoided reporting on Grand Slams, and the arrival of the biggest star in tennis was supposed to be kept secret. "I know that our dad, as the head of the association, went to welcome her at the airport. It was raining then, and he waited for her with an umbrella by the plane. Because of everything that was happening here, she had to use a special entrance. I know Martina remembered that someone was always watching her," recalled Helena Sukova, one of the mainstays of the national team, years later. This unique match left the Czechoslovak girls with a bitter-sweet memory. "We tried to focus on our game, but in that final, it was really unpleasant for us. People were cheering for the Americans. Of course, not because they didn't wish us well, but because of Martina," Sukova described. After the singles matches, the result was already decided - the home team had lost both. But the tournament rules had to be fulfilled, so the doubles had to be played as a dead rubber. "When I lost to Chris Evert and Hanka lost to Martina, we didn't want to play the doubles. We said: 'They're not cheering for us anyway, we're not going.' But they talked us into it," the Czech player recalled. Now, with the benefit of hindsight, Sukova sees the match differently: "Looking back at it today, it was simply a tennis celebration."

Tennis Circuit

Why Players Will Need Sex Test To Play On WTA Tour



Tennis is the latest sport to introduce genetic testing for women

The Women's Tennis Association (WTA) is to require all players to undergo genetic sex testing in order to compete on the WTA Tour. In the latest edition of its women's eligibility policy, which came into effect on Tuesday, July 21, players will be required to provide a cheek swab, blood or saliva sample to test for the presence of the SRY gene which is part of the Y chromosome and causes male characteristics to develop.

Players will be tested just once in their lifetime and only a negative result, showing no presence of the gene, will permit them to compete on the Tour. If they test positive, players will face further medical assessment before being allowed to play. The new policy also requires players to sign a document that states they could face disciplinary action if they refuse testing. The WTA's previous policy, last updated in 2024, allowed transgender women to compete on the Tour if they had lowered their testosterone levels to below 2.5 nmol/L continuously for the previous two years. There are no known transgender women currently playing on the WTA Tour. "The WTA's women's eligibility policy is designed to promote equal athletic opportunities in women's professional tennis and maintain fair competition for all players participating in WTA tournaments," the governing body said. "Since first being introduced in 1975, the eligibility policy has undergone periodic review in light of developments across international sport."

Muchova Works On Recovery Ahead US Open

Wimbledon finalist Karolina Muchova is set to be sidelined for a "few weeks" after having a "small surgery". The 29-year-old lost to Czech compatriot Linda Noskova in an extraordinary and dramatic three-set final at the All England Club earlier this month. Muchova, who has dealt with a number of wrist injuries throughout her career, did not specify what the current problem was, nor the exact timeframe for a return. She confirmed she will miss the Canadian Open in Toronto, which starts on August 1, but was working on her recovery, with the US Open taking place from August 23. "I had to undergo a small surgery that will keep me off the court for a few weeks," said Muchova. "Everything went well, and I'm already working on my recovery. Sad



Muchova is ranked sixth in the world

to be missing Toronto this year. I was really looking forward to making my debut there, but recovery comes first." Muchova, who is ranked sixth in the world, suffered her second Grand Slam final defeat at Wimbledon, having also lost the 2023 French Open final to Iga Swiatek.

Kienka Defends Players Selection For Zenith Bank Next Gen Tennis Masters

The 2026 Zenith Bank Next Generation Masters served off at the newly refurbished Mainland Tennis Club at the National Stadium Surulere on Tuesday, July 27 with Director of the International Tennis Academy (ITA) Godwin Kienka defending the selection of players for the championship. The tournament is for the eight players, men and women, who are considered, in the opinion of the International Tennis Academy (ITA), the organisers of the Masters, to have made the most remarkable improvement in transiting to the senior ranks. According to Godwin Kienka, Director of the ITA: "Our selections have been very objective and thorough and the players, men and women, in the top five of our seniors currently, have been winners, runners-up or semi-finalists in the last five years." "Now all the good intermediate players are fighting to be a part of the tournament by doing well at the preceding senior tournaments. They know we prepare them psychologically to do well at the seniors," the director said. Ito Bassey of the GEUF Tennis Academy, Uyo, and Abuja-based Canice Abua, who are dominating at the senior level currently in the women's and men's respectively, were runner-up and winner respectively four years ago.



Kienka

Sports

CAF Appoints Media Experts Limited (MEL) For CAF WAFCON 2026

AYO BADA

Media Experts Limited (MEL), the international sports and entertainment media consultancy has been appointed by the Confederation of African Football (CAF) to Commercialise the Sub-Saharan Africa free-to-air media rights to the TotalEnergies CAF Women's Africa Cup of Nations (WAFCON) Morocco 2026.

The deal covers the free-to-air distribution of Africa's flagship women's football competition across Sub-Saharan Africa, giving MEL the responsibility to market and distribute the licensed free-to-air media rights in accordance with the mandate granted by CAF. It marks a continuation of MEL's relationship with CAF, which has also included work connected to the Confederation's men's Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) properties, and sits alongside MEL's broader portfolio of assignments for global sports and entertainment giants.

According to Kunle Falodun, Founder and CEO of Media Experts Limited, "Women's football in Africa has waited a long time for the recognition it deserves, and momentum is now firmly on its side with record prize money, record crowds, and a new generation of stars the whole continent is proud of. To be entrusted with bringing CAF WAFCON Morocco 2026 to audiences across Sub-Saharan Africa is both an honour and a responsibility. At MEL, we see this as a platform to celebrate the progress

the women's game has made, and the women who have been responsible. It is also an opportunity to bring our broadcast partners and sponsors along with us on this noble mission."

Luxolo September, Head of TV Operations & Communications Director at CAF says; "Free-to-air television remains a cornerstone of CAF's broadcast strategy, ensuring that African football is accessible to millions of fans across the continent. We are delighted to appoint Media Experts Limited (MEL) as the preferred partner for the commercialisation of the TotalEnergies CAF Women's Africa Cup of Nations Morocco 2026 free-to-air rights across Sub-Saharan Africa. This partnership reflects our shared commitment to expanding the reach of women's football, strengthening broadcaster engagement, and bringing the excitement of WAFCON 2026 to audiences in every corner of Africa."

While CAF remains the exclusive owner of all media and commercial rights relating to the TotalEnergies CAF Women's Africa Cup of Nations Morocco 2026, the mandate arrives at a pivotal moment for the women's game in Africa. The most recent edition of WAFCON, hosted in Morocco, delivered a 45 per cent increase in total prize money along with expanded participation payments for competing federations. This is a shift CAF President Dr Patrice Motsepe has linked to the Confederation's long-term commitment to making women's football more competitive and financially sustainable.

Guernsey Boxer Teers Loses On Commonwealths Debut

Guernsey boxer Tommy Teers saw his Commonwealth Games debut end in defeat.

The 28-year-old bantamweight who juggles his boxing training with working as a carpenter - lost on a split decision to Eriu Temakau of Kiribati.

Teers had a point deducted for a low blow in the opening round before improving in the second.

But Temakau won the third round and took the decision 3-1.

"Surprisingly, I feel good - a split decision loss, I think the point deducted away from me in the first round kind of edged it his way, which is boxing,

these things happen," Teers told BBC Guernsey.

"I'm just so happy to be here in these facilities and around all these athletes, it shows me what I've done to get here and I'm just happy, I couldn't really say any more to be fair."

Teers has twice reached the English Elite National semi-finals, but says this bout was likely to be his only fight at a Commonwealth Games for Guernsey.

"I think realistically this is it for me for amateur boxing," he added. "I think I'm more suited to the pros so I think I'm going to try to go pro and see what's out there for me.

AYO BADA

Nigeria's preparations for the Commonwealth Games 2026 in Glasgow, Scotland, which kicked off on Thursday, July 23 have not been without controversy.

In the days leading up to the Games, concerns emerged from within Team Nigeria after

some athletes complained that they were omitted from events they had qualified for, while others were entered into disciplines they had not prepared to compete in.

The complaints prompted calls for the National Sports Commission (NSC) to review

registration procedures with the Athletics Federation of Nigeria (AFN) and ensure affected athletes receive fair treatment before their competitions begin.

Despite those concerns, Nigerian officials remain optimistic that the country's blend of

Glasgow 2026: Team Nigeria Stays On Medal Trail As Oluwafemiayo Breaks World Record

F lashade Oluwafemiayo produced a stunning performance to claim gold medal in the Women's Heavyweight Para Powerlifting event at the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Oluwafemiayo set a new world record, lifting 175kg to amass a total of 134.8 points. Her compatriot Rita Ferdinand lifted 158kg to secure the silver medal.

Remarkably, Ferdinand also surpassed the previous world record, capping a breathtaking Nigerian clean sweep of the top two positions.

Australia's Hani Watson claimed the bronze medal with 111.5kg.

It marks Nigeria's second one-two finish of the day in para powerlifting. Esther Nworgu, and Esther Oyema had earlier claimed gold and silver in the Women's Lightweight event.

Roland Ezuruike won Team Nigeria's first medal of the opening day. He clinched silver medal in the men's lightweight category.



Oluwafemiayo with her gold medal

AYO BADA

The Senior Special Assistant (SSA) to the President on Grassroots Sports Development, Hon. Adeyinka Anthony Adeboye, has congratulated Team Nigeria for its outstanding start at the 2026 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Scotland, describing the opening day performances as a clear testament to the country's abundant sporting talent and the rewards of sustained investment in athlete development.

Hon. Adeboye particularly praised Nigeria's para powerlifting contingent, whose remarkable exploits produced three gold medals, three silver medals, and multiple world records, instantly placing Team Nigeria among the standout nations of the Games.

The Presidential aide said the record-breaking performances by Folashade Oluwafemiayo, Esther Nworgu, Riluan Idris, Esther Oyema, Rita Ferdinand, and Roland Ezuruike have once again demonstrated why Nigeria remains a dominant force in para sports globally.

"The remarkable performances of our athletes on the opening day of the Commonwealth Games have filled every Nigerian with immense pride. They have shown the world that with resilience, discipline, proper preparation, and belief, Nigerian athletes can compete with and defeat the very best on

the global stage."

He described the multiple world records set by Team Nigeria as a reflection of years of sacrifice, dedication, and structured athlete development, noting that such achievements further reinforce Nigeria's reputation as one of the world's leading nations in para powerlifting.

He commended the National Sports Commission (NSC), under the leadership of Chairman Mallam Shehu Dikko and Director General Hon. Bukola Olopade, for creating an enabling environment for athletes to excel through improved welfare, motivation, and strategic planning.

According to the SSA, the Commission's enhanced athlete reward system sends a strong message that excellence, patriotism, and hard work will continue to receive the recognition they deserve.

"When athletes know that their sacrifices are appreciated and their achievements rewarded, they are inspired to give even more. The support being provided by the National Sports Commission reflects a new direction for Nigerian sports under the Renewed

Hope Agenda of President Bola Ahmed Tinubu."

Hon. Adeboye further noted that the success recorded in Glasgow should inspire greater commitment to grassroots sports development across the country.

He explained that every international champion first emerged from a community, a school competition, or a local sporting programme, emphasizing that Nigeria must continue to strengthen talent identification and development from the grassroots to sustain success on the global stage.

"Every medal won today began as a dream in a local community. Every world record started with a young athlete who was given an opportunity to develop. This is why grassroots sports development remains the foundation of our national sports agenda. We must continue to identify, nurture, and support young talents across all 774 Local Government Areas so that Nigeria can consistently produce world champions."

The Presidential aide also commended the fighting spirit displayed by Nigeria's men's

3x3 basketball team, encouraging them to remain focused despite their defeat to Australia after recording the country's historic first Commonwealth Games victory in the event.

He equally urged athletes competing in other sports to draw inspiration from the para powerlifting team's exploits as the Games progress.

"The Commonwealth Games is a marathon, not a sprint. The performances we have witnessed on the opening day should motivate every Nigerian athlete to compete with courage, determination, and the unwavering belief that they can bring honour to our nation. Nigeria is solidly behind Team Nigeria."

Hon. Adeboye expressed confidence that Team Nigeria would continue to build on its impressive start and deliver more memorable performances throughout the Games, reaffirming his office's commitment to supporting initiatives that expand grassroots sports, promote athlete development, and create sustainable pathways for future champions in line with the vision of President Bola Ahmed Tinubu's Renewed Hope Agenda.

Glasgow 2026: Nigeria's Charge For Historic Medal Haul Threaten

registration procedures with the Athletics Federation of Nigeria (AFN) and ensure affected athletes receive fair treatment before their competitions begin.

Despite those concerns, Nigerian officials remain optimistic that the country's blend of

world champions, Paralympic champions and emerging talents can deliver another memorable Commonwealth Games campaign.

Team Nigeria presented a contingent of 74 athletes at the Opening Ceremony, marking a historic number of partici-

pants since we first debuted at the games 76 years in Auckland, New Zealand.

According to a statement from the Special Adviser, Media, National Sports Commission (NSC), Kola Daniel, on Friday, Team Nigeria turned heads as one of the best-dressed dele-

gations and "For the first time EVER at the Commonwealth Games, Para and non-Para athletes entered together."

A powerful statement on equality and inclusion. Team Nigeria was part of that historic moment. It was a night of style, pride, unity, and history."

Tony Eluemunor

Abuja Notes

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Dennis Amachree On Abacha's Death: Bogus Investigation, Scandalous Conclusion



Abacha and Arafat at the Airport

I'll never presume to teach any Department of State Security (DSS) agent how to conduct investigations because they are supposed to be adequately trained. I will be grateful to learn from them. So, the best I can grant from ex-DSS Assistant Director, Mr. Dennis Amachree's bloopers (including mere lapses and terrible blunders) is not to blame his teachers, but to assume that he betrayed them, at least on his conclusion that the late Head of State, General Sani Abacha, died from a heart attack during a tryst with a woman. The gaffes and blunders are contained in the excerpted part of his book, "DSS @40: My Journey Behind the Shield". In case you assumed from the title that he authored a Nigerian version of "Every Spy A Prince: The Complete History of Israel's Intelligence Community" published in 1990, please, hold your peace; this book is Amachree's personal story. His take about how Abacha perished while in bed with a woman is filled with errors any secondary school student would have corrected in no time.

First example: The Vanguard newspaper of July 22, 2026 published that "Amachree recalled that a few days before his death, Abacha received Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat's emissaries and later hosted Pope John Paul II, who appealed for the release of political detainees." Just when I thought that Vanguard must have misrepresented the author, the paper quoted him: "Indeed, the Pope was the last visitor that Gen. Sani Abacha received." These few lines contained three errors: One, BARafat himself, not emissaries, visited. Two, the Pope was not Abacha's last visitor; three, Arafat was Abacha's and the sunset Abacha saw on his way to the Airport was the last he saw on earth because he didn't survive the night.

Why am I picking holes in Amachree's tall tale? Oh, from the Vanguard of July 25 this year comes this: "Amachree said that his decision to write about the incident was informed by a desire to preserve what he believes is an accurate account." Yet, Amachree made little attempt to achieve accuracy. Pope John Paul II (now Saint John Paul II) visited Nigeria on March 23, 1998. But Arafat made a brief, high-level stopover visit to Nigeria on June 7, 1998, meeting with military Head of State, General Sani Abacha, at the Nnamdi Azikiwe International Airport in Abuja. This visit is historically notable as the final public engagement and public appearance of General Abacha, who died less than 24 hours later on June 8, 1998. I just posted "Arafat's visit to Nigeria" on google and that quotation popped up.

So, if Amachree was not sure about such easy items and yet saw no reason to cross-check them, it is easy to understand why he was wrong about weightier matters, such as how Abacha died. For instance, if he had been humble enough to phone the Director of National Operations at the time under reference, Barr Mike Ejiofor, to verify when the Pope visited, he would have avoided his "error". Mr. Ejiofor who is a popular national security analyst then was in charge of the Pope's security and personally took the "Pope's Mobile" back to La-

gos enroute to Rome, after the visit.

Mr. Ejiofor was also in charge of the DSS security matters concerning Gen. Abacha. So, if Amachree had cross-checked the relevant timelines with his superior or such other superiors of his in the DSS, he would have understood the suspicion Nigerian security agencies attributed to Abacha's and Arafat's Airport rendezvous.

Terribly, without his knowing when Abacha hosted Arafat, that is if the Vanguard quoted him correctly, he totally dismissed every version of Abacha's death, saying: "Many accounts were published but few were based on verifiable facts. These range from fictional stories of a poisoned apple from disaffected soldiers to more sensational claims involving foreign intelligence agencies." Then, only the Almighty God knows what came upon Amachree when his hubris level brimmed over, and he went ballistic: "As a security professional who was in the thick of it, I feel compelled to set the record straight and provide the true narrative for posterity." Please, someone should tell Amachree that he couldn't have been in "the thick of it" because he was actually Assistant Director, Travel Control (overseeing Airports, Sea Ports, and Land Borders) and he left the DSS in 1999. So, he handled migration and people on the watch list matters, not Abacha's security.

Even about the single interview he conducted concerning Abacha's death, on which his entire story of Abacha rests, he verified nothing. He wrote: "At roughly 4:05am, the pharmacist" whose sister was Abacha's girlfriend but had left her to spend the night with the General, noticed

It was during the airport formalities that the double-agent tapped the head of his pen repeatedly and dropped some poison on Abacha as he introduced members of Arafat's entourage to Abacha, and he shook their hands.

that Abacha had died, returned to the Abuja Hilton Hotel, and she and her sister escaped to Lagos". Then Amachree interrogated the pharmacist in Lagos, as the DSS Director of Operations in the national headquarters instructed him. "The first thing she said to me was: 'I did not kill him, he died on top of me.'" Then Amachree sent the lady back to Abuja immediately. Finish!

Mr. Amachree's publication is an indictment on the DSS! Any journalist who would base his conclusion on such an unverified tale would be issued a query. What if she smothered him with a pillow or poisoned Abacha but lied that the man died while having illicit sex, or worked for a foreign

secret agency?

Worse still, Amachree who sent the lady back to Abuja for further interrogation said nothing about Abuja's findings. Showing that ignorance could actually be bliss, he rated his unverified conclusion above those of the DSS headquarters' final determination of what killed Abacha. That Amachree never referred to the findings of his DSS head office is his greatest self-indictment.

So, the most charitable one could be to Amachree is to wave off his claim as that of an ill-informed ex-agent who was blissfully ignorant of the concerted efforts at the controlling heights of the DSS, National Intelligence Agency (NIA), Military Intelligence and coordinated by the office of the National Security Adviser (NSA) over Abacha's death. I assume Amachree had no role in the investigations but was contacted to watch the Airports for that lady or some people being investigated. Worst of all for Amachree, he may never have known of the conclusive findings... which I now lay bare here.

Though two women, Filipinos and not Indians, had visited Abacha that night, the informed opinion was that he died after an asthma attack. As he did not plan to stay away from home for long, he did not take his anti-asthma inhaler with him. So just when he was about to leave the girls, he was said to have slumped at the steps, fully clothed, yes, he was certainly fully clothed.

It is almost certain that nothing hanky-panky happened between the late General and the Filipino damsels that fateful night as he had earlier complained that he was rather unwell, and his doctor had plied him with steroids, as usual. That enabled him to leave his sick bed after some sleep, welcomed some visitors, attended to his very last official duty - signing a cheque and giving it to former military officer and Sports Minister, Air Commodore Emeka Omerua, for our national team's South Korea trip. Really, Abacha was very ill with diabetes and liver sclerosis.

Signs of trouble appeared well before Abacha died. On returning from the Airport after seeing off Yasser Arafat, Abacha's health deteriorated and his doctor gave him an injection by 6 P.M and advised Abacha to have a bed rest. He did, but rose up by 9p.m and began to receive guests. His last visitor, the late General Jeremiah Timbut Useni, the then Minister of the Federal Capital Territory, remained with him till about 3.35a.m. So, between that time and the 5 a.m. when Abacha's Chief Security Officer, Major Hamza al-Mustapha (rtd), was informed about Abacha's health emergency, was what Amachree termed a critical unaccounted for period. But he had no way of verifying the story he claimed that the lady told him. And this is tragic for he published the information he wasn't in a position to verify as a fact and so fouled

up Nigeria's institutional memory. Gen. Useni said in the Sunday Vanguard of April 3, 2010, in "How Abacha Died, by Jerry Useni", "May be around 5 A.M or so". Abacha's doctor said so, too, at the Oputa Panel. Soldiers summoned Hamza al-Mustapha to see a dying Abacha, as opposed to a dead one. Al-Mustapha met him alive but gasping for breath and so summoned a doctor. Amachree's Pharmacist told him that Abacha died by 4.05 A.M, and he published it as the truth though he verified nothing. Haba, hubris should have a limit!

There is this hole any journalist would have noticed but it escaped Amachree. Did Amachree, a trained security agent, believe that a soldier guarding Abacha for the night would have, on his own, ordered a car to smuggle Abacha's visitor out of Aso Rock, just because the lady said so? Of what rank would that soldier have been to order a vehicle to take someone out of Aso Rock without going through Abacha's ADC, Security Officer or the like? That would never have been possible when Nigeria had no mobile phone by then. Or, did the soldier abandon his duty post of guarding a Head of State to wake up a driver?

Then, if truly the lady fled, so who informed the soldiers who in turn informed Mustapha that Abacha needed help? Or did the soldiers barge into the room to tell Abacha to get up and go home? This is the question Amachree didn't address. Answer: The female visitors who were with Abacha did. But they were not prostitutes. Those two Filipinos were old time visitors to the presidential villa. They grew up in Kano, a city with a large Asian population.

So, what killed Abacha? Though Abacha was lethally ill, he was pushed off the cliff and into the abyss. Abacha's last public assignment was the airport departure formalities for the late Palestinian leader, Yasser Arafat, in the evening. In Arafat's entourage was a Palestinian, who Nigerian security agencies identified as a double-agent - who was collaborating with the Americans. It was during the airport formalities that the double-agent tapped the head of his pen repeatedly and dropped some poison on Abacha as he introduced members of Arafat's entourage to Abacha, and he shook their hands. A review of the video recording showed the double-agent undoing Abacha - and such video reviews and other security issues were carried out after Abacha's death to determine what killed him. The NIA took that task very seriously because that organization was at war with the global West in its attempt to thwart their numerous efforts to bump Abacha off. But the West succeeded through that man Arafat brought to Nigeria.

Note: Abacha's death details came from my manuscript for a book, "AUDACITY OF HYPOCRISY: 24 Years of Nigerian Leadership from 1999 - 2023."

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Dele Sobowale On The Other Hand

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APC Change In 2014 Turns To Scandalgate In 2026

"In every community, there is a class of people profoundly dangerous to the rest. I don't mean the criminals. For them we have punitive sanctions. I mean the leaders. Invariably, the most dangerous people seek power." – Saul Bellow, 1915-2005. VANGUARD BOOK OF QUOTATIONS, VBQ p 124.

"It was beautiful and simple, as all truly great swindles are." – O' Henry, 1862-1910, VBQ p 239.

Nigerians have been swindled by the most dangerous men to seek power in any country.

The All Progressives Congress, APC, was eventually created from the alliance of four legacy parties – ACN, APGA, CPC, and fragments of PDP – in 2013. But in actual fact, it was the brain child of one man; who formed a partnership with another in a historic visit to Daura, Katsina State. Bola Ahmed Tinubu and Muhammadu Buhari were the founding fathers of APC. When a young man becomes a problem to society, the first question people ask is: who are his parents? To go further into that part of our history, it is necessary to point out that Tinubu never before ran for President; he sponsored eventual losers. Buhari was candidate three times; lost three times and vowed never to contest again – until Tinubu approached him with a convincing winning strategy. A pact was sealed. School is still out on whether that was a marriage "made in heaven" or in the "darkest pit of hell". Time will tell. But we are in 2026 and the heat Nigerians are feeling cannot emanate from the Almighty's abode.

LESSONS FROM A BOSTON SWINDLER

"If it is too good to be true, it probably is a swindle." – Boston Swindler, Jay. 1973.

Millions of people globally, particularly those keen on following major crimes, have heard about the Boston strangler; the man who murdered over 20 women before being apprehended. Few have heard of the Boston Swindler, Jay 2, who made millions duping trusting individuals. Jay 2, had a brother, Jay 1, same mother same father – a Baptist Pastor. Jacob, Jay 1, was as poor as the proverbial church rat. Jason, Jay 2, swam in wealth fraudulently obtained. Jay 2 blamed his victims for being stupid; often wondering how they could believe his stories before handing over their life-savings. Each scam was unique and simple and effective.

Nigerian politicians have perfected the art beyond what Jay 2 could have imagined. The National Assembly, NASS, passed a bill giving financial autonomy to all Local gov-



Bola Tinubu

ernments. The President signs it into law. Most Governors ignore it. Presidency, NASS and over 30 Governors belong to the APC. If there is another name for that, I am ready to have it. Citizens are being swindled by those they elected promising change – without asking if it will be a change for better or worse. Jay 2 lures his preys into believing that their lives would be better by investing in his scams, until it was too late.

WHAT HAS CHANGED SINCE 2015?

"Is APC the answer?" Dele Sobowale, August 2014.

"Alliances are held together by fear; not by love." – Harold Macmillan, 1894-1986. British Prime Minister. VBQ p 9.

Macmillan, for those who might not have read any history, was the one who drew global attention to "the wind of change blowing over Africa" as former colonies gained independence from colonial rule in the 1960s. Today, there is increasing evidence, including right here in Nigeria, that Africans have merely exchanged colonial chains for enslavement by their own people. To be quite candid, we were governed better and more humanely by the British than Fellow Nigerians – even now. The British Prime Minister has no fleet of aircraft at his service. The Nigerian

President, governing a poorer nation, parades eight. That summarises the transformation from white servitude to black enslavement.

Despite being a strong supporter of Buhari since 2010, and knowing that none of the opposition parties could defeat the PDP in 2015, I was an enthusiastic promoter of an alliance to dislodge the ruling party. But, after the dust had cleared and the new party was unveiled, the veils also fell from my eyes. Most of the leaders were the same dubious politicians who have ruled and ruined their states, as well as the Federal Government. The emergence of Buhari, as the flag-bearer provided a measure of hope. "Mr Clean" would very quickly rid the party of political parasites. Buhari, so I thought, would insist on fulfilling the major promises of the party's Manifesto, which being so ambitious, left no room for corruption – given Nigeria's extremely limited resources. I was wrong; dead wrong. Three cardinal promises in the party's Manifesto – health, job creation, and zero tolerance for corruption – are recalled below. After eight years of Buhari and three years and three months of Tinubu, it is clear to what extent Nigerians have been duped.

On health, the party promised to establish one world class teaching

hospital in each of the zones within four years, in order to halt health tourism – which was draining foreign exchange from Nigeria. When campaigning, Buhari routinely criticized Nigerian leaders going abroad for medical services. It was Jay 2 stuff and Nigerians fell for it. In office, he established no single world class teaching hospital; and, during his first term, spent the longest time of any Head of State, military or civilian, abroad. He returned and shamelessly declared: "I have never been so sick in my life". Despite that, no world class hospital was initiated. He availed himself of foreign healthcare several times after that. Serial hypocrisy had never been more openly demonstrated. That was however the mildest of his assaults on our commonwealth.

The promise to create six million new jobs every year – starting the first year – went beyond the customary politicians' promise before elections. The APC must have drafted the best con-men money could buy to draft that portion of the salad bowl of illusions called Manifesto. A half-decent administrator might have at least attempted to redeem the pledge. Buhari, given low educational qualification, didn't even try.

Long before some of his top officials (and I will provide the names soon) were unmasked as the most vicious kleptomaniacs Nigeria had ever seen in government, I got published a series of articles in 2018 titled SAI BABA AND THE HUNDRED POLITICAL RASCALS. That was not my original title. Mine was SAI BABA AND THE FORTY THIEVES. But I was persuaded to water it down to avoid litigation. Before writing it, a whistle-blower in the Ministry of Justice had raised alarm that properties forfeited by individuals to the FG were being misappropriated by top government officials – starting from the Ministry. Two weeks ago, a Federal High Court ordered the forfeiture of 48 properties linked to a top official of the Buhari administration. Need we say more about APC and what became of its vaunted CHANGE Agenda and how it contributed to bringing Nigeria to the brink of bankruptcy? But, unfortunately, there is more.....

NIGERIA'S DEMOCRACY WITHOUT LEGISLATORS AND JUDICIARY – 2

"You cannot adopt politics as a profession and remain honest." – Louis M Howe, 1871-1936.

Permit me to start where I ended last week by bringing back the last paragraph.

THEN CAME TINUBU

"Standing on the foundation emplaced by

the current administration, we shall.." – President Bola Tinubu, RENEWED HOPE Document, p 3.

How anyone can stand on a foundation laid on quicksand and build anything enduring remains a mystery. Tinubu kept his words – including creating a Rubber Stamp NASS.

I took an entire week off in 2022, after receiving my copy of the REDEEMED HOPE Document; lodged myself in a hotel and went through it several times; conducted analysis of data presented, cross-checked facts stated and drew a conclusion. Wait for it.

However, I almost stopped reading after coming across the statement represented above on page 3. It was extremely alarming. How anybody who wished Nigeria well could ignore the overwhelming evidence of ruinous mismanagement of the economy was baffling. More disturbing was the promise to build on that disaster. Granted, Tinubu was stuck between the deep sea and the hard rock; he was confronted with a political dilemma. Tinubu could not openly distance himself from the devastating Buhari-nomics and expect to clinch the ticket. But he should also not have tried to portray the state of the Nigerian economy, under Buhari, as worthy of emulation and continuation. He was not being honest with Nigerians. When the President eventually had the guts to tell the truth about Buhari, it was like most cowards insulting dead majesty. Tinubu waited until it was safe to reveal the truth to Nigerians. By then, his own strategy for NASS-capture was already bearing fruit.

It was beautiful and simple. Nigeria's newly-elected President forced the Senate, the senior chamber, to accept as their president, to accept a senator who had, and still has, a pending case with the EFCC. In one stroke, a symbiotic relationship was formed. The EFCC would bury the case file; and the FG would always be allowed to have its way without question. Agreement soon elided into blackmail: "do what you are told or else..". The office of the Senate President has never had an officer so frequently insulted in the media. On one occasion, the poor fellow was even sent on an errand to represent the President of Nigeria on official State Visit to Lagos State. The contempt is obvious!!!

We are now in the Emilokan era of presidency; under which the subservience of the NASS is total. Nigeria's democracy has taken several rapid steps towards landing in the dustbin of history. Was this the CHANGE we were promised in 2014-5?

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